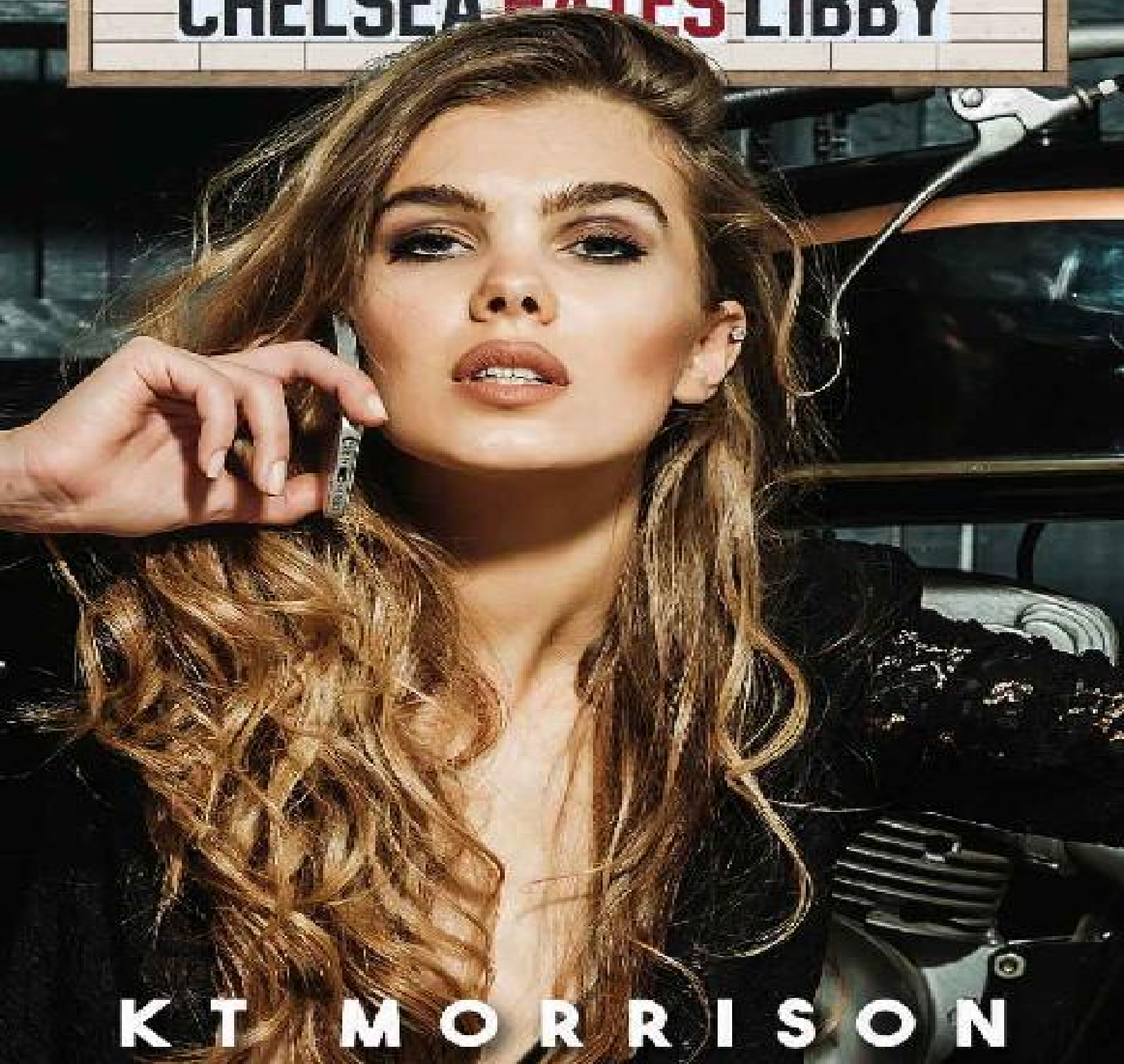


# BACKSTAGE PASS

2 of 3

CHELSEA **HATES** LIBBY



KT MORRISON

# BACKSTAGE PASS

---

CHELSEA HATES LIBBY

KT MORRISON

# CONTENTS

[About the Author](#)

[Also by KT Morrison](#)

## I. [Hot Tub Time Machine](#)

[Chapter 1](#)

[Chapter 2](#)

[Chapter 3](#)

[Chapter 4](#)

[Chapter 5](#)

[Chapter 6](#)

[Chapter 7](#)

[Chapter 8](#)

[Chapter 9](#)

[Chapter 10](#)

## II. [Ragna-Rock](#)

[Chapter 11](#)

[Chapter 12](#)

[Chapter 13](#)

[Chapter 14](#)

[Chapter 15](#)

## III. [Dorchester](#)

[Chapter 16](#)

[Chapter 17](#)

[Chapter 18](#)

[Chapter 19](#)

[Chapter 20](#)

[Chapter 21](#)

[Chapter 22](#)

[Chapter 23](#)

IV. [Shout](#)

[Chapter 24](#)

[Chapter 25](#)

[Chapter 26](#)

[Chapter 27](#)

[Chapter 28](#)

[Chapter 29](#)

[Chapter 30](#)

V. [Home Girl](#)

[Chapter 31](#)

[Chapter 32](#)

[Chapter 33](#)

[Chapter 34](#)

VI. [Half-Truths](#)

[Chapter 35](#)

[Chapter 36](#)

[Chapter 37](#)

VII. [Brand New Day](#)

[Chapter 38](#)

[Chapter 39](#)

[Chapter 40](#)

[Chapter 41](#)

[Chapter 42](#)

[Chapter 43](#)

[Chapter 44](#)

VIII. [Chaos](#)

[Chapter 45](#)

[Chapter 46](#)

[Afterword](#)

## ABOUT THE AUTHOR

KT Morrison writes stories about women who fall in love with sexy men who aren't their husband, and loving relationships that go too far—couples who open a mysterious door, then struggle to get it closed as trouble pushes through the threshold.

*Visit My Website!*

[ktmorrison.com](http://ktmorrison.com)

# ALSO BY KT MORRISON

## **SERIES**

*Landlord*

*Obsessed*

*The Cayman Proxy*

*Separate Schools*

*Keely*

*Six Weeks In Winter*

## **EPIC NOVELS**

*Cherry Blossoms*

*Maggie*

*Learning Lessons*

*Happy Endings*

## **NOVELS**

*Going A Little Too Far*

*Pool Party*

*Après Ski*

*Rachel's Truth*

## **NOVELLAS**

*Watching Natalie Cheat*

*Watching Natalie Again*

*Inconceivable*

*Mary's Pledge*

*One Night Only (as Becky Haze)*

## **ANTHOLOGIES**

*The Taken Anthology*

This is a work of fiction. Similarities to real people, places, or events are entirely coincidental.

Models on cover are meant for illustrative purposes only.

All characters are over the age of eighteen.

This book takes place in Canada where recreational use of cannabis is legal.

## **BACKSTAGE PASS**

### **A Chelsea Hates Libby Serial Novella**

#### **Chelsea Hates Libby #2 of 3**

*42,500 words*

First Edition. May 30, 2019.

Copyright © 2019 KT Morrison

Written by KT Morrison

Cover by KT Morrison



# PART 1

# HOT TUB TIME MACHINE

TUESDAY, JULY 2

THE ENORMITY OF HIS GUILT—ITS sheer abundance—weighed like a tangible force across his shoulders. He carried the hurt in his face too. He could read it in his own expression, standing in the front hallway now with his hands on the dresser studying his sallow face in the mirror. The bags under his eyes weren't imaginary. A fingertip pressed to the pad under each eye's lid blanched a sickly moon that slowly returned dark again.

Last Saturday evening was spent doing the stuff of teenage fantasies. He was a selfish son of a bitch if there ever was one. Indulging himself like that, knowing there was a price to pay. Didn't he care about Libby? Didn't he love her? He did. More than anything.

Then why would he betray her?

"Any minute now," Libby called down, coming to the top of the stairs before darting back into their bathroom again.

"That's my line," he shouted back, lifting his tone with good humor. Putting on the act. Heavy as his heart was, he wouldn't let Libby know. *What's wrong, Ben? What's hurting you?...* And he had no resolve; he'd be blubbering the truth to her in a moment. Gushing his hurt, flushing his pain and anguish to her, forever damaging her heart, her trust. And she would leave him...

He shouted up the stairwell: "I'm going to have a nap on the couch, wake me when you come down." The mock laughter held up his voice again in a charade of glee.

"Ha, ha," Libby pronounced, still in the bathroom.

Now he put his back to the hallway wall, hands in the pockets of his shorts, head back and resting, chin turned up, waiting to see his sweet and

innocent wife come down.

There was a dinner tonight for four at the home of their old friend Chelsea. Just a sit down with their new neighbors, one of whom they grew up with. Nothing out of the ordinary. Until you looked under the hood. There was a devious engine humming under there. It rumbled and roared, and who knew what fuel it burned, but it just might take them to the glorious destination of absolution. It was costly. If Finn could somehow cast a magic spell over his bashful and demure wife, the next step toward Ben's salvation was infidelity. On his wife's part. Libby would have to surrender herself to another man. Would that save him? It was such a crazy gamble.

It was moot. *It is moot! Moot!* he shouted to himself. There was no way Libby would fall for any charm that Finn had. Libby wasn't like that. The idea that Finn could encourage her out of the path of their marriage was crazy. It would never happen.

And when Libby didn't do it, he would have to tell her the truth. He couldn't carry this weight much longer. His legs weren't strong enough. Those legs were strong enough—and stupid enough—to carry him down the street last weekend so he could cheat his way into this awful position...

Upstairs, he could hear lights being flicked off and the fabric sounds of his wife swishing about in a hurry. Libby wasn't one to dawdle in the bathroom. Not like most women he knew, Libby was quick and efficient in her ablutions. She didn't wear makeup, she kept her hair conservatively cut and easy to maintain. No perfume except for her Secret baby powder deodorant. Her jewelry was sedate. Wedding ring and engagement ring. One ring on the middle of her other finger that was a gift for her graduation from her grandparents. Small, almost unnoticeable gold studs in her ears. That was Libby. But ever since Chelsea had come around, it seemed to conjure up some more of that high school unsureness in his wife. Wearing the lipstick the other day. Not even confident enough to pull it off...

"Coming, coming, coming," Libby called out as footsteps came to the stairs again. She was revealed to him in descension: first her ankles and calves, then her knees, up her thighs as she bounced down the steps. The first thing that struck him was the sway of her bosom. Libby wore tight and restrictive—sensible—undergarments. Her bra sets came with protective straps and cups that kept all her lady equipment tucked into place. But she wasn't going braless. The only thing that could come to him was that she had bought a new bra. That thought was overtaken as he saw his wife come

down with a new haircut, lipstick, and a smoky eye. It befuddled him. “What is...?”

She hopped down with her bare feet on the hallway floor, came close and hip checked him so she could lean her back on the wall beside him. “What’s what?”

“You look beautiful.”

She tried to purse her lips and he could see her physically restrain herself from doing it, her eyes turning up so her mouth could soften—Lib reminding herself not to muss her lipstick. Now her elastic brow curved up in question. “Is it okay?”

“Your makeup...?”

“Is it?” Her voice was a whisper.

“You’re always beautiful, Libby. But right now you are *unbelievable*...”

The stiffness melted out of her neck and shoulders, and those lips that had wanted to purse to a slim line pulled to a smile now. “I’m so embarrassed,” she said.

“Because you’re wearing makeup?”

“Getting made up is weird,” she said, putting one forearm across to clutch her opposite arm, covering her breasts.

“It’s Chelsea?”

“Is what Chelsea?”

“Why you wanted to start trying makeup?”

“I guess,” she said, eyes sinking down to the right.

“You know you’re ten times more beautiful,” he said, turning to face her, touching her hand where it crossed over her upper arm.

She smiled, but couldn’t look at him still. He just watched her pretty profile, cute little upturned nose and the way the crimson on her lips strengthened their plump curl.

“Really beautiful,” he said.

She smirked. “You’re going too far,” she said.

“I mean it,” he said, tugging on her arm so she would face him. He made to move closer like he would kiss her.

She put up a hand between them, said, “Don’t. I’m wearing lipstick.”

“See why I like you *without* lipstick?” he said in mock reproach as he stood now and folded his arms, looking up and down her body.

She rolled her eyes and smiled bashfully. “Which shoes should I wear?” she said, looking down and wriggling toes for both of them.

“We’re just going to Chelsea’s for dinner, what are you thinking—heels?”

“What heels do I own, Ben?”

“I don’t know, maybe you’ve been out shopping? Didn’t you buy a new bra...?”

Now she crossed the other arm over her chest. “How can you tell?”

“I can just tell,” he said, smiling.

She looked cross. “It’s *under* my clothes,” she said with a curious sneer.

“I know everything about you,” he told her, dipping in for a kiss but this time descending to plant it on the curve of her soft, fair shoulder. She patted his cheek as he stood and was surprised to see the hump of a nipple against her turquoise blouse. His eyes darted away before she caught him looking. The mortification would have sent her dashing upstairs to put on a sweatshirt.

AFTER THEY WALKED through their lively beach neighborhood, they were greeted at the Slades' door by Chelsea. With a tea towel in her hands, she leaned one shoulder against the door jamb and gave them a big smile. She wore a flirty white tank top and jean shorts that were cut higher than Libby would ever wear.

"Well, if it isn't the Todds," she said, "perfect timing, come on in..."

Ben ushered Libby ahead of him, and she stepped in the foyer. She gave the cordial head-winding-a-crescent, admiring the place, saying, "I love your home."

Chelsea said, "Aw, thanks, Lib, we're not quite as lived in yet as we'd like, it takes some time—I'm sure you know... Take off your shoes, guys, come to the kitchen and we'll go out back..."

Libby pried off the canvas sling-backs she'd chosen, and he kicked off his moccasins.

Chelsea's back was to them, and Libby turned to say something secretly to him, her face bright, her eyes shifted to the right, her open mouth preparing to whisper something to him. That was when Finn appeared in the archway from the kitchen, saying, "Look at this... Ben and *Libby*..."

Libby jolted and whipped around to see him. And there, Ben witnessed his wife's face brighten in an alarming way. The plump curl of her smiling lips, the happy sparkle in her eye... It hit him hard and fast. The makeup she wore was for Finn...

Not for Chelsea at all. Shows how well he knew girls. Here he was thinking Lib was intimidated by their confident and aggressive female

friend, but the whole time maybe Finn was right when he told Chelsea: Libby has a crush on me...

The undulating wave that hit him next was surprising. It made his knees dip. The wave lifted and raised him up in a swell where he could see everything then dipped him low, making his stomach sink and showing him nothing but black. A burst of happiness, a joy that he would be saved; *maybe Libby did have a crush on Finn, maybe this crazy thing could work*; then pushing him higher, showing him and his wife revived, renewed, maybe embarking on a more sexual lifestyle than he ever bargained for; then pushing him down deep, showing him the truth... Libby would have sex with another man. The intimacy he shared would be dashed on the rocks. *She'd only ever been with one man, and that was you*. Then it would no longer be. And worse still, yet somehow equally classifiable in the golden-hued sunshine wave-crest: Libby's face as she shared intimacy with a man that wasn't him... Libby on her back, her familiar legs locked around the hips of someone they hardly knew. *What would Finn do to Libby?*

A turgid arousal sank his underwear, and he tilted his pelvis forward before his bulge would show. Starry black bewilderment twirled behind his eyes like a disco ball's glittering reflection. He hated it; he loved it; he would kill to prevent it; he would die to have it; he deserved it; he deserved punishment; he would enjoy it...

Now he put a hand on his hip and couldn't hide a look of pain on his face. Anyone seeing him would recognize a patient entering the first stages of appendicitis. But all *his* pain was psychic. *But was it pain?* He was instantly twofold—*torn* in two; the urge to grab Libby's wrist and march her out of here took hold... He would shove her down on the couch in their living room and bare his soul to her. He would supplicate at her feet and beg forgiveness. He would renew himself to her, pledge his ever-dying love and he would mean it. Then there was another Ben who loved her equally as the one who would show her the truth, only this one carefully cradled her in his arms as he marched her to the edge of a volcano where he would cast his young virgin sacrifice as a sacrament and pledge to the gods that ruled him. He would die a thousand deaths for sacrificing someone he loved in this way, but the gods' boon and fortune would be received in heavenly glory, and ultimately he would be rebuilt alongside her...

“—what's your problem?”



It was Chelsea, close to him, rubbing her hands to dry them inside the tea towel, eyeing him sly and sidelong. He fidgeted with his belt, looked around now, realizing he'd been in a fog. It was just him and Chelsea in the hall, but he could see Finn and Libby with their backs to them walking through the kitchen.

Chelsea said, "You look a little woozy."

"I am," he said, brushing at his shirt front. His eyes were unfocused, but aimed toward his wife and his friend's husband in the kitchen together.

"Something tells me you thought you *saw* something," Chelsea said now.

"No," he murmured.

Now Finn and Libby emerged in the dining room by the doors that led out to the deck.

Chelsea shouted, "Why don't you give Lib a tour of the place first, Finn."

"Yeah," Finn said, putting his hands in the pockets of his fleecy shorts. He wore a black concert T-shirt, Gothic letters of a band Ben had never heard of across the front. The sleeves had been cut off and you could see the divot of where his pronounced shoulder muscles curved to meet his biceps.

"Sure, so, Lib, you got a nickel?"

Libby looked confused. "A nickel?"

Finn laughed and stroked her arm. "It's the nickel tour, Libby. I need the nickel..."

Finn's hand touching Libby's skin was like a static shock in Ben's psyche. Though he stayed standing, inside he crumpled.

Now Libby patted at her skirt pockets, miming the quest for a nickel. "No nickel," she said.

"This one's on me," Finn said and laughed. Libby laughed too. Finn held out his hand to her and said, "But now you owe me..."

Libby gave Finn one of her quirky *You're going to get it* faces, then slapped her little palm in Finn's. Finn's fingers closed around hers, and he led her through the living room. As they passed, Libby said, "You coming, Ben?"

"You're already familiar with the place," Chelsea whispered and his face pinched into a harrow. Libby didn't catch it, looking around behind her now as they passed, waiting for an answer from him.

Chelsea said, “Ben gave me the tour of your place, now it’s your turn,” and she waved them off with the back of her hand. Finn led her upstairs...

ON CHELSEA'S BACK DECK, just the two of them standing by the glass patio table, Ben's eyes wouldn't come away from the black maw of the open sliding glass doors, waiting to see two figures loom in the kitchen; Finn and Libby. To Chelsea now, he said, "They're up there so long, how big is your second-floor?"

Chelsea laughed, forearm muscles flexing as she twisted the corkscrew out of a bottle of red wine. "Relax, Ben. Maybe it's good news."

"What's good news?"

"Maybe it's done. Maybe Finn is zipping up right now and Libby's—"

"Don't say that," he hissed.

Chelsea laughed again and emptied the bottle into four glasses sparkling in the fading sunlight. "Could you *imagine*? All these years, Libby Sanders *was* that kind of girl after all..."

"She's not."

"They're up there so long, Ben. There's like two rooms, for sure they're doing it right now."

He muttered remonstrations, thrust fists into his pockets, marched around behind her, leaning on the deck railing so he could peer into the house better. Without sunlight in his eyes now he could see the interior of the kitchen. No one. "They're still upstairs," he murmured.

"Looks like you're safe, then, my friend. You got what you wanted."

"This isn't what I wanted."

"Well, run up there, grab my husband off your poor sweet and innocent wife..."

“I would... Except there’s no way that that’s happening up there, you’re just being an asshole.”

Chelsea snorted laughter into the bowl of her wine glass as she tipped it up to take her first sip. Her eyes never left him, narrow slits watching him as she drank. She savored the wine, swirled the glass then set it down. “Just think, Ben, this all works out, maybe while they’re up there it’s you and me on the couch. We can take off where we left off...”

He wanted to condemn her, spit disgust and defend his wife’s honor with a renewed appreciation of his own. Only no words came. He hunched his shoulders up, flexed his back muscles, his brow lowered angrily.

Chelsea came to stand beside him, peering into the kitchen. She said, “Who knows, maybe we can do it tonight. I think they might be on round two...”

“Look, there’s no way.”

“I sure saw old Lib’s eyes light up when Finn came in the room.”

He grumbled.

“What was that?”

He shook his head no. He could see Chelsea smiling wide in his periphery. “Aren’t your steaks going to burn?”

“Don’t worry, Finn’s the chef around here. If there’s one thing that *will* pull him off your sexy little wife, it’ll be tending to his meat.” The dirty phrase hung in the air, and he grumbled again. Chelsea tittered quietly, said, “Right now it’s your wife that’s tending *his* meat...”

A ball of surprising energy swirled up in the center of his core. Lust and anger, and the image came to him now of him twisting at the hips, somehow having his glass of wine in his hand and dashing it into Chelsea’s face at the offense of her words. But then he heard laughter from the front of the house, could see movement in the narrow dim gap of the archway where the kitchen met the front hall. Then Libby and Finn were there, coming into the light. Finn spun around and opened the fridge, stuck his rump out as he dipped his head inside, bottles clattering. Libby stood at his side, putting one foot over the other nervously, hand on her hip, eyes lowered—and he swore to God she was checking out Finn’s ass.

Finn pulled out two cold ones and set them on the counter; Libby came to join him, putting her elbows on the island and watching his hands work. He had large hands, tattooed and capable ones, and his wedding ring clinked on the glass as he spun the two twist-tops off and Libby took the

bottle that was hers. They clinked necks, then took swigs of beer with their eyes watching each other. Libby tilted forward, as if preventing a laugh, covering her fingers over her mouth. She shook her head no, and he could hear Finn's deep voice saying, "No?"

Libby turned up her nose and shook her head to affirm her response. She didn't like his beer selection.

Finn laughed, tilted his bottle up and imbibed more. Libby watched his Adam's apple work.

Chelsea murmured, "Should I get the garden hose?"

"Shut up," he muttered out of the side of his mouth to Chelsea who'd sidled alongside him with her wineglass held up. They were watching Finn and Libby joke around with each other, talking close, Libby's chin turned up, her eyes not leaving this other man.

"She's in heat, Ben, I swear, let me get the hose..."

"Even if she is, I don't think I want this..."

"You can always say no... You can always change your mind..."

FINN WAS QUITE THE CHEF. Served at their patio table from Finn's wood-fired grill: four moose steaks in a maple glaze, and scallops wrapped in bacon. He'd also made a salad of shoots and greens and dried apricots with lemon and poppyseed dressing. It was unexpected given his appearance. Ben would have expected Chelsea to have done the meal preparation so her rock music husband wouldn't embarrass her by serving Jack Daniels and cigarettes and some Kraft Dinner with chopped up hot dogs. It inspired Libby to say admiringly: "Wow, a real renaissance man," and it provoked a long-lasting irritated rumble in Ben's belly while he ate the scallops.

Three bottles of wine were drained between the four of them. The weather was perfect. The sun a golden orange hue that deepened while they finished their drinks. Slowly the night turned blue. The porch lights came on by timer.

And a steady hum and percolation coming from the hot tub made Ben's stomach tighten.

CHELSEA TOOK him under the arm and led him from the kitchen where the four of them were talking. The conversation had switched to music now, Libby saying how excited she was about seeing Dorchester. Once she got talking, telling Finn all about the last time they'd gone to see the band—which must've been 2007—Chelsea brought Ben into the living room, whispering, "Leave them alone for a little bit."

They made their way to the couch, flopped in it together, Chelsea curling up next to him, twisting at the hips and slinking one knee up her thigh until it touched his hip. With her elbow on the back of the couch, she eyed him closely. He broke first. "What?..."

"What do you think now?"

"Do I think she would go for it?"

"Do you?"

"There's no way. I mean, I know how it looks..." He glanced over his shoulder toward the archway into the kitchen, but Chelsea led his chin back with the point of her finger. "Let them be..."

"I don't want it."

"What about your guilt?"

He shrugged, sunk heavily into the couch seat. Chelsea stroked his cheek. Her eyes looked down on him like he was a curiosity. He said, "Do you think if Libby slept with him, she would forgive me?"

She withdrew her hand, thought about it a moment. "It was *my* suggestion, Ben."

"But you're a woman... and as a woman...?"

"I'm not like Libby, Ben, that's why you're in this position."

He hummed an affirmative sound then groaned. He folded his arms over his chest, bit the inside of his cheek. From inside the kitchen, he heard Libby giggle.

Chelsea looked in the kitchen, said to him, "I tell you what, Ben, I think Finn's right."

He sighed. "There's no way..."

"Maybe not. But it looks a lot more likely than it did a few days ago, you couldn't argue with me on that one."

It was true, this experience had been completely unexpected.

Now Libby was trotting in, bright eyed and rosy cheeked, smiling so she showed her teeth; she came directly to the couch, and he lifted his knees protectively. She grabbed at his wrists. *How many glasses of wine had she had?*

She said, "Come on, Ben. Show me how you dance..."

"I don't dance," he insisted.

Libby pouted playfully in a way that poked at his heart and wound up a strange curiosity. She said, "We're going out, don't be a poop..."

"Don't be a poop, Ben," Chelsea purred near his ear.

"Come on, *please*," she pleaded, even pooching out her lower lip childishly.

This was a test. This was a test and he could see it very clearly now. In small increments, maybe he could warm up to doing this thing they were proposing. They'd said they would stop if he requested...

He prepared himself, examined the words in his mouth, studied them like they provided meaning from the heavens. Then he uttered them.

"You go on and dance with him, I know you want to. Go have fun with Finn..."

The words hung in the air, pregnant with dread. He could see them, wished to snatch them, swipe his hands through their fluttering butterflies and gather them again into a protective basket. Stuff them all back in there and get the lid closed.

"You're not going to come out?" Libby said and pouted again.

Behind her, Finn stood by the patio deck, saying, "Isn't somebody, *anybody*, going to come out and dance?"

"I'm coming," Libby said, eyeing Ben with her mouth twisted to one side. It was there. He could see it. Maybe it was his imagination, maybe



everything he saw in her eyes was conjured up by his own beliefs and had nothing to do with his wife's truth. But he swore he could see it now.

Something under his stomach pulled tight like a string, getting it jittering, the tension in it singing out in desperation. It was going to snap. He shifted uncomfortably where he sat, grimacing with a look he tried to pass off as gastric distress from eating too much of Finn's delicious dinner. But the hurt wasn't in his stomach. It was below there. A sexual spot, a primal walnut, and, like a leaky faucet, the purest bad juju dripped from his brain like black molasses over his swelling testicles. "Go on, Libby, I like to watch you dance..."

The words were cold and distant. A robot's voice on an answering machine. *It wasn't him who'd said it... surely it wasn't him...*

THE MUSIC GOT TURNED UP, and Ben was treated to flashes of either Finn or Libby bouncing into view, spinning, shaking their hips.

Chelsea asked him if Libby liked to go dancing and he told her she never went out. Chelsea said it sure looks like she'd have a good time. He told her he just didn't like to dance. Chelsea asked if Libby ever requested they go out. Not to dance, no, he told her, she never asks. Chelsea stroked her fingernails on his forearm. "Don't fret," she said.

"It's my own fault," he said.

"I just can't believe you keep thinking this is a negative somehow."

"Don't make me go through it again."

"Don't make *me* go through it," she said.

He turned to regard her, curled up like a cat on the couch next to him. "So you just let Finn fuck groupies?"

"He doesn't anymore. Not now that we're married. But if he did, he would tell me. There's a singer that he hooks up with whenever she comes through Toronto."

"Who?"

Chelsea ran an imaginary zipper over her closed mouth. Then she hummed a tune in her throat, but he didn't recognize it. "Finn just has a way with women," she said then, and shrugged.

It was true. Every time he saw Libby twirl into view, her eyes were seeking Finn or already locked on him. Her mouth was peeled in a perpetual smile. Her cheeks were rosy and bright in the lantern's light...

AFTER A LONG DANCE SESSION, someone out there turned the music down. As the music faded, Libby's laughter was bright over top of it. Lib and Finn were saying something in rushed and hurried tones, something funny to each other, laughing again. Then it was just the two of them talking. Chelsea was saying, "...that's why I always—"

He shushed her. She laughed.

It was Finn's low voice, then Libby's. They were moving deeper onto the deck, maybe toward the railing where it dropped off to the garden below where the hot tub was. A tragic thought struck up through him like a spear: rushing out there to find Finn and his wife naked in the hot tub, the lit up bubbles camouflaging the movements below the water's surface...

It actually had him moving forward, looking to climb out of the seat. But now he could see them. Or at least see all of Libby, and a quarter of Finn. Their backs were to him, and they were indeed leaning over the railing, standing side-by-side. Libby was watching what Finn was doing, but his hands were hidden from Ben.

Chelsea asked: "What are they doing?"

"I don't know," he said. Then there was a tuft of smoke that flashed in the lantern's shine before disappearing into the night again. Smoking.

But his eyes tracked sideways now, seeking Finn's face. Then into the frame of the open door, he could see Finn passing something toward Libby. It was bulbous, with a stem, and glimmered like it was liquid. Libby smiled tentatively, eyes watching what was presented to her. Her own hand came up, and the item was passed into it. Ben knew what it was now. A glass bubbler, a handheld one. A marijuana pipe.

Libby turned it over, studying it from side to side, running a sheet of hair behind an ear. She asked Finn something, nodded when he answered. She swapped hands, then took a lighter from him.

Now Ben watched as his perfect track record wife—a hundred percent attendance at school, straight-A student, never drank until she was in college, and had never ever done a drug in her entire life—put the pipe to her lips. She flicked the lighter, and Ben could see the chamber fill, blotting out with pure white smoke. Libby inhaled it and held. She crossed both wrists over her mouth, items clumsily held in her small hands, her eyes squinted shut. Finn's hand came into view, caressed her shoulder and rubbed her arm. Libby turned her back, coughed and blurted into the starlight. A puff of smoke slashed away from her sideways in the brisk summer night breeze. She coughed, and Finn rubbed her back.

When she turned, her face was redder, her eyes glassy, and the smile stretched to its limit. She passed both items back to Finn who took them, while she twisted knuckles into her eye sockets like a crying child. Then they were both laughing, and they exited stage right where Ben couldn't see them.

WHEN FINN and Libby came back in the house from the deck, Lib came right to him, saying, "Why are you two still inside? It's so nice out there..."

He said, "We were just talking," looking up at her and smiling wanly.

Chelsea said to Lib, "Look at that smile on your face..."

Libby blushed on her already red cheeks, covered her face with her hands and said, "Am I smiling?" into the cup of her palms.

"Someone looks very happy," Chelsea said.

Libby backed herself to the couch next to theirs, scooped her skirt underneath her knees and plopped down. Finn was coming in, taking a swig from his beer bottle then sliding the glass door shut. Libby said to Ben, "You should come out dancing with me," kicking a foot out and pointing at him with her toes. She looked playful and happy and he loved to see it.

Finn came around the couch, and since it was Ben and Chelsea together, Libby all alone on the other couch, it made sense for him to drop himself down next to her. He threw an arm over the back of the couch, slunk into it like his arm was around Libby. Libby didn't jump away or even dip her head forward. She still smiled dumbly, lifted her shoulders a little then dropped them again, as if she didn't notice Finn's close proximity. Or mind it. She even leaned toward him a little, turning her face toward his and saying, "They're party poopers."

Finn said, "Chelsea's not much of a dancer, either."

"I do alright," Chelsea said, "but Libby can take my place at *all* the dances..."

Libby raised her hand as if volunteering, saying in a cute voice, "I'll do it." She giggled, and Finn took the opportunity to grip her shoulder with his

big hand, his arm full around her now, his tattooed fingers curling around the soft curve of Libby's shoulder, her tank top strap swishing and revealing the color of her brand-new bra. Pastel pink.

Now Libby pointed with both feet, aiming her toes at Ben and Chelsea, saying, "What were you guys talking about?"

Ben's mouth opened as his brain floundered for a falsehood, but Chelsea was quick, shooting from the hip and saying, "Bad news, I'm afraid..."

Libby looked puzzled. She put her feet down, hands clasped between her knees. "Oh no, something's wrong?"

Chelsea said, "Shoot, I guess it's not for me to say. Sorry, Ben..."

Ben looked to see Chelsea watching him. He frowned.

Libby said, "What's wrong, Ben?"

"I..."

Chelsea patted his arm, said, "I'll say it since I started it. It's about the Ragna-Rock Festival... about *Dorchester*..."

"What about them?" Libby said hesitantly, her voice tinged with worry.

"Ben can't make it. He's got to be out of town... That boat..."

He threw his palms up as if to say *What are you going to do?* His heart pounded in his ears. *What the fuck was this?*

Libby's happy expression collapsed. "Oh, no," she whined, "Ben?..."

"I can't, Lib, that boat... It's like going to be twenty percent of my income this year."

"But Dorchester..." She pouted.

"You can still go," Finn said.

Libby said, "When do you have to be away?" Her beautiful eyes were still fixed on him.

"Friday and Saturday, both days, I got to head around the lake and meet with the guy who's going to sail the boat." *Not bad.*

"But why that weekend?"

"The guy I got, Lib. I'm beholden to *his* schedule. I wish there was a whole list of guys I could get to do this for me, but there's only one guy... At least who can do it when I need it done."

"Shoot, Ben," Lib said, brow dipping and her mouth turning down in a sullen bow.

Finn said again, "You can *still* go."

"I'm not going alone," she said.

Finn said, "I'll be there. Come with me..."

Libby's face showed the interior dilemma. It was something she *couldn't* do. She couldn't go off with another man to a show. She wanted to. She wanted to see Dorchester, had been *told* she was going to see Dorchester, and gosh, darn it, she really, *really* wanted to. And then maybe something a little more base... Maybe something inside her head a little more feminine and primal. *I want to go... I want to go with Finn... I want temptation... I want to feel that challenge inside me... I want to feel like a woman...*

Fear burned in Ben's chest and he rubbed at his shirt. He said, "You could do that if you want, Lib."

"I can't... that's so nice, but you..."

"You're absolutely going to come with me," Finn said, engaging her, pumping her up, saying, "Dorchester, come on now, Dorchester..."

It got her smiling, but it still looked as if there was no way she was going to go, it showed in her face. She turned back to Ben, raising her eyebrows with the hope of the possibility, she said, "I *can't* go..." Then darting back to look at Finn, she added, "You're working, anyway... I'd be alone..."

Chelsea said, "Really wish I could go, but I'm away in Ottawa that weekend. I'd chum with you, Lib..."

"Let's totally do this," Finn said. "My work will be done already. I don't work the show, I got guys that do that, and, shoot, the venue has their own team, too. I do the set up, and then I hang out for consultation. I'll be on call, but mostly just hanging out, watching the show. I was going to hang with you guys..." He gestured towards Ben now too.

"What do you say, Lib," Ben said, not believing the words were even coming out of his mouth.

Libby looked on the verge of laughing, and her eyes went up and to the right as she considered it. She said, "I don't know," then hummed as she pondered.

*It was going to happen.*

Finn said, "This is a great idea,—we'll have fun... Ben, it's a good idea, right?"

"Yeah, Lib, you really wanted to go, I don't want to be the jerk that means you have to miss out on your favorite band."

"I wanted to see them with you," she said.

“It’s not going to work out, though, baby—but *you* should go.”

“That’s crazy,” she said, looking to Finn.

Ben said, “I already booked a room,” then realized he’d booked it with Finn through email, Finn saying to get the room that adjoined his suite. *Had this been planned all along without him?*

She said, “You can still cancel it...”

“But it’s there,” he said. “Just go with Finn, go hang out with him and go see Dorchester, you’ll have fun.”

Finn said, “You don’t *want* to go with me?”

“Hey,” she laughed and collapsed against him, bumping him with her shoulder before sitting up again. “It’s not that at all.”

“Don’t be shy, Lib,” Ben said, and it made her flash him a sort of mean look.

She said, “I’m not shy...”

“I don’t mean *shy*,” he said, backpedaling, and now the moment hung strange in the air.

Finn said, “Hey, it’ll be fun. Seriously, you’ll be backstage with me. You want to meet the band? I’ll be in and out of the dressing rooms and everything, come meet them, don’t you want to do that?”

Libby nodded. “That’d be cool.”

Finn said, “And our hotel rooms are side-by-side. So I’ll be right there. You won’t be alone...”



FROM THE CLOSET DOORWAY, Ben watched his wife. At first he thought she hadn't heard him coming because she didn't acknowledge him. When her shirt came off, she paused to look over her shoulder and asked, "Are you watching me again?"

"Busted," he admitted, giving a brief snort.

"Don't watch me, Ben," she said, and despite her protest, he detected a certain purr in her voice; a tiny signal from his wife that in his long time with her he'd become sensitively attuned to because it could mean his wife was in the mood. Libby wasn't into broad pronouncements, her indicators were small, contracted, and only the most well-versed could decipher her sometimes.

In an unhurried tone, he said, "Then hurry up and get dressed because I have to change, too, you know."

She paused to answer, giving him a sidelong glance over her bare shoulder. She only wore her pajama shorts, had taken off her tank top and that pretty-in-pink bra. He'd never seen her more beautiful. And now she turned to face him. A bold move from timid Lib, but held in check by crossing her forearms over her bare breasts—but she'd revealed to him the flesh of her bosom as it was squashed. It flabbergasted him, because Libby would *never* do that. His eyebrows raised, and he made a croaking sound that made her smile.

Soft as a distant babbling brook, he murmured, "Show me..."

But now she hugged herself, swiveling at the hips and giving him a funny smile. She popped back around, snatched her pajama shirt, said, "Can you turn around now, please?"

“Sorry,” he whispered, internally shouting *Show me more!* He turned his head away and listened as she shimmied the soft cotton over her bare skin.

When he turned back, she was facing him, still hugging her arms across her chest though she wore her shirt now. She said, “It was a good night.”

“It was,” he agreed, unbuttoning his shirt.

“I’m still so surprised. I thought Chelsea hated me...”

“Sometimes you can make up things in your head.”

Libby said, “Oh, no, I was pretty sure she hated me because she made it clear...” She shook her head, looking away and down at the floor. “Pretty clear indeed.”

“We all seem to be getting along now.”

“The dinner was really good,” she said.

“It was,” he agreed, slipping his shirt off and throwing it in the hamper.

“Finn can really cook.”

His stomach tightened and a feverish burn rippled over his heart. He bit his lip, said, “On the dance floor, too.”

Libby nodded, looking away and to the side still, leaving him unsure whether it was to give him privacy while he changed, or so she wouldn’t have to look in his eyes when they talked about Finn.

He put on pajamas in silence, Libby not leaving, leaning against a dresser with her arms folded. When he’d changed, she said, “It’s okay if I go with Finn?”

He took a pause, gathering his thoughts, doing his best to keep his expression plain and unmoved. He said, “Of course. Why wouldn’t it be?”

“Because you’re not going to be there.”

“Finn’s going to be there,” he said.

Her mouth moved around, her brow creased. “But Finn’s not my husband.”

“So?” He shrugged, acting like he waited for more of the story.

“A married woman like me shouldn’t...” She hunched her shoulders and grimaced, then didn’t continue. She said, “Don’t you think?”

“It’s his job to be at the concert. You’re friends with him. You guys have separate rooms, you’re not staying *together*. You can *hang* at a concert...”

“Okay,” she said, keeping her arms folded but wagging her hands at him. “It feels weird, but I *do* want to go. If you don’t think it’s a big deal...”

He scoffed, darted his head back, said, “A big deal? Not at all, Lib. I’m so happy that I’m not going to ruin your Dorchester concert.”

“It won’t be the same without you,” she said purposefully meeting his gaze and showing him sad eyes, wanting him to know she meant it.

“Aw, I know, baby, I really wish I could go. But I don’t want you to miss out, I mean it. I’m so happy that Finn is going because it means *you* can go. It would be worse if you couldn’t go at all. I’m grateful for Finn, you should be too...”

“I think I’m going to go,” she said, and gave a curt nod to herself.

“You should, Lib, you should. You *totally* should,” he said as his phone vibrated on the dresser. He snatched it and looked at the face, saw it was a text from Finn. He said, “Go on to bed, I’ll just be a second with this...”

Now she came very near him, a braless breast brushing past his arm, a whisper close to his ear. “Hurry, because I think I want to get frisky...”

“You do?” He startled at her unusual immodesty, and as she passed, she gave an attempted sly look before she darted from the doorway. His hand clutched into a fist over his sternum and he slumped against the dresser. It really was happening. Finn brought something out of her, and while he hated it to the highest degree, something about it was so damn arousing.

And what would it matter? If it absolves him of his guilt and also improved their sex life at the same time?... And what if it would maybe open doorways to new sexual dimensions?

He swiped his screen, read the text from Finn.

**Finn:** what a night! Libby is such a doll. Things look good. Let me know...

He chewed his lip as his thumbs hovered over the text keys. He closed the phone down instead, set it on his dresser.

LIBBY WAS CURLED up in bed with her back toward him, and he slipped in behind her, pulling the sheets over to cover himself. He squirmed his way next to her so the fronts of his thighs touched the back of hers. He put his hand on her hip over the blanket. And even though Finn was the last thing he should be talking about right now, he heard himself ask her: “Why do you feel weird about going with Finn?”

She flinched, whispered over her shoulder to him, “I don’t know. I don’t feel *weird*, Ben. It’s just... I’m going away without my husband...”

“And with another man...”

“Right,” she said.

He asked her, “Do you think it’s wrong?”

“Do *you*?” She glanced over her shoulder.

“I said I didn’t. But why do you worry? Is there a big deal? Aren’t you two just friends?”

“Yeah,” she said, brow scowling. “I know. We’re just friends...”

“So if you’re just friends...?...”

She nodded vigorously. “You’re right,” she said. “No, I *know* you’re right. I told you I’m going to go. I’m *going* to do it.”

“I’m proud of you,” he said, “that’s a pretty bold move.”

The scowl returned though she smiled thinly. “Don’t make me worry about it...”

His hand drifted down, found his erection raging as hard as it could be. Finn was right—Libby had a crush on him. Why else would she worry about going away? He said, “I think it’s awesome. I’m so glad you have someone like him you can do a thing like this with.”

“He’s so nice.”

“You guys dance well together.”

“I’d rather dance with you,” she said, “but you reject me.”

He said, “Trust me, as a bystander, you and Finn put on a much better show...”

She giggled, and he watched her shoulder shake.

He whispered, “Frisky?”

She whispered back: “Maybe...”

He pushed the front of his pajama pants down, got them to his knees. He poked her bottom with his erection and she giggled again, squirmed her hips on the bed.

“You *are* frisky,” he said.

“No, I’m not,” she laughed, “Ben...”

“Spoons?”

She stilled, asked over her shoulder: “Did you like that?”

“I liked it a lot, Lib,” he said, then hooked a thumb into the side of her pajama shorts. He slipped them down a little, and Libby’s hand went over his to assist. They worked her shorts down to her knees; she wasn’t wearing any panties.

“We had a lot of fun tonight,” he whispered, gripped the base of his erection, and ran it along the back of her thigh and across her buttock.

She sighed, said, “We did...”

“We’re the cool kids now, Lib...”

“We can go anywhere in the caf, sit anywhere...”

He laughed and watched her lips part in anticipation of having sex with him. She turned her chin up to the ceiling, but folded her forearm across her eyes, hiding herself.

He whispered, “Are you going to go on his motorcycle?”

Libby gave a breathy gasp, said, “Oh, I don’t know, I’ve never...”

“You can take my truck. I’ll rent a car...”

Libby’s eyes moved from left to right as she considered it. She sucked her lower lip a moment. “I want to go on his motorcycle...”

He smiled and groaned at her innocence, her sweetness, her obliviousness to the deviousness of her husband and the people she wanted as friends. He ached for her; ached to be inside her. “Are you ready? Is it okay?”

Lib's breaths came quicker, her eyes closed, and she furrowed her brow.  
"You should probably wear a condom, I think..."

"Are you sure?"

"No, maybe..."

"I can go get one..."

"I don't want to wait..."

That made his heart jump in his chest. He'd never seen Libby this eager before. Or at least prepared to vocalize it. His cock was like steel in his hand. She'd never turned him on more in his entire life. He studied those pouting lips, saw their wetness, saw the perfect flare of her nostrils, wondered what those eyes would tell him if she would reveal them.

He wanted to see into her, wanted to know what she thought...

As he nestled his tip into the tight membranes of her opening, her juices squished around him. She was teeming wetness. She said, "Just pull out..."

"I will," he assured her, his heart beating even faster. This was practically dirty talk—at least for Libby—and hearing it come from her pretty mouth was driving him wild. *What was inside her?*

He pushed himself deep, and she squeezed around him like a tight seal. She was so slick, the sound of his plunging crackled with the sticky sound of oil. He whispered, "You're *so* wet..."

"Be-enn," she chastised.

"You are..."

"Don't..."

Then as he pulled out and plunged in again, she made a whimpering sound. She uttered the dirtiest words she'd ever said to him: "You're so, *so* hard..."

"You make me so hard..."

"Be-enn," she chastised him again, but her hand scrambled for his, pulled it to her chest. He grabbed her breast and felt the hump of her nipple hard against his palm. He pushed in and out again, watching Libby's face. She was closed off, her eyes hidden, and he *knew* she was thinking about Finn.

He withdrew, plunged all the way in now, making the headboard rattle. Libby squawked, then panted. He watched her bite her lower lip then let it plop loose.

He built a rhythm with her, and she squirmed along against his movements. He looked at those pouting lips connected by a thin silver wire

of her sweet saliva. Those eyes were closed off so she could shut the outside world. Because in her mind the man she's with right now isn't her husband... She's in a hotel room in Barrie having sex with another man...

"So, so hard," she gasped again, and it had him jumping on the bed. His hips shot back, and he ejaculated into the bedding. He cursed and growled, made long dragging hisses as his body was wracked with an enormous orgasm. He kept the sheet to his hands, gripped it around his throbbing erection. The whole time he'd ejaculated, Libby squirmed on the bed next to him. And he could tell now that she had a finger on her button. She pulled the sheets over to cover, but he could see her hips rolling in circles and knew her hand was down there.

"Holy crap," he said, watching her do something he never imagined he would witness. His mouth went instantly dry, and he stared at the sexy lusty hump under the bed sheet twiddle pleasure from itself. Slowly, eventually, she slowed, her pants not building to ecstasy, but at least providing herself some much-needed relief. He held two handfuls of bedding between his legs, sitting on his hip now and watching the shape of her.

Libby labored for breath, a rapid rising and falling of her chest under the sheet. She moaned a little and sucked on her lower lip, gradually composing herself.

He watched in awe. When the room was quiet, he whispered, "I'm going to need this bedsheet," and tugged gently on it to prove it was her clutch on it that prevented him.

She sighed, turned her head on the pillow, eyes sleepy and happy. She whispered, "Did you get any on the top sheet?"

"I don't think so."

"Okay," she said, releasing her hold on the sheet, "there is clean bedding in the dresser in the closet."

"I know," he said, backing up to get off the bed, a bedsheet full of his semen clutched between his legs, watching the cotton slowly drift off his wife's curves and her bare back revealed to him. As the sheet came off, she put a spread open palm across her bare ass cheeks to block his view. She said, "Bedsheets, please, quick, I don't want to be cold..."

"Got them, got them," he said, backing away and looking at the sexiest thing he'd ever seen in his marriage. His wife, on her side, her toes curling, knees drawn up, at the cusp of a broad sexual awakening, her eyes cast out on the horizon. She was primed, she might accept adventure...

He ducked into the closet, squeezed his cock out into the sheet, tossed it into the hamper, pulled up his pajama shorts. He slid open the drawer, but put his elbows on the top and grabbed his phone. He batted out a text to Finn with his thumbs moving quick.

**Ben:** I want to do it



## PART 2

# RAGNA-ROCK

FRIDAY, JULY 12

FRIDAY NIGHT, not long after six o'clock, Libby got home from her shift at the bookstore, practically skipped in the doorway giving him a breathy *Hey, hey, hey*, then sprinted up the steps two at a time. He stood at the bottom of the stairs and watched her shadow move and disappear into their bedroom, listened then as she ran the shower and got in for a quick rinse before Finn arrived.

Fifteen minutes later she came thumping down the steps bringing him out of the kitchen to watch her.

"Who's excited?" he asked into the hallway.

"I am!" She was shouting from the front hall.

"Is Finn here yet?" he asked, coming around to lean on the kitchen archway and watch his young wife nervously prepare for the arrival of the guy who was taking her to the proverbial prom.

"No, he's not out there yet." She practically bubbled.

"How was work?"

"The day went on *forever*," she said and rolled her eyes.

"I can imagine. Dorchester, baby," he said and raised a limp fist.

"You're still a jerk for not coming," she told him sulkily.

Now he crossed the space between them, taking her in as he walked. She wore a pair of shorts he hadn't seen before. They were black denim, jet black. Tight at her waist and kinda showing off her round bottom. Not too short—they had a rolled cuff that ended two inches above mid-thigh—but strangely short for Lib. Then in contrast she wore a white T-shirt, a V-neck, with billowy sleeves and when she moved her arms around, he could see

the top side curve of her pale pink bra. The one she wore for Finn. His stomach grumbled.

"I'm still so proud of you, I can't believe you're going to go and see Dorchester..."

"Without you?"

"No, I mean at all. I'm happy for you. You'll have an awesome time."

"Imagine if Finn can get us backstage..."

"He's going to, he said he's in and out of there..."

"You think he'll take me with him back there?"

"He said he would."

Her gaze drifted down and her eyes bulged as she considered herself meeting real live celebrities she fan-girled out on when she was a cute little teen. She said, "Maybe it'd be better if I don't."

"Why?"

"I don't think I could handle it," she said, and fanned herself.

He caressed her bare arms, said, "You'll kick yourself if you don't."

"You're right," she agreed. "Yeah, I have to be a big girl."

"You're a big girl, Libby. You're the best girl..."

She giggled, softly said, "And you're such a jerk for not coming."

"I would be there if I could. I *wish* I was going..."

"You don't even like Dorchester," she murmured.

"But I like you," he said, slinked his arms around her tighter. "Plus, there are lots of other bands playing."

She hugged him in return, said, "Do you think they'll play Tom's Everglades?"

"I think they have to."

"They better."

"You like that song Holding Your Heart."

"They'll play that," she said.

They held each other and began to rock from side to side, his wife clinging to him, her weight heavy on him as she leaned her weight; he gripped her shirt to keep her upright. She was reluctant to leave.

A rumble approached, and he knew it would be Finn's motorcycle. "I think he's coming," he said.

She whispered, "I hear him..."

TOGETHER, he and Lib came down off their doorstep and onto the sunny garden patch out front of the house. At the mouth of their short driveway, Finn's motorcycle had pulled up sideways. Chelsea was on the back, kicking out a long denim leg to dismount, then stomping her cowboy boots to get her jeans comfortable again. She flipped up the visor of the helmet and waved to him. He waved back.

On Chelsea's back was the pack Finn and Lib would bring with them. A change of clothes for both of them, their toiletries and other necessities. Libby had dropped off her overnight items to Chelsea the day before. Chelsea had packed the bags for the two of them. Chelsea doffed it, dropped it near the bike's fat rear wheel. Finn shut it down, then kicked a leg out to dismount as well, popping off his helmet as he did. He wore a leather jacket that fit tight to his body and a pair of black canvas work pants. He gave Lib a hang-ten sign and called out: "Dorchester!"

To Ben's surprise, Libby let out a hoot and pumped a fist. His eyebrows raised as his heart raced. The sudden urge to stop this lunged out at him now, gripped his lapels and try to shake some sense into him. *You don't want this* it said.

*I have to, I have to amend my guilt...*

It's not about that anymore...

*It is, it is!*

Chelsea unzipped the slim leather jacket she wore and shrugged it off her shoulders. She wore a tank top underneath and no bra. Her nipples were dark coins seen under the pale fabric. "You all set?" she said to Libby as Libby came closer.

“I am,” Lib said. “I’m *so* excited...”

Chelsea held out the leather jacket like a bullfighter’s cape, luring Libby to put an arm through it. Libby turned her back and slunk an arm through the sleeve of Chelsea’s jacket. Finn came to join her, and now the couple was facing his wife as the jacket was zipped up. Chelsea gave it a few good stop-and-go tugs to get it over Libby’s chest. It made Libby sway on her feet but she got it done up to the neck, then patted Libby’s shoulders. She said, “Your tits are *way* bigger than mine,” and laughed.

Finn laughed as well, and Libby swallowed the bottom corner of her lip, her bashful eyes turned up to look at Finn. Her cheeks blushed right before Ben’s eyes. A bright cheery bloom on her perfect little cheeks. Stop it, what you doing?—this is madness! *My guilt! My guilt!*

“This is it, Lib,” Ben said, stepping up and running his hand over her leather arm, feeling the gathered sunlight heat there. “You got everything?”

“I do,” she said.

“You got your phone?”

Chelsea held out her hand. “Give it to me, I’ll zip it in the pack.”

Libby retrieved her flip-phone from a pocket and passed it to Chelsea, said to Ben, “Check.”

“Money?”

“Check.”

“Credit card?”

“Check.”

“ID?”

“Check.”

“Switchblade?”

“Ch—what do I need a switchblade for?”

Finn hugged an arm over her shoulder, said, “How else you going to protect me, Lib?”

Libby elbowed at him but didn’t connect. She said, “Aren’t you supposed to protect me?”

Finn said, “I’m going to show you a good time, I was hoping you would be the muscle.”

Libby’s cheeks blushed, and she said, “You’re the one with the muscles, Finn,” and that cute smile on Lib’s face as she looked up at this guy she was crushing on could very well break her crazy husband.

BEN TOOK HIS WIFE ASIDE, held her shoulders and looked in her eyes. He said, "Go have a good time. Have the best time of your life. I'll be thinking about you and I'll be hoping you're having fun."

"I will," she said, unable to hide that she was projecting a brave face because underneath she was timid.

"You wear your helmet no matter what Finn says."

She frowned and smiled. "He's not going to say I don't have to."

He squeezed her shoulders. "I don't want you getting a tattoo."

"I won't." She smirked.

"Make sure Finn doesn't go too fast."

"I've never been on a motorcycle before," she said and looked nervously over her shoulder at the aggressive and muscular styling of Finn's custom hog.

"You hold on to him..."

"I know how to do it," she said, then looked back at him now. She'd put gloss on her lips. His stomach ached.

He said, "I love you."

"I love you too, Ben," she said, the worry creasing her brow.

"Promise me you'll have fun."

"I will."

Libby donned the nylon backpack, a sporty-looking thing with all sorts of racing striping and logos. She jumped up and down to get the pack's weight to settle, and Chelsea made sure all the zippers were done up and the straps had been tightened. She patted Libby's visor, rubbed a circle on her shoulder, guiding her onto the higher curve of the motorcycle's leather seat.

Libby's leg was thrown over the saddle, her pussy humped snug up against Finn's rump. He had his helmet turned to the side, watching them get her prepared.

Ben came in, gave her a light hug, his head twisted away to make room for the bulb of her fancy helmet. She patted his back, and he gave her a thumbs up. She gave him one back, and Finn reached to grab her hand, and pulled it to his front. Libby leaned forward and rested her chest on him and hugged her arms around Finn's body. Ben stepped back.

Finn started up the bike, and Ben began to chew on his lip watching as the bike went into gear, the guttural motor sound changed and the bike rolled forward. Both Finn and Libby looked over their shoulders to see if traffic was coming, then Finn let the bike out, did a slow 'U' on their shady, tree-lined street, Finn waving as they began to grumble down Sarah Ashbridge in first gear. Libby was too afraid to wave, kept her hands clutched to Finn's chest.

He missed her already. The fainter the rumble of Finn's bike grew, the more he wanted to call this off. The more he wanted to put an end to it. He would confess. He would throw his body on the gears of the machine and let it bend him at its will. *At his wife's will...*

Chelsea came to stand beside him, both of them watching the bike slow at Boardwalk, its indicator coming on showing left to take them to the highway.

"There they go," she said.

"I can't believe this is happening," he said.

"Oh, shoot," Chelsea said.

He waited for more and when she said nothing he turned to regard her. "*Oh, shoot* what?"

She held a hand out and wiggled Libby's flip-phone at him. She said, "I forgot to pack Libby's phone."

His stomach tightened further, and he groaned. "Why would you do that?"

"Because I'm a bitch," she answered, obviously proud of it.



LIBBY DIDN'T CALL him until after ten o'clock at night and he was about ready to scream. He'd been driving up and down the 401 between Pickering and Oshawa waiting for her call. He was on a break, pulled over at the Tim Hortons, sitting in the parking lot, cursing and muttering, sweaty hands gripping his steering wheel tight. *Why wasn't she calling?* She'd left before seven, she would've been there eight-to-eight-thirty, why didn't she call right away? Did she not make it? Was she hurt? Did they check into the hotel, but were too busy getting sweaty under the sheets to let poor Ben know everything was all right? Poor husband was the last to know. Sitting here at proverbial home waiting for a call from his errant wife...

Only *he* was the bad one. Why was he going back and forth on the highway? *Well, when Lib calls, I have to look like I'm on the road to Niagara. You know... The whole reason I can't go to Dorchester and she will end up cheating on me... Fucking crazy...*

When the phone buzzed, he jumped a foot off his leather. The god damn ring tone was set too loud. It was like a telephone explosion had gone off in the cab, someone dropping a telephonic grenade into his front seat. His heart hammered in his ears and he gripped the phone close, his eyes reading the screen. *Finn calling.*

Right. Libby didn't have her phone. Finn was in control...

The call disappeared. The chance to answer it gone. "What the fuck?" he muttered. *Come on...*

A new sound, a bubbling sound. A FaceTime call.

He swiped the app open, received the incoming call. He was presented with a blurry image of his wife, smiling wide, her eyes turned low like she

was looking off at the bottom of the screen. She was mid-sentence, saying, "...on?... I don't think it's... wait... No, I see him..." Now her face turned up to the screen, and she waved at him with gleeful exuberance.

"Hey, baby," he shouted, his voice as disturbingly loud as his jangling phone had been in the quiet cab. His truck filled with light from the white reverse bulbs of a lifted SUV backing out from a spot behind him. "I miss you..."

"This is so crazy," Libby said, then to her side: "How do I?..."

There was a deep rumbling voice but he couldn't decipher the words. The voice was Finn's. A hand and forearm loomed into view. The forearm was muscular, covered with tattoos, the hand held a clear cup half drained of its beer; a wedding ring winked. Finn pointed at something on the phone, Lib said, "Okay, okay, that's good now—I can hear you better now, Ben..."

"I said I missed you so much—you got there okay?..."

But she was ignoring him again, turning her face to the side as Finn said something else to her. She nodded, said something behind her hand, then laughed, slapped her knee, smiling and showing off her white teeth. She turned back and said, "Hold on, Ben..."

Then she fumbled around, Finn helping her with something. Now the camera was back on her face, and Finn's hand was tucking an ear bud into her ear. She was saying, "Okay, okay, that's good... Ben?..."

"Hi, baby," he said clearly for her.

"I miss you," she squealed.

"Are you having fun?"

"I swear I am," she said. Her face was so close the background was blotted out. He asked her where she was.

"I don't know," she said, her face turning to look around. "It's like a control room or something. The bands are doing sound check..." Now she loomed even closer... "I... saw... *Dorchester*," she mouthed, pronouncing each word then stretching her mouth in a silent fan-girl scream while her head jittered.

"Did you really?"

"I did. They were doing sound check, and I was sitting up here in the booth. I didn't get to meet them or anything, but I got to see them practice their set..."

"That's awesome."

She said, "They're going to play Tom's Everglades."

“Oh, yeah?”

“They played it at sound check,” she said and squeezed at her nose.

“What did you guys do for supper?”

“Finn and I went to—” She turned away and asked Finn, “What was that place?”

Finn’s deep voice returned an answer, his shadow passing as he leaned closer to Lib.

She repeated, “Finnegan’s Irish Public House.”

“What is it?”

“A bar. Restaurant...”

“What did you eat?”

She got close and whispered, “Just a chicken breast and salad...”

“Why are you whispering?”

Her eyes darted sidelong. “It’s because my stomach is upset...”

“From nerves?”

She nodded.

“You’re doing great,” he said.

She glanced around the room where she was, the camera falling away from its close focus on Lib. He could see the glare off a large sheet of tinted glass, a man’s back turned his way; the guy had long stringy hair and sat at a control board of some kind with an array of lights and switches and sliders. Conversations threaded low in the air, undecipherable but decidedly all-male. Libby turned her face back, said, “It’s crazy here...”

“Who else did you see?”

“Sound check?—uh, Peter Frampton, Matthew Good... oh, uh, Aerosmith is here, but I didn’t hear them play but I saw the lead singer guy walk across the stage...”

“How’s Finn?”

“He’s awesome.” She turned her face away from the screen, looking up. She said to Finn, “I’m just saying to Ben how you’re awesome,” her voice quieter away from the microphone. She waited for a response, and he watched her throat gulp as she chuckled. Now she returned to him, saying, “Yeah, Finn’s good. We had dinner, then we went and checked in, but then we had to get to the show real quick... I didn’t have a chance to call you. And hey, why didn’t you ask me something?...”

“Ask you what?”

“How come I’m calling you on Finn’s phone.”

“I know why you’re calling me on Finn’s phone.”

“Not so I can do video chat...”

“I know it’s not because you can’t do video chat on yours...”

“I lost my phone,” she said in a husky conspiratorial manner, her comic tone making him wonder if she’d been drinking. Why not? She’d gone to an Irish bar. Of course she was drinking...

“You didn’t lose your phone,” he said.

“No, I did, seriously...”

“It’s here.”

“It’s there? Serious?”

“I have it,” he said.

“Oh, my God,” she gasped in relief, clasped a hand to her chest and let out an exasperated roar, her pouted lips tilted upward, a brief exhale making her hanging hair whisk away. “Oh, wow, Ben, I was really, really, really—”

“It’s here,” he said, “I have it. Chelsea forgot to pack it.”

“She said she packed it,” Libby said.

“She thought she did.”

Away from the camera, Libby said to Finn, “Ben has my phone. Chelsea forgot to pack it.”

Finn said something, and they both laughed.

“What is it? What did he say?” But Libby wasn’t paying attention to him, still listening to Finn.

Libby laughed, and Finn’s shadow receded. Libby turned and asked him, “Where are you now?”

“I don’t know,” he said, “I’m not sure,” making a production of looking around. “I kinda zoned out. I’m on the highway somewhere, but when you called I was parked—I was feeling sleepy, so I pulled over to a Tim Hortons to grab a coffee...”

“Don’t drive tired,” she said, her tone serious.

“I won’t be,” he said, “I got a coffee now. I’m good, Lib, I’m good. What are you going to do now?” He asked to change the subject of his location.

“I don’t know,” she said, leaning back from the camera again, her head turned to the side and he heard her ask Finn, “What are we doing now?”

Libby listened and Ben watched her hand gather at her collar, her finger tracing up and down the fabric line where her T-shirt crossed her neck, absently caressing herself.

Libby came back, her face blotting out the background, saying, “We’re here for a little bit longer. He’s got some stuff to do, then he said we can do whatever. There are a couple parties, and he said maybe the bands will have something going on in the hotel...” She widened her eyes, like she couldn’t believe it herself. She said, “Then I guess we’ll just go back to the room...”

“How’s your room?”

“It’s really great,” she said.

“How’s the bed?”

“Clean. Comfy,” she said. “It’s gonna be empty without you in it.” Now she pouted out her lower lip again.

“I really wish I was there, Lib,” he said.

She turned away again, listened to someone speaking to her. She said, “Okay, I gotta go, Ben, we’re going to a different room. Finn needs his phone for a bit...”

“Call me later, baby.”

“I will if I can,” she said, eyes turned down like she was trying to figure out the phone’s controls. “How do I...?”

Finn’s low voice instructed her.

“And this is for hang up?”

Now Finn’s face loomed, sharing space with Libby’s. They were almost cheek to cheek, but they didn’t touch. Finn’s hand came around her shoulder, his tented fingers holding up the almost empty beer cup. He said, “How’s Big Ben?”

“How’s it going, Finn?”

“Awesome, man, you’re missing the best show this summer, guaranteed.”

Libby agreed, saying, “It’s so awesome, Ben...”

“You guys have fun,” he said, the sound of his own words creeping a pair of cuckold horns behind his head. *Was Libby thinking right at this moment that there may be a possibility...?*

Finn said, “I’ll make sure she does. You’re having fun, right, Lib?” Their faces turned toward each other’s—far too close together.

Lib said, “I guess we are already,” and laughed. She turned to face Ben, said, “Don’t worry about me, baby, I’m having fun...”

“I love you,” he said, feeling his heart beginning to ache.

“I love you, too,” she said, eyes turned down, and then Finn pointing to show her which button to press. “Bye, baby,” she said, her last word cut off

as the screen went blank.

His stomach grumbled again, and he hunched forward hugging his elbows into his hips as real pain tightened through him. “Oh, God,” he hissed over and over again, delightful pain almost caressing over him like a teasing sheet being drawn up his body, its tassel-strung hem tickling over his scalp. *Why wouldn't he stop this?*

*Because you deserve it...*

“I know,” he said finally, gasping as a measure of relief washed over him. He panted for breath, pushing those thoughts out of his mind. He fired up the truck, backed out and went through the drive-through. He'd need a coffee because this was going to be a long night...

LIBBY NEVER CALLED him again that night, though she only promised she would try, and as the clock turned over to one in the morning, he broke the Apple remote. He told himself, sitting on the couch waiting for her call, that if she didn't call by midnight, then she was sleeping with Finn.

The hour between eleven and twelve was the worst hour of his life. It was spent twisted on the couch, a pillow held to his chest. As the witching hour drew near, he ended up with his head resting on the back of the couch as he rabbit-punched body blows into the pillow's plumped up center, pinched in the corner of the couch where it couldn't get away from him.

The dark and ugly truth was clear. He could call Finn, he told himself, and cancel this. Finn had said it. No. He was all alone, his wife so far away, and there was no way to stop her. He could call Finn and Finn wouldn't answer. Wouldn't hear his pleas of surrender. *Please don't sleep with my wife!*

What scared him the most when he faced it was the ugliest of suspected truths. Finn *would* pick up. Why *wouldn't* he pick up? The reason Ben wasn't calling yet was because he wanted to wait just a little bit longer. Just a minute more. *I want to hold out... I'll decide later...* Because there was a dark part of him that *wanted* this to happen. He could try to fool himself saying he wanted it to happen because he could explore with Chelsea, maybe even spend a little more time with Neve, and do it guilt-free... But the truth was since this awful summer project had changed into second gear and became about Libby and Finn—not his absolution—he hadn't thought about Chelsea in that way at all. Quite the opposite. All his focus was pinpointed on that petite squeaky clean fresh-faced young girl he married...

Who right now had her little legs wrapped around Finn's hips, her nails dragging lines on the hard shapes of his muscular back...



## PART 3

# DORCHESTER

SATURDAY, JULY 13

WHEN HE AWOKED, there was a text waiting for him.

**Finn:** got into our hotel room safe and sound everything great!  
Call you tomorrow

Was it Finn who'd written it? Was that Libby's text? If it was Libby, wouldn't she have sent him some hearts? Or maybe hearts for her husband were the last thing on her mind when she tumbled into the hotel room after partying with some band. Was Finn on her the moment they fell into the room?—her back going up against the wall, her arms going around his neck as he kissed her? Was that how it played out?

*Maybe she texted you after the deed was done...*

Maybe when they came in the hotel room, all Libby's thoughts of her Ben were long gone. Maybe this text was sent in that hazy afterglow of sex. He could picture her, the way she'd get bashful, hide herself in the sheets, her cheeks were broadcast with red and there was a sparkle in her eye. After sex, her hair would hang limp and she would have to keep tucking it behind her ears. Is that what she was like, sitting next to Finn in bed, him stretched out and satiated, her little thumbs dabbing out an A-OK message to her witless husband...

*Maybe it hadn't happened. Maybe nothing had happened.*

It was possible. It wasn't likely, but it *was* possible. Perhaps they just came in after a night out, keeping it sensible, neither of them drinking too much—Finn was at work after all, just drank that one beer, that was all he'd

had, Finn had to keep his wits around these bands, didn't want to lose respect—they came in but it was just too late to call. Before Finn disappeared into his separate room, Libby asked him to send Ben a quick text. Then she went and crawled into bed solo and thought about her husband and the great night he was missing...

Unlikely.

Maybe he didn't *want* to know how it played out. Maybe it would be sufficient to know that it had been done. He didn't care where. Didn't care if it was in a luxury suite penthouse hotel room's bathroom, done up against the sink, in the back of a limo, or a cab, back at the hotel room... It didn't matter where or how, just that it was done.

Only, he had no more pervasive thought than 'the *how*.' All morning he limped around the house, head hung like a man in mourning. Physical pain gripped him, crippled his gait, had him lurching and wincing and grimacing as he moved from room to room trying to find a comfortable place for him to curl up and die in.

One o'clock, she texted again.

**Finn:** up and at em

**Ben:** how'd it go?

**Finn:** How'd what go?

*Was it Libby?* His mind raced and his heart hammered. He texted.

**Ben:** The party. This is Libby?

**Finn:** It's me. Hi baby. I'll call you in a bit. I just want you to know that I'm okay, we were out late

**Ben:** did you go to a party?

**Finn:** I'll call you in a bit

He sent a thumbs up, and clutched his phone like it was a lifesaver and he was adrift at sea, eyes boring into that screen and waiting for it to text him back. She didn't call again until three.

HE TOOK a video call sitting in a park. The park could pass for Niagara, he figured, and he'd spent the day catching up on paperwork and calls, doing it all out of the house and playing a weird game of musical chairs, moving from unfamiliar locale to unfamiliar locale so Lib wouldn't recognize the background.

It wasn't Libby's face that popped up on the screen. It was Libby's bottom. She wore a pair of denim shorts much like the black ones that were new to him yesterday. These ones were shorter. There wasn't the cuff, and they rode about three inches higher than the black ones—tucking just below the curve of her buttock. He watched that bottom he married swish from side to side as she danced; music blared into distortion, and the image was blurry. Libby's hair danced on her back, and her dancing and swaying grew more pronounced as the tempo picked up. This would be an opening band, an early afternoon starter. He didn't recognize the song, but Libby sure seemed to like it.

“Just calling to check in...” Finn's voice near the mic.

He asked, “Is it done?”

Finn didn't answer, and now the camera was moving closer to Lib. She held a plastic cup of beer up above her shoulder as she danced, her head bobbing from side to side, in opposite beat to the boom-boom of her jean-hugged ass. Finn's hand loomed in the image now, reaching out and touching Libby on her shoulder. He could hear Finn shouting *Lib, it's Ben, it's Ben* over top of the music.

When Libby turned, it was like she had been expecting Finn, and like she'd been alone for a little while, because when she turned to see him

approaching with the camera she lit up, dancing for him, putting her arms out like she wanted to hug him.

“It’s Ben,” Finn shouted over the crashing music again.

Libby tucked her hair behind an ear, leaned close, pushing her ear forward.

“It’s Ben!”

Libby jumped back in instant happiness, and she shouted *Ben?*

“Hey,” he shouted, waving at the screen, looking like a dummy to anyone passing by his park bench. “I love you!”

So this was what her face looked like after she fucked another man. His guts let out a tremulous whimper.

“I miss you so much,” she shouted, waving now frantically at him.

“I miss you too,” he shouted.

The tempo changed and the band that played entered another song. Libby turned over her shoulder to watch them. She cheered loudly, the sound like a shrill siren from his phone’s speakers, making him wince. She pumped another fist overhead and beer sloshed over the lip of her glass.

That simple image of her experiencing a simple carefree joy—something not always attainable to his timid wife—warmed a glow over him. He loved to see her like that. Maybe there was a future in this. She’d been with another man. She would be hurt by her own actions, maybe. Hopefully. And she would have regrets. He would tell her that he’d done it as well, and maybe they could engage in this new something together. *Had he ever even wanted that?* The clear question was: had he ever dared to dream it?

Sudden brave command rose up within him. He was proud to see her like that. Proud for her because he loved her. She had attained a level of independence that had helped her squeeze through the iron bars of her buckram prison. Sure, maybe it had been drawn from her by another man, but it was *his* warm and coaxing hand on her back that gave her the courage to take the step she feared. His guilt was cleared. He was free. She slept with another man. She was a new woman. She clearly loved him. She was happy where she was. His eyes welled with sudden tears. There was a sadness, a longing for something that had been lost. But there was a proud feeling in his heart, thinking that whatever they faced going ahead they could manage together. He sniffed, wiped at an eye and said, “I’m so happy you’re having a good time, Lib.”

“It’s awesome, Dorchester’s on soon,” she shouted over the cacophony, the phone jostling and blurry still.

He said, “Go. Go Libby, I’m just glad to see you. I’m glad to see you with that smile on your face...”

“I love you,” she shouted, and he wasn’t sure she’d even heard what he’d said. He just gave her the biggest smile he could muster and waved to her. She waved in return and his heart swelled. He took a shaky breath and held it, waved at her further and hung up.

The next half hour a numb feeling cradled him. A buzzing *nonexistence*. A feeling of not knowing who you were. Feeling like he was a stranger with amnesia in a house that seemed so familiar to him. The half hour after that he took it all back. He burst into tears, cried into his hands at what he’d done and what was gone from his wife now. She’d done it and it was over. She wasn’t entirely his anymore. He deserved it, Lord, did he deserve it; he would take the pain and the hurt, but he wished it was never like this. He wished they were restored to the weekend before Chelsea had returned to their lives.

He writhed in agony on the couch. Half an hour later, Chelsea arrived and surprised him. An hour after that, Libby’s parents arrived and surprised both of them...



THERE WAS a soft rap on the aluminum screen door, and he lifted himself from the sofa, made his way to the kitchen and peeked out the window. Chelsea was there, leaning a shoulder up against the brick.

The instant reaction was surprise and a happy sort of curiosity. But it was immediately quashed by dread. That pretty figure propped up on his porch portended a lot of trouble. It was her reintroduction to his life that had led him to this ruin. The lure of some sort of freestyle life paled now in the harsh reality of his Libby's infidelity. The idea of getting between Chelsea's sheets and getting their legs working together, putting his mouth on hers, held no current allure. The price had been too great to pay.

He lumbered to the hallway door, clicked open the aluminum screen, said, "Aren't you supposed to be in Ottawa?"

"That was night. Got home this aft," she said. She had that sly look in her eye, but there was a compassionate softness to her lips. They weren't tense or merciless, the corners were lowered in solemn repose. She raised a fist now, fingers clasped around a bottle in a brown LCBO bag. She held it aloft like a trophy, gave it a wag and made its liquid contents splosh. "Soften your sorrows," she said, "lubricate your lamentation?"

"Come in," he said, pushing the door open and stepping away, shuffling through the hall to the family room and flopping onto the couch.

Chelsea followed, the brown paper bag tucked under an elbow, head swiveling around looking at his untidy house. "Late night?" The table was littered with empty chip bags, beer cans, a dirty plate, his twisted and snapped Apple remote.

"Couldn't sleep," he said.

“Poor Ben,” she said. “But look at you now, you’re a new man.”

“I want to be the old man. The man that I was...”

“Own your position, Ben. *You* put you there. You made the mistake, but maybe you made it right now.”

“Maybe I made it right?”

“Time will tell, Ben, time will tell.”

“How will I know?”

“That all depends on Libby now.”

He raised his eyes up to look at her standing near the side of the couch.

“Are you going to tell me what happened?”

“Finn didn’t text you?”

“I guess he’s too busy,” he said.

Chelsea came around the L-shaped couch, let herself drop into it so the two of them both faced the TV. With elaborate performance, she kicked up one long leg to the coffee table, then the other followed, her heel hooking. Now she held the neck of the bottle in clawed fingers and whisked away the paper bag, presenting to him Kentucky bourbon.

He sighed. “You really came to support me?”

“Curious to see how you’re taking it.”

“Off and on. I have my good moments...”

“But a lot of bad ones?”

“I’ve been freaking out sometimes. Yeah,” he said, dumbly, “really just freaking out.”

“You’re not happy where you are?”

“Where am I?”

“Don’t you feel like you’ve been freed? Do you feel like your guilt is gone?”

“No,” he said, rubbed his forehead.

She put the bottle down on the glass top of the table with a loud crack, leaned forward with her elbows on her knees, her face looming closer to his. “Think about it, Ben. Really, really think about it.”

He sat straight, imitated her position, leaning forward and draping his wrists over his knees, head hanging down. He stared at the floor between his feet. He muttered, “Do I feel better?”

“That’s the question, Benjamin. How. Do. You. Feel?”

“I’ve been better.”

“And your guilt? I mean, the things that Libby *did*...”

His chin darted up. "What did he tell you?"

"He told me what happened."

"What happened?" His voice was urgent and quick now.

"Is your guilt gone?"

"Yeah, sure. C'mon, tell me what happened..."

"Don't rush me," she said, holding up her palms and pushing them at him like she was pumping the brakes.

"Would you just tell me what happened?"

Chelsea raised her eyebrows, let her hands drop. "Libby sucked him off." She shrugged, gave him her best *What are you going to do?* expression. "It's done, Ben."

"What?—wait... What are you talking about? Lib went down on him?"

"Finn says she did. Went down on him in some hotel bathroom. Not theirs, an after party or something. A band's. Said she was down on her knees, he came in her mouth."

"Holy fuck." His voice was just short of shouting. He stood up now, paced around the coffee table in a circle, poked at Chelsea's feet to let him past. *Libby, what the fuck are you doing?* He marched around for a second time, doing the full three-hundred-sixty tour. His eyes were wild with disbelief, his vision jittered with his pulse. "Libby, oh, my God," he said, and collapsed back in his spot. "Finn told you this?" He looked at Chelsea, she had her feet back up on the table, lounging comfortably in his couch.

"Yep. Said they went out, headed to some party or something, Libby'd been drinking all day, she followed him into the bathroom, before he knew it she was sliding down his body. Didn't think that was the way it would play out..."

"There's no way." He raked fingers through his hair.

"You don't believe me?"

"No, I believe you," he said. "I just can't believe that she did that. Not my Libby..."

"It's always the quiet ones. Finn says they're going to fuck tonight, for sure."

"Oh, my God." He rocked forward and backward.

"So how's your guilt?"

His stomach felt upside down. He rolled to his back on the couch and drew up his knees, hugged his shins. He closed out the light by squinting his eyes, gritted his teeth.

“Your guilt, Ben. Does that make it better?”

“I guess,” he shouted.

“You’ll get used to the fact that she did it.”

“I’ll never get used to it, Chelsea.” His tone was more spiteful than he’d intended.

“Yeah, you will. Because this is just the start.”

“What do you mean?”

“Sky’s the limit now,” she said, looking up to the family room ceiling like she could see the stars.

Now he sat up again. “No, it’s not. Finn thinks she’s gonna do more?...”

“Can you believe she did what she did?”

He shook his head, pulled at his collar. “No.”

Chelsea shrugged. “I guess that’s because she didn’t do that.”

He slouched, stared at this stupid bitch that he bothered trusting in the first place, this manipulating cunt who’d ruined his life. “She didn’t?”

“Nah. I just got in, I haven’t talked to Finn. He texted me this morning, said they went to their separate bedrooms.”

He groaned, rolled back to collapse on the couch with his arms out spreadeagled. Warm relief flooded through him. He exhaled and chuckled. But cold settled quickly, the heat dissipating, an icy lividity sinking him further into the couch. He wasn’t free then. The guilt *had* been gone.

He sat up now, said, “You’re such a fucking bitch.”

Chelsea said, “Have a drink,” and she nudged the whiskey toward him with the toe of her expensive cowboy boot.

He grabbed the neck, spun off the cap, took a tentative swig. He hid his grimace in the crook of an elbow, exhaled inhaled, swallowed. He roared, thunked the bottle down on the table. Chelsea was watching him. He rubbed his hands together, staring at the bottle, he told her the awful truth: “The guilt was gone.”

Glee upturned her face. “It worked?”

“It did.”

“Told you so.”

“You lied.”

“I did you a favor. I helped you. Now you know. Now you know you can handle it.”

“I can’t *handle* it, that’s not true. The guilt went away, but... Now that Lib has her purity back, I want to preserve it.”

“What you did’s going to burn in you like an ulcer, Ben. You tell the truth some time and she’s still pure Libby, then you’ll lose her. I’m telling you, you think this is a magic trick, but there’s a good chance it’ll be what saves your marriage.”

“It’s so fucking crazy,” he muttered.

“You want to save your marriage, don’t you?”

“More than anything,” he said.

“So I just gave you a gift, Ben. Take this in little increments. At least you know a certain truth now.”

He chewed his lip and stared at the floor, taking slow and deep breaths. The guilt had been gone...

“How you gonna repay me,” Chelsea said, rising, snatching up the whiskey bottle by the neck and tossing herself to land right next to him—hoisting him up for a moment on the pillow of the couch. She settled against his arm, staring close at the side of his face. She took a long and steady drink, watching him the whole time. She swallowed without making a face then rested the square bottom of the bottle between her skinny thighs. She said, “Finn said it was close last night, but it wasn’t a sure thing. He let your little fishy off the hook but he said she can’t resist the bait tomorrow. And that’s today, my friend. Right now.”

His head slowly oscillated to face her. An eager smile was kept in check, her pretty mouth tightened into a trembling W shape as she tried not to burst out in merriment. “So we gonna fuck now?” she said finally then laughed.

He snatched the bottle from her, raised it to his lips, said, “Is that all you \_\_\_”

“Hello, hello, hello...” Loud friendly shouts from their front step coming through the screen door. Shoes were stomping, he could picture the voice’s propellant standing with hands in a light spring jacket, bouncing on his toes, the remaining side swatches of hair brushed carefully behind his ears, the rosy glow of his professor glasses. Libby’s dad...

WHEN BEN JUMPED out of the couch, Chelsea grabbed the front of his shirt in a tight grip and pulled him to stay.

He was frantic, shouting, "Hey!"

Chelsea asked him, "You know what's funny?"

"Jesus, Chelsea," he said, prying her hand off him. "That's Libby's dad at the door."

"Ben, you know what's funny?"

He pivoted out of the couch, one foot on the floor, one knee on the seat. "What?"

"Libby's never given a blow job in her entire life, you think that's her go-to move when she wants to impress my husband? Timid little mouse wouldn't try that..."

"Fuck sake, Chelsea," he said, grabbing at his crotch where his penis had plumped out his underwear uncomfortably.

He stepped away, backing toward the kitchen, Chelsea watching him the whole time. She said, "She'll go to her back, Ben. Mark my words, first time she lets him fuck her, she's right on her back with her legs open..."

"What is wrong with you?" he whispered, tugging a comfortable tent in the front of his shorts and heading to the front door. *Holy shit, holy shit, holy shit...*

His pace to the door quickened, and he could already see Rich peeping in the screen and testing the aluminum door's lock. "Hey, hey there, Rich," he said happily, and now could see Bev was right behind him.

"Nice night, don't you think?" Rich said, looking out at the street and the low fading light that made the trees thrown in orange.

“What are you guys doing here?”

Bev said, “We’re going out to see a movie, but Rich is taking me to dinner first...”

“Boy,” he laughed, “you guys are really touring the town these days.”

“It’s summer, we’ve been cooped up for half a year.”

Shit, why didn’t he just keep the door closed? If it had been closed, he could’ve pretended he wasn’t home.

*But your truck’s in the driveway, Ben... Aren’t you supposed to be in Niagara arranging a phantom sailor?*

“Shoot,” he said, “guys, where’re my manners,” pushed open the door for them to allow entry.

Libby’s mom and dad slipped into the foyer, Libby’s mom wiping her shoes on the doormat. Libby’s dad’s eyes were fixed over Ben’s shoulder, and Ben whipped his head around to see Chelsea there grinning, leaning against the kitchen archway.

“Oh, ha, hey, guys, you know Chelsea.”

“Chelsea... right,” Libby’s dad said, wagging his finger toward Chelsea, eyes turned up in mnemonic activity. “Chelsea...”

“Chelsea Cunningham,” Ben said. “Friend of Libby’s...”

Bev said, “Oh, you guys have visitors.”

Ben stumbled, gave an uncomfortable chuckle, said, “Uh, no... This might look weird... It’s just me and Chelsea here, you remember Chelsea, from the old neighborhood...?”

Bev said, “In Aurora?”

“Yeah, she was friends with Libby, we were all friends back in public school. She’s the one—”

Rich snapped his fingers, then one finger settled on Chelsea like he was a short-haired Pointer. “The one from the movies.”

“That’s me,” Chelsea said and waved a palm at them.

“I remember.”

It dawned on Bev, who brightened. “Oh, the one who did the pageants...”

“I *hated* those,” Chelsea confided.

Ben said, “Yeah,” gave another nervous chuckle, “it’s just me and Chelsea here, but you know what’s weird?...”

Rich said, “What’s that?”

“Libby’s not here because she’s out with Chelsea’s husband.”

Bev was puzzled, said, “Out with Chelsea’s husband?”

“Yeah, Libby went up to Barrie to see Dorchester.”

“Oh, the band, the music guys? She loves Dorchester. She didn’t tell me...” Then to herself, wonderingly: “Libby tells me *everything*...”

“Chelsea’s husband works as a sound engineer and he got her into the Ragna-rock Festival up in Barrie. She loves Dorchester, she went yesterday after work. I couldn’t go because I had to run down to Niagara today, but I just got back—Chelsea came over because we’re going to go sit out back on the patio and FaceTime them.”

“On the computer?”

“That’s right,” he said. “I don’t know when they’re going to call, but we were just going to sit out back and wait.”

Rich was off boring Dorchester, saying, “You were in Niagara today?...”

*Oh, shit*—was he spotted somewhere else? His mouth hung open as his brain raced to form an excuse.

Rich said, “This about that boat?”

“Uh-huh,” he said. “Need a sailor for it.”

“It’s a done deal?”

“You know how it is,” Ben said to Rich, “but not a done-done deal till the boat’s in the harbor.”

“And the money’s in the bank,” Rich said and winked.

“I got half up front, but these guys...”

“They got deep pockets?”

“They got deep pockets,” he agreed, two men talking about business.

Bev asked Chelsea: “So, what are you doing now?”

Doing? Ben’s stomach did a funny bounce picturing Chelsea saying *I’m doing Ben if you two old farts would get outta here, I was going to do him up in the bedroom where he sleeps with Libby...*

But she said, “Still acting.”

“In movies?”

“If they’ll have me. But no, I do I do a play at the Vanguard.”

“Like a *play* play? Theater?”

“Sure thing. You guys ever want tickets—you go to shows?”

Bev said, “Is it something we know?” Then added: “Not that we wouldn’t go if it wasn’t...”

Chelsea laughed. “It’s an original play. But I think you might like it. Just ask Libby if you want to go, and I’ll get tickets to her for you.”



Ben saw his chance. “What’s the show tonight you’re seeing?”... As in *Don’t you think you should be getting the hell out of here?*

AFTER RICH and Bev had been appeased, then ushered to their vehicle, Ben shut both doors and locked them. Slumped against the door, one hand gripped the doorknob tightly to support his weight. As the Sander's bug's headlights came on and the ignition was fired, he gave them a friendly wave goodbye through the door's window.

"Smooth, Ben," Chelsea said, "they didn't suspect a thing..."

"Do you think they did?"

Chelsea said, "We're not doing anything."

"We're *not* doing anything," he said. "But you're here, and... Libby's away..."

Chelsea shrugged. "Away with *my* husband."

"Yeah, with your husband," he agreed, the reminder squeezing at his guts.

"So don't sweat it."

Ben's forehead rested on the doorframe. "This is just getting worse and worse."

"Let's go wait for the call, Benjamin. Just like you were telling them." She held out a hand for him to take.

"That's what we were going to do."

Chelsea took his tentative hand. "I can't believe they haven't called already," she said, guiding him back to the family room, around to the couch again, and taking her spot where she'd started.

He sat, hung his head and ran his fingers through his hair, scratched at his scalp. "Ah, fuck, shit..."

"What now?"

“I have to tell Libby I’m not in Niagara.”

“Why?”

“Because her parents were *here*, Chelsea.” He gestured at her like it was obvious. “What do you think? They don’t talk?”

She shrugged. “I don’t talk to *my* parents.”

“Libby talks to *her* parents, believe me. They will definitely have some questions for her...”

“It’s fine.”

“Everything’s fine with you.”

Chelsea rolled her eyes, looked around the room a moment. “So, just like you told them. You got home early. And *I* was never here.”

He laughed. “They *saw* you Chelsea.”

“Oh, yeah,” she laughed, “okay, I’m here. What’s the big deal?”

“I shouldn’t be with you.”

“Lib’s with Finn...”

“I’m with you *alone* in our house.”

“She’ll be alone with Finn at the hotel, with adjoining rooms. Just one doorknob away from fucking...”

“Wow, that’s a great defense, Chelsea,” he said, sitting hunched, both hands spread on his face, “I’ll let Rich and Bev know so they’ll get a clear picture of how pure and clean their daughter’s marriage is. That’ll make things so much better, I guess, because it’s what—equal?”

With obvious difficulty, Chelsea refrained from laughing and kept a smile mostly in check. “All right, so I’m *here*. What were you gonna tell Lib, anyway? She’d see you’re at home...”

“I’ve been out of the house trying to find places that don’t look like home, but she doesn’t call on time—or, sorry, your *husband* doesn’t call on time *for* her... I put tape on my phone’s camera, I was just gonna say it wasn’t working.”

“If you could just be honest with each other, these levels of deception would be so frivolous. It’s silly, really...”

“I just want to save my marriage, Chelsea. I don’t want Libby to get hurt...”

“She’ll be fine. Finn’s going to take good care of her...”

JUST BEFORE SEVEN O'CLOCK, Chelsea received a series of texts from Finn and relayed their content to Ben.

"Libby's pumped, Ben."

"She is?" he said, jolting out of his reverie. They'd been sitting silently, half the bottle of whiskey depleted. Outside the sun was getting lower in the sky, ripening to a deep succulent orange. It streamed through the windows and got caught on all the edges of the sharp and shiny surfaces in the quaint little beach home for two. "What is she saying?"

"Rattlesnake just played."

"Who's Rattlesnake?"

Chelsea shrugged, eyes still lowered to her phone. "Libby liked them. Finn says they went backstage for a bit, now they're going back out to the front. The VIP section."

"For Dorchester?"

"Dorchester in about five minutes," she said. "I told him to call. Told him you're freaking out."

"I'm not freaking out," he said in a tone that betrayed the message. "I'm *not*... Did you tell him you lied to me?"

"Didn't come up," she said. "He's going to call your phone." She nodded toward where his phone lay dormant on the coffee table next to the bottle.

He leaned forward, collected it; slippery in his sweaty grip.

Chelsea's thumbs were tapping away. She said, "He's calling now—no, *Libby's* calling now..."

Just at that, his phone came to life, and he answered it immediately. The video display of her was slow to come but soon it resolved. And now: Libby's chest, shoulders, and delightful face. The front of her T-shirt hung heavy and loose, probably from dancing and perspiration. He could see the topmost of his wife's cleavage. Her cheeks were alive with exuberant color and her eyes sparkled. He was radiant and happy once again—seeing her that way made everything seem all right.

He gushed when he saw her. “Aw, baby, baby, baby, oh, my God, I hope you’re having a great time...”

She was sandwiching an earbud under a sheaf of her hair, hung heavy with humidity. She said, “Oh, wait... yeah, I can hear you. Hi, baby,” she said now letting go of the earbud and waving till her hand became a blurry smudge.

He said, “Dorchester!” His energy was fake as shit, but high and pumped for the sake of his angel all the way up in Barrie.

She shouted back: “Dorchester!” Her mouth opened wide in a silent scream. “Oh, my God,” she said, “Ben, I’m gonna go backstage and everything...”

“That’s awesome—how was Rattlesnake?”

She was being bumped around as a gang of concert-goers were passing close to her. At least it was quiet now, though he could hear something, feet stomping and clapping hands in the distance as though Lib were sequestered in a hallway. She hunkered forward again with her hand cupped over her ear.

He said, “Your folks were just here.”

“Where?” She frowned an expression that showed she thought she must completely misunderstand him. *He was in Niagara...*

“I just got home. I got home early...”

“What!” She looked joyous. “You did?...”

“Just got home...”

“Ben, come up, come up, baby...”

“I can’t, Lib, it’s too late...”

“Come up now, Ben, come *on*...”

“Dorchester is about to go on, Lib, I’ll miss them, they’ll be off the stage by the time I’m on the 400.”

“Come on and hang out with us, come up, leave right now,” she pleaded with him.

“You’re on your own, I wish I’d known. I’m exhausted, I can’t drive all the way up there, not if I’m going to miss the show. So, hey, I got home your parents were here...”

She showed him her cartoonish expression of disappointed baulking. She wiggled her eyebrows, shaking it all away, knowing her husband was talking sense, and asked, “How are they doing?”

He nonchalantly added: “Chelsea’s here, too.”

Lib darted closer to the camera. “What was that?”

He said, “Chelsea’s here.”

“Here where? In our house?”

There was a changed pitch to her tone, and he recognized a measure of tizz. “With me, we’re waiting to get a phone call from you and Finn. You can pass the phone to him in a second,” he said.

Her brow had grown troubled but smooth. She said, “My parents though, they still there?”

“No, they took off, they were going to go see a movie.”

“So, you’re just there with Chelsea?”

“Yeah, she just got here. She’s going to go after our phone call.”

“Okay,” Lib said, showing a low level of mitigation. “Why don’t you just come up? Come up anyway, meet me at the hotel room...”

He said, “I miss you, but it’s crazy to drive all that way just so we can sleep in the same bed together...”

“I’d like it,” she said and her face sank into forlorn. Then somebody was touching her arm. She said to the camera, “I gotta go, hold on,” then turning, the camera dipping and showing only feet and concrete floor, he heard her calling, “Finn, Finn...”

Then the phone was passed to him, Lib saying, “Your wife’s with my husband...”

THEY ORDERED a pizza and finished off the rest of the Jack Daniels, cutting it now with Coca-Cola. They watched a movie together on their separate couches, not saying anything. It was a horror movie, an independent one filmed in Toronto. Chelsea knew some of the people in production. The movie wasn't very good, Chelsea was good at cutting it to ribbons. At quiet points in the movie, sometimes he would ask her things like, "What are they going to do after the show?"

Chelsea would shrug, say, "I don't know. Finn doesn't have to do any breakdown or anything, you know it's not like that..."

He would give a Whatever shrug.

CHELSEA SAID, “Finn really wants to do this—I imagine he’ll want to get Libby back to the hotel as quick as possible. He’s going to be dying to fuck her.”

Ben hissed, lightly bounced his fists on his knees. It wounded him to hear it. But he knew the release of his guilt would be on the horizon. All he had to do was let this ship sail its course.

At almost 11:40, Finn finally texted. Chelsea’s phone lit up, and she related to Ben what Finn told her.

“Your wife’s freaking out.”

“Why?” He nipped forward eagerly.

“They’re going backstage.”

“How was the concert?”

She smirked at him over her momentarily lowered phone. “Really, Ben, *how was the concert?*”

“Is she having fun?”

She raised her eyebrows but lowered her gaze to the phone. “Finn says Libby had a blast.”

“That’s good,” he muttered.

“Finn’s having a good time, too. He really does like Libby, you know...”

“Okay,” he said, not knowing how to qualify that statement with a response. *Was it good?* On the one hand, sure. At least the guy that was going to tempt her into infidelity *wanted* to be with her. *Would it be better if he just threw her down and pounded into her?*...

And there presented the flip side: what if Libby really liked it? Liked it *because* Finn was into it. The question formed on his lips: is Finn good in



bed? It seemed stupid. Of course he was. That confidence, that charm, the fact that he was with Chelsea fucking Cunningham... Finn was the guy who scored Chelsea Cunningham, got her to marry him. He had to bring something to the table...

His heart rate kicked up a beat, and he rubbed his palms on his knees so they burned. "What's Finn saying?"

"They're going to go backstage and Libby is shitting her little pants right now."

He drew a long inhale, staring off and picturing Lib and how happy she was right now. Happy, but nervous. He wished he could tell her to relax and let it happen. He said, "You know she bought shorts...?"

Chelsea murmured, "I'll let the papers know."

"No, I mean *short* ones."

"Most people buy shorts for just that reason."

"Shorter than what she would normally buy," he said.

Chelsea's eyes were turned to her screen, but he could see it light up the smile that peeled her cheeks back. "Libby, Libby, Libby—I told you, Ben. I bet she's creaming those new shorts she bought just for my husband so she could show off her can..."

He clutched at his stomach. It was confirmed. Chelsea saw it, too. The dark thoughts that had jumped out at Ben seeing Lib in that new clothing. *God, and that sexy pink bra*. This was so wild. The wildest part wasn't the fear but the lust that came behind it. Presented a year ago with a scenario where someone might be coming onto his wife, and that his wife might respond favorably, would've been at once unbelievable and enraging. It would've been something he had to put a stop to. Put his foot down, roll up his sleeves and consider dealing with it man-to-man. Only now here he was letting it happen remotely. Curled up on his couch with his companion—the hottest girl from his high school dreams... This could never have been predicted...

"Yeah," Chelsea said, "they're backstage. Finn's about to introduce her to the band..."

## PART 4

# SHOUT

SUNDAY, JULY 14

FOUR IMAGES of Libby appeared at almost one in the morning. Each one a side-by-side shot with a sweaty handsome member of Dorchester. Cheek to cheek with the drummer, the bassist, that mysterious guy who played lead guitar, and the cute little boy-toy who sang lead. Not such a little boy-toy anymore, Van Waters was the same age as them. Now the lead singer was a handsome twenty-five-year-old talented multimillionaire whose poster used to stare down on Lib from her teenage bedroom wall. Van still had cool hair. And he looked very much like he enjoyed having his cheek pressed up with this flirty little blonde with the cute glasses who appeared backstage. Libby's cute little butt was on display, her shirt tucked into her shorter-than-usual shorts. The neck-hole had stretched, and she was definitely letting some of the guys see the bare northernmost point of her beautiful bosom.

Ben looked at each one, recycled to the beginning and started over, each successive time paying closer attention to every detail. "She looks so... *Happy*."

Chelsea saw it, too. "Yeah, she's happy."

"Bubbling," he said.

Chelsea said, "Imagine if she bangs the band..."

He scoffed. "Not in your wildest dreams."

Her lips slunk into a sleazy smile. "I bet they're in yours..."

He scowled, said, "No. They are *not*."

"You'll let Lib be with Finn, why not one of those hotshots? Bang her in the back of a tour bus, maybe let her ride in his lap behind the wheel of a Ferrari. Libby just swiveling, her little butt going up and down..."

“You paint a picture,” he said.

“Why not, Ben? You let Finn.”

“That’s for a reason.”

She rested her cheek in a palm, staring at him. “We’re still talking about the guilt, right?”

“That’s the reason.”

Chelsea sighed, raised her eyebrows. “I like you, Ben. I didn’t know how it was going to go with you living so close. It’s even better than I thought...”

“It’s worse than I imagined,” he told her.

“You’re gonna tell me it hasn’t been fun? You didn’t like my tongue in your butt?”

He growled, rubbed at his temples.

Chelsea stretched, continued: “Yeah, this whole relationship is taking a life of its own. I like where it’s headed.”

“I can still cancel it.”

“There’s a hundred percent ‘zero’ chance of that. I’d put money on it. Sure, you get rid of your guilt... But I have a feeling there’s a dark curiosity in Ben Todd, Mr. High School Nice Guy—the only thing still left up in the air is how low that angel of a wife of yours wants to fly. If it was up to you I guarantee you’d want her titties scraping the ground.”

“I just want it to be done and over. I don’t want to worry about it anymore, whether it’s going to happen...”

“It’s *going* to happen.”

“Then just happen already...” he said, thrusting his hands toward her phone resting on her long denim thigh. “The waiting is driving me crazy.”

“The first time is gonna be a real trip, Ben. You might want to slow down and enjoy it. You’re going to look back on this night later—and you’d be surprised—but you might even smile...”

“If I make it. My heart rate is already way too high, like seriously, do you have a Fitbit or anything?—something to take my pulse...”

Chelsea laughed. “Seriously, relax, Ben. Tonight is just the beginning...”

HALF AN HOUR LATER, Chelsea gave Ben the horrible news: “Finn says they’re at the hotel now. They’re going up in the elevator.”

He’d been laying on his side, one hand between his knees, the other under his cheek, as his eyes vacantly circumscribed the items on the far side of the room. The TV with its patient Netflix menu, the framed print of Van Gogh’s *Starry Night*, the dead black fireplace, the side table, the lamp, the framed wedding photo, the framed collage pictures on the wall showing when they went to Europe for their honeymoon. Now he was upright, heart pounding.

Chelsea said, “I told Finn to call me and leave the line open.”

“Leave the line open?—what do you mean?”

She scornfully presented the obvious: “So we can listen in...”

“I don’t know,” he muttered.

“Stop me if you want to,” she said, raising her brows as her eyes returned to monitor her screen, acting as if he’d be crazy to.

“I don’t know—it doesn’t matter if I want to or not, it’s Libby’s *privacy*...”

“Libby is your wife and she’s with another man.”

“I know what’s happening, Chelsea. That still doesn’t give me the right to listen in on her.”

She swung her head his way. “Won’t it be a lot easier if you can hear it for yourself? You want to make Finn break it down for you... Or me?”

“I just don’t think it’s right,” he said, crossing his arms then his feet at the ankles, looking sullen to show his disgust to Chelsea—and yet somehow also *not* doing a single thing to stop her.

*You could storm out of the room. Leave her to the nefarious Machiavellian methods she might want to use, but you aren't going to sully your wife in that way. Now, that was a different story last weekend—you sullied all over those two girls...*

The moment between his proclamation of offense to the time when Chelsea's phone rang grew so long and torturous he thought he would burst out screaming before it ended. At last, her phone jangled (another one who kept the ringer way too loud).

"Shit," he said, and thumped the seat at the fright it gave him.

Chelsea shushed him, answered her phone, didn't say a word and set it down on the coffee table between them, face up.

Libby was mid-sentence, saying, "...you doing?"

"Just a sec." Finn's deep voice.

There was an echo as though they were in a narrow space, and he could tell by the footsteps and their breathing that they were walking. *Walking the corridor back to the hotel room...*

Libby said something else, her soft mousy voice too quiet to decipher the words. Finn laughed, said, "Sent Ben and Chelsea good night texts. We'll see if they pop back, but they must be in their beds by now."

Libby made an 'aw' sound, said, "Ben's going to be so mad he missed that show."

"All for a boat..."

"Can you believe it?"

"That's a terrible mistress."

"Hey," Lib comically scolded, and he could tell she'd slapped her hand on his arm.

"A boat, Libby, come on..."

"Don't say things like that..." They both laughed.

Finn said, "You're full of beans still."

"I'm pretty jazzed," Libby said.

It sounded like they rounded a corner, their voices' echo changing in texture.

"I know, I'm wide awake. Watch a movie with me," Finn said.

"I should go to bed."

"Fall asleep while we watch a movie. You're just gonna sit and stare at the ceiling..."

"I know," she laughed, "listening to the ringing in my ears."

“It gets louder in the silence. Trust me, kick back, put a movie on, you’ll be out ten times faster than if you try to lay in bed.”

“It’s *so* late, though. What time are we leaving?”

“Whenever we get up.”

“We don’t have to be out at a certain time?”

“We can sleep in, long as we leave before one, we’re—”

“One in the afternoon?”

Finn laughed, and it sounded like they brushed up against one another. “It’s *already* past one, of course one in the afternoon, who would ask a guest to leave in the middle of the night unless they were too loud or something...”

Libby giggled, Finn chuckled. “Oh, shoot,” Libby sighed. “It’s *so* late...”

“Come on,” he heard Finn say, and now their footsteps stopped. “Come in and have a water, put your feet up. We can watch horror movies until we pass out.”

There was a long silence, then he heard the swipe of a key card, a beep and metallic clack. The door opened. Finn said, “You coming in?”

Another long pause that went on *forever*, then he heard the door close. Nothing had been said. Did Libby go to her room?

Now Finn said, “Put on the TV. I need a drink... you want a water or something more lively?...”

“Fuck, turn it off,” Ben said, and rubbed at his cheeks.

Chelsea said, “It’s just getting good, Ben. I’m not turning it off, why don’t you put your hands over your ears...”

There was no way he would do that. If this lifeline to his wife was open and available, he would cling to it no matter how immoral it might be. There was a whole heap of wrongs, and if he were ever discovered, listening in would be a drop in the bucket of bad he’d done.

He heard the tinny sounds of television voices now. A clatter came that made it seem like Finn’s phone had been put down on a table. Far from the speaker, Libby called out loud, “How do I work this?”

Finn’s voice, also distant: “I’ll be there in a sec.”

More dreadful silence, then the flicker of fresh sounds as the channels were switched. Footsteps came, something was slid, then he could hear Libby say, “I figured it out. What do you want to watch?”

Finn’s deep voice: “I brought you a drink.”



Libby thanked him.

Now there was the sound of Finn sitting down, and Libby was changing channels again.

Libby said something quiet that couldn't be heard. Finn didn't even hear it and asked her to repeat herself. She cleared her throat, said, "I should have changed."

Finn said, "I like what you're wearing..."

FOR A LONG TIME, he and Chelsea sat hunched forward with elbows on knees, eyes staring blankly across the room with their ears practically perked outward to hear *anything* that might happen. Mostly they heard the sounds of a movie. It was an old one, he figured, because of the pervasive creepy organ music. There was the occasional bang, a loud clap, and stiff static ‘fifties’ speak from the leads.

When the moment grew too long and uncomfortable to bear, Ben smirked and whispered to Chelsea, “What movie is that?”

“I have no idea,” she said. “It’s a Hammer, but I don’t know which one...”

They listened in on more of the movie, catching occasional snippets of dialog, listening to the soaring music as action took over. He complained to Chelsea: “There’s nothing happening.”

She shushed him again, got closer to the phone, eyes narrowed. Ben listened too, could hear only the movie, but seeing Chelsea’s focused expression had him imagining he heard more. Maybe there was. Maybe a low sort of grumbling.

He asked Chelsea, “Is that Finn talking?”

“I think so...”

“What’s he saying?”

“I can’t *hear*, Ben. Be quiet...”

Now he could clearly hear Finn say, “Put a pillow there.”

*Put a pillow where?* An obvious, disgusting image jumped out at him: Finn angling a nice armrest pillow under the small of Libby’s back to keep her pelvis tilted at the right angle for his entry.

Then Finn said, "How's that? You comfortable?"

A soft *compliant* murmuring came from his sweet wife. A sleepy high-tone affirmation. She was comfortable. She was at ease and sleepy next to Finn.

Chelsea raised her butt off her couch, swung around and dropped next to him. Now they were side by side, and she tapped her phone's curved corner with an index finger to bring it closer to them.

They listened intently.

More movie. No more voices.

Ben said, "Is it a vampire one?"

Chelsea appreciated the humor, but whispered, "Shut up."

Minutes went by and both of them worried teeth over their lips as they anticipated what was going to happen. Chelsea let out a quick impatient sigh.

"Come *on* already," she insisted.

"This is killing me..."

More movie, more hand-wringing.

"Vampire Circus," Chelsea mumbled.

"It sure is," he agreed, thinking it was some term for a convoluted plot.

"No, Ben, the movie."

"Vampire Circus?"

Chelsea nodded, eyes turned up. "I'm pretty sure."

"Never even heard of it."

There were a few more grumbled snatches of Finn's voice that took their attention. Sometimes Libby would do one of those quiet squeaky Yeahs, like she was telling Finn she enjoyed the movie or something else. *Like the way he was rubbing her feet.* That simple thought sickened him. Those pasty little tootsies were his alone to rub. He could feel their damp cool in his palms' imagination, longed for this to be done and for Libby to be home with him where they could be reunited on the couch and he would assume the wonderful task of rubbing her pretty feet.

Feet bouncing on the floor, a manic energy took over his legs. He listened intently, but his brain grew afraid to hear something he could never *un*-hear. A gasp as she was penetrated. A moan. Libby's soft voice groaning Finn's name...

He wanted to scream, burst out laughing, grab the phone, run quick to his back deck and launch it up into the night. Chelsea would come out

screaming *That's my god damn phone, you idiot!* and he would cackle and collapse on the deck in cushy relief.

"Look, Chelsea, we should—"

She stopped him short. "Listen." It was spoken as a hissed command, urgent and dire. Like an angler who'd got his first nibble after a long biteless afternoon in a boat.

Ben got close to the phone, strained to listen. "I don't hear anything," he said, not really even trying to. *Afraid* to.

"Listen," Chelsea said again and got closer, a smile wanting to form on her pretty mouth.

"Oh, God," he muttered, and she shushed him again.

Both of them got very near, their faces turned toward each other and close enough to feel one another's breath, their ears hovering above the screen of her phone. Chelsea asked him: "Is that *kissing*?—you hear it?"

"No," he said, almost a whimper.

He could hear something. Soft wet mouth noises. Lips smacking, sucking, a low moan.

Now, outrageously, he grew hard in his pants. He gripped and tugged at the fabric of his fly, angry with himself. He clenched his jaw tight, made a wincing face and wasn't afraid to let Chelsea see his pain.

Chelsea nodded, that smile spreading. "They're kissing, Ben..."

A LOUD SMACK NOW, a mouth sound, *two* mouths. They both darted ears closer to the phone. Someone was moving. Fabric on leather, that embarrassing flatulent sound. Ruffled clothing. Then Finn's voice: "Where you going?"

Libby, voice high and tense but still airy soft: "I have to go."

Finn said, "Don't go, Lib..."

Lib: "It's late..."

More sounds of movement, and now Finn and Libby were coming closer to the microphone, their voices getting louder. Like Finn had placed the phone on a table right behind the couch, and now they were standing beside it.

There was a soft squeaking sound, more cotton blurting against leather. Finn said, "Hey, come here," kindly and encouraging.

Libby said, "I've got to go..." Her voice was quiet and sullen and not as insistent or demanding as Ben would like her to be.

Finn said, "You can go, Lib, if you want, but would you come here first, please?..." There was a hand-patting sound like Finn had encouraged Lib to come by clapping a hand on his thigh. Ben could picture them now, maybe Finn sitting on a stool, very near the side table where his phone sat, Libby with her lips pouted, her brow lowered, both hands tucked into her armpits. His heart *ached* for her. The struggle she must feel, the conflict, the trauma... the *lure*...

There was another sound of moving fabric, and Finn said, "I had so much fun with you today, Libby..."

Then, almost equidistant, Libby's voice: "I had fun too."

Their voices were close together—Libby had joined Finn at his demand. They'd been kissing, she knew she had to go, but Finn could lure her back. Ben could picture Finn on that stool, his knees out, Libby standing huddled and afraid between his thighs. Maybe Finn would put a hand on her back...

"God," he hissed, and straightened on the couch, writhing in pain as though he had a cramp.

"It's getting good, get back here," Chelsea urged him.

"I need to turn it off," he insisted quietly. But again, he made no move to extinguish the bad news coming across 4G.

Finn said to Libby, "I'm so glad you came with me this weekend."

Lib took a long moment before answering. "Thank you for everything you did, Finn."

"You made it fun, I would've been bored out of my mind if you weren't here with me."

"I'm glad."

A soft sound, lips on skin. *Finn kissing Libby's neck?* Libby made a soft sound in her throat, a complaint, but not an insistent one. Now there was a stroking sound, hand on an arm maybe. Finn: "Don't go."

There was another muttered complaint from Libby, this one more decided than the first. But still not final.

Finn said, "I'm sorry... I can't help myself..."

"It's okay," Libby squeaked.

Finn, lower and slower: "I think about you so much."

"No, you don't..."

"You're so awesome, Lib..."

"Don't..."

More movement, a smoothing of flesh over flesh—*Finn's hand stroking Lib's upper arm?*

Finn's voice, practically a whisper: "I loved dancing with you."

"It was fun."

Another long dreadful silence, then Finn confessed: "I think about you... Do you ever think about me?"

Libby didn't answer, but there was a blubbing noise.

Finn said hopefully: "You do?"

No words, but Ben could picture Libby nodding her chin as unnoticeably as she could.

"You make me so hard," Finn said.

Libby made a soft sort of gasping noise.

“You do. You’re so hot...”

“I am?”

“You’ve been driving me crazy this last week, I’ve been going out of my mind...”

“For me?”

Rustling fabric (*an embrace?*), then Finn said, “I couldn’t wait to be alone with you this weekend...”

“Oh, God...”

“Alone with you tonight...”

Lib’s breathy protest: “We can’t...”

“Sorry, Lib, I can’t help how you make me feel...”

Another blubbery noise, farther away, Libby had retreated. Ben was at once happy and forlorn.

Finn said, “Come back, Libby, come here, please...”

Libby’s words were timid and faltering, but she pronounced clearly: “I... thought... about... you...”

“I swear, Lib, I couldn’t wait for this weekend, for tonight, the whole time you were on my bike and you had your arms around me I was dying...”

Libby whimpered.

Finn continued, “You drive me crazy, you make me so wild...”

“I’m married...”

“God,” Finn said, surprised almost, like he was talking to himself rather than Lib, “just talking like this, letting it out... I’d do anything for you, to be with you...”

“No...”

A sharp brisk sound of fabric (Did Finn clutch himself to her?) Finn’s voice was low, a grumble, a masculine and proud proclamation: “Libby, you make me so, so *hard*...”

Another gasp. Bright and surprised air whisking over Lib’s palette into her cheery pink and innocent lungs. A man presenting to Libby the status of his sexual arousal was an affront of the *highest* order. Ben raised his shoulders to protect his ears in anticipation of the harsh wet smack that would be delivered across Finn’s cheek. *How dare you*, Libby would roar, *I have no need to know the state of your genitalia...*

Libby said something soft, but her mouth was thick with saliva. She was filled with emotions, Ben could hear it.

When Lib said nothing more, Finn prompted her. “It is, Lib. It’s so hard for you right now.”

*Way too much, Finn, this doesn’t work on my Libby...*

Chelsea’s eyes widened, waiting for every juicy word now that things had got good.

More rustling fabric and it enraged him because he wanted to hear more words.

A soft smack, a kiss. Finn kissing Lib’s neck? Breaths came heavier now, and Ben could hear Libby’s passion deepening. It made his brow crease, and a tortured expression pinched his features. “No...”

“Oh, yes, Ben, it’s happening,” Chelsea said, poking his upper arm.

A popping mouth sound now, a sucking preemptively pulled free. The fabric sound ceased, the moment went quiet, and it drew Ben and Chelsea closer.

Libby’s timid voice now: “What... Wait, what is that?—it’s not...?”

“My dick...”

Chelsea gasped and clutched Ben’s knee and he jumped.

“No, no, no,” Ben whispered, “shut it off, shut it off...”

Libby said, “That’s not your dick...”

Finn, reassuring: “Sure it is.”

“No...”

A quiet moment, then Finn, quieter: “You want to touch it?”

Libby’s breathy gasp: “No...”

Chelsea dug her nails into his knee with an attempt to control her boiling-over excitement. She triumphantly whispered, “He’s showing her his dick, Ben!” Her lips had peeled back from her teeth.



FINN SAID, “Do you want to see it?”

Chelsea exhaled, “Ho, come *on*, come *on*...”

Libby was confused: “But... it’s not, it can’t be...”

Chelsea’s face was wide with joy, and she clutched her hair, wide-eyeing him, saying, “This is too good, this is *too* good...”

Finn asked Lib: “Because it’s big?”

Libby in a quick chuckling exhale: “It’s really big.”

Finn asked her: “You’ve never been with a man who has a large penis?”

Chelsea collapsed into the couch in exaltation, but rebounded quickly, stomping back into place next to Ben, hunched over and listening.

Libby said, “I’ve only been with Ben.”

Chelsea whispered, “*Bullshit.*”

Finn asked Libby, “In your whole life, only with Ben?”

Libby agreed, “Uh-huh.”

“And his isn’t like this?”

Ben had begun to hyperventilate, and he clutched his chest. He caught Chelsea watching his look of pain and she laughed at him silently.

Libby said, “No...”

Chelsea shot him a sympathetic look, acknowledging how these words must affect him.

Finn asked Libby, “How much bigger is mine?”

Chelsea cupped a hand over her mouth, her eyes alive with jollity.

Libby, falteringly: “I don’t know...”

Ben made to grab Chelsea’s phone, wishing he’d earlier launched it up into orbit and avoided details he didn’t want to know. Chelsea was quicker,

grabbing at his hands and digging her nails into his skin. She hissed near his ear: “I will fucking kill you, Ben.”

“I don’t want to hear anymore.” His voice was high and warbling with pain and sadness.

Chelsea wrestled the phone from him and set it back on the table. “Plug your ears or go upstairs,” she said, looking him in the eye. “I want to hear this.”

Ben buried his face in his hands but stayed put. He hunched forward like he had a stomachache.

Finn said now, “Can I take it out?”

“What?—*no*,” Libby laughed, which was the answer he wanted to hear, but it still hurt that she hadn’t fled Finn’s hotel room altogether.

Libby said, “I don’t want to see it.”

“Are you sure?”

“I’m sure.”

Chelsea ran her tongue over her lip, easing closer.

Finn asked, “Is Ben’s, like, this long?...”

“No.”

Ben reached for the phone again and Chelsea grabbed his wrist hard, holding him with a surprising grip.

Finn asked, “Shorter?”

“Ah, fuck,” Ben hissed, bewildered how voices heard on a phone could provoke real and powerful pain in him.

Libby said, “Yes.”

Chelsea’s face peeled back in a silent gleeful howl, her mouth shaped in an O.

Finn asked, “Like this?”

Libby: “I don’t know...”

“Show me with your finger, Lib. Show me where Ben’s stops.”

Chelsea drew a short quick breath and patted his arm rapidly. There was still time to flee, time to escape what would be hurtful, but he remained in place, practically hugging his knees now, head lowered near the table.

There was a long silence, and he thought maybe the call had been disconnected, but then could still faintly hear the TV, though it sounded like someone had turned its volume down. Chelsea got close with him, showing him a puzzled face as they both wondered what was happening. There was movement now, the sound of something against denim.

Finn said, "There?"

Libby: "Uh-huh."

Then more silence that got Ben and Chelsea straining, getting low. There was swishing fabric sound again. It continued for a few moments but no one said anything. Finn and Lib's breaths were deep and slow.

Finn said in luxurious pleasure, "That feels good..."

Ben clutched his thighs together, found a surprising hardness between his legs. Chelsea got in his face and silently mouthed: *She's fucking jerking him off...*

Libby said, "I should go," and the sounds stopped.

Finn said, "No, no, put your hand back..."

"I can't."

The silence was ripped in two by the obvious dragging sound of Finn's fly being drawn down.

"Here it comes," Chelsea said, biting her lower lip and staring at him.

"Stop, stop, I can't take it," he said, put his hands near his ears as if he would cover them, but wouldn't commit.

"He's taking his dick out for her, Ben," Chelsea said. "He's going to fuck her right here..."

"Shut up, Chelsea," he said.

There was movement in Barrie, sounds of fabric, maybe the phone being jostled. He could imagine Finn snatching it up so he could bring it to the bedroom so he and Chelsea could listen in while he fucked Libby with his big dick.

Chelsea almost squealed with glee, sitting upright, raising her knees up for a moment, whispering, "It's happening, Ben, it... is... *happening...*"

Finn had said something but Chelsea's glee had drowned it out; and Libby had made a high sound, too...

"Shut up, Chelsea," he hissed, his face pinched in a tight scowl as his eyes burned on this evil device on the table. "I missed what she said. What did she say?..."

"I think her mouth was full."

"Shut *up*," he said again, more urgent this time. He leaned closer, turned his ear toward the phone. There was silence. No TV noise, no nothing. "I don't hear anything."

Chelsea got close, said, "What's happening?"

"You fucking talked over them," he scolded her.

“Oh, Ben, it is totally happening, totally, *totally* happening...” She seemed excited, her eyes bright, voice breathy.

“Oh, my God,” he said, and clutched at the hair above his ears. He squatted lower, his face just inches away from the phone. His ears strained to pick up the slightest sound but there was nothing. “What do you think’s happening?” he said to Chelsea, turning his eyes up. The instant look of strange compassion on her face made him realize how pathetic he must look now: Hovered over her phone, listening to his wife cheat on him. He was on the verge of crying, could feel his eyes swelling out of their sockets. His heart went off in his chest like a staccato machine gun. This was what he wanted and now he was getting it. Somehow, somewhere along the way, he’d been convinced this would be what saved his marriage...

He looked at that face smiling down on him, this evil Mother Teresa reaching out now to stroke his shoulder. “You fucking did this,” he said.

“It’s all you, Ben,” she said, her tone even, almost kind.

“I can’t believe it,” he said, sitting back from the phone. He stayed near, his forearms over his knees. It was hard to breathe. His cock was like a steel bar in his pants.

“They must’ve gone to the bedroom,” Chelsea said now, getting close.

She stayed there, her ear hovered over the phone, her eyes moving around, sometimes meeting his for a second, the corner of her mouth curled in an expectant smile, waiting to hear a gasp of pleasure as Finn sunk his large cock inside Libby.

“Can I still stop it?” His voice was dry and timid, one spark could set a forest fire.

“Why, Ben?—it’s done. It was a lot harder to get here than I thought, but we’re here now.”

He touched the tip of his tongue to the top of his lip, trying to form the command: *Tell her not to do it...*

...then he jolted as a fast-busy signal buzzed loud from Chelsea’s phone. The call had been disconnected. Chelsea winced and darted her head back. She swept up her phone and closed it off.

Phone tossed behind her, Chelsea slunk her lean body against his. She purred, “Right now your wife is taking Finn’s cock.” She gripped his knee.

He licked his lips, stared across the room. “It’s big?”

“Oh, Ben,” she laughed. “The biggest. Why do you think all my friends want to sleep with him?”

“My Libby...”

“She’s having the night of her life right now, Ben, I can guaran-fucking-tee it. She’s got those short little legs up around my husband’s hips and he is giving her the deep-dick-thrill of a lifetime, lucky Libby.”

“How big?”

She gave him a firm karate chop in the middle of his thigh, proclaimed, “Big, my friend,” then got close and nibbled on his earlobe. “It’s done, Ben. Shouldn’t you be thanking me?”

“This is a big mistake.”

“Are you sure?” Chelsea’s hand drifted up the inside of his pant leg, settled between his thighs. He didn’t resist her, could feel the heel of her wrist grinding against the belly of his rock hard erection. He groaned and humped his hips against her.

“This is a whole new day, Ben, a whole new day.” Her fingers fumbled around, she worked down his zipper.

“I can’t believe Libby’s doing this.”

“We got her to the stream, all she had to do was drink.” Chelsea had both hands now undoing the top button of his shorts, yanking open his fly. She got close, reminding him in a breathy imitation of his wife, “Oh my goodness, Finn, you have such a big cock...”

“She didn’t say that.”

Chelsea smiled, looking at the side of his face. “What did she say?”

“It’s really big,” he said, mousy, just like Lib.

Chelsea whispered in his ear, “It’s really big, Finn,” her fingertips going over the shape of his cock underneath his boxer shorts. “I’ve never seen a big cock before...”

Ben groaned, shut his eyes off.

Chelsea said, “Let me just touch it, Finn, Ben’s isn’t like this at all...”

“Fuck off,” he groaned, but stayed immobile, arms heavy at his sides, Chelsea’s delicate touch over his cotton-shrouded erection feeling like sin, and the badness of his wife sponsoring a deep and awful ache in his testicles.

Chelsea giggled, then her two hands worked apart his fly, pushed it down so that his cock stuck straight out and bare from between his legs. It was desperate to feel contact and trickled lubricant. She said, “And here’s the good news, Ben,” then disappeared from his vision, her head sinking

into his lap. Her mouth closed around his cock and he let out a long mournful sigh. It *was* somehow good news despite the hurt in his heart...

While her head went up and down in his lap, delivering him the most heavenly pleasure from her artful mouth, he pushed knuckles into his eye sockets until all he saw was fiery blood red. It still couldn't blot out the images. His Libby standing there, Finn with his legs open, Ben and Libby discovering together that the neighbor who she was going to cheat on him with had a huge penis. His poor Libby, his poor inexperienced girl, caught up in some devious spiderweb that he'd helped create. His sticky little spider legs had joined some of those threads together—or maybe he was the fucking spider food, too...

"Shit," he shouted, and his hands came down, grabbed Chelsea's hair. He held it in shaking fists, then cupped his fingers around the pretty globe of her little skull and fucked her mouth.

The words repeated in his head: *And his isn't like this?....No....How big is Ben's, show me on mine with your finger...* and Libby did.

He roared and blew a whole days worth of pent-up lust into her yawning mouth. Chelsea blurted and laughed, coughed, gagged. But he held her head still until he'd pulsed every last bit into her.

When he was done, she elbowed his hand away, sat up laughing. She'd swallowed most of it, but a jiggling thread connected her top lip to her lower lip, and his semen dripped off the point of her chin. "That's it, Ben, now you get it," she said encouragingly, then fell against him, wiping her mouth and neck and cheeks on the sleeve of his shirt.

He panted. His cock—the one much smaller than his wife was getting railed with right now—still hard, poked up out of his fly, leaning to one side and dangling a fishing line of his seed. "I can't believe this," he said.

"It's done, Ben, it's done, and now we're going upstairs to celebrate..."

CHELSEA CLIMBED on top of him in the bed he shared with Libby. “I’m so horny, Ben,” she said, “I’m going to scratch your skin off like a bitch cat in heat. God, I have to fuck, have to, *have to...*”

His jaw and brow ached as they resisted the sobbing sadness that wanted to tear him down, leave him a hump of a broken man on the bedroom floor. A cold meanness settled in his frontal lobe and his hands moved on their own and seized her hips.

Chelsea wore a loose T-shirt with Mötley Crue on it. The neck hole had been cut wider with scissors and it hung off one tanned shoulder. The turquoise string of her bra top crossed over her collarbone. Big hair, glam metal faces sneered at him, emblazoned below them the name of the tour in 1983, and also a sagacious command: Shout At The Devil. On his back looking up, Chelsea straddling on her knees, he could see beneath her shirt. Her belly was hard and flat and tanned. She was beautiful, her body drool-worthy, all taut curves and screaming sex. He could see her tits resting in the cotton triangles of her bikini top.

Hips driving up with force, he bucked her off him and she toppled to the bed at his side. Quick and aggressive he was over top off her, pulling up her shirt and exposing her breasts. One of the cups had gone askew and her rubbery nipple poked out, brown and aroused. Chelsea struggled her arms over her head, yanked them out of the shirt’s sleeves but he kept it over her face. The fabric was gathered in a clump behind her head, held in his fist, the pretty features of her Scream Queen face jutting out the black cotton; her mouth was open, her breaths came lusty, her chest rising and falling, the covered nipple humping out against turquoise constraint. With the knot of

T-shirt clenched tight, the threadbare fabric stretched over her face, he grabbed her pussy over the denim. He was rough with it, beating on it, tearing his fingers over her damp sex, warm through her jeans. Her breath came in gasps through her open mouth held in an O, the cotton forming a trampoline over the gap. He bit her chin, shoved his hand under her jeans. No underwear, just shaved perfect pussy that was eager to greet him. He twiddled his fingers hard through her membranes, then stiffened his arm and strummed. A wet and sticky sound built and Chelsea arched her back and croaked. He jazzed her pussy until his triceps cramped, then curled two fingers inside her and bit on that long graceful neck. It brought a gasp from Chelsea and she raised her knees up, bumping his shoulder, but allowing him to dig deeper inside her.

“Oh, ho, Ben,” she purred, “somebody’s mad at me...”

His hand came out wet, and he unbuttoned her jeans, pulled them down to her knees. Chelsea writhed on the bed, long arms grabbing at the sheets, that one perfect brown nipple peeping at him, her ribs and stomach muscles undulating against her bronze skin. On top of her again, he tore away her bikini, and her breasts jiggled and bounced; she inhaled sharply, liking it.

“You gonna beat me up?” Her voice was breathy and encouraging from behind the shroud of her shirt. Like she *wanted* to get beat up.

Then his mouth went over a nipple, the prefatory one, sucked it hard, rushing all the blood to the surface of the skin. Chelsea moved gracefully under him, her long fingers dragging long nails over his shoulders, the whole while blindfolded by her shirt.

“Choke me,” she gasped in a whisper.

He growled, bit at the other nipple while his hands undid his fly.

First, one hand closed around that long elegant neck. When she smiled, he slipped the V of thumb and fingers of the other hand underneath the first hand, and slowly squeezed. Veins rose against the skin, and Chelsea responded like she liked it. The grace and beauty of that thin neck of hers was astounding, and in context of the brutality of closing his hands around it was wild and outrageous. Chelsea was almost like another being, *better* than human. Perfectly proportioned, gorgeous face, long graceful limbs, flawless skin—but inside that skull was an evil brain. He closed his hands a little tighter as a little chuckle escaped her lips and he closed off her airway. Soon as it was done, he let go; she laughed at him.



“You choke like a girl, Benji,” she said, reached up and lightly swatted at his face.

“You’re such a bitch,” he said.

“And you don’t have that killer instinct... those soft hands couldn’t—”

“Shut up, Chelsea, I have to stuff my cock in your mouth to stop you?”

“Just fucking give it to me, Ben,” she said, sneering, confident, sexual, and even hidden by her shirt, frightening. Her hips pushed up, grinding her wet pussy into his hard cock, the slippery feel of her sex astounding and overwhelming.

With her flat on her back but her knees to one side—haunch, ass, and pussy bared—he got over her again. Her cowboy boots scissored on the bedding and she taunted him still: “Don’t tell me you went soft, Benjamin...”

He jammed the back of her thigh with a knee, exposing her slit, closed his hands around her neck, caressed her, squeezed, released, caressed, took her cotton-covered mouth in a kiss as he aimed his hips. The spear-point of his erection found her hot wet opening and he pushed himself inside her all the way until his pubic hair scratched at the soft shaved shapes of her mound. She breathed a lusty exhale into his mouth and he started to pound her. The more he pounded, the more she responded.

“Fuck me like that, Ben,” she shouted, “fuck me hard,” then bit at his neck, teeth tearing her own shirt.

He pushed at her face, said, “Don’t leave any marks on me.”

Through the shirt, her soft lips moved, visible now in a small oval tear: “Why not, Ben?—the jig is up. Finn’s going to leave his mark all *over* your wife, trust me...”

“Shut up...”

“She’ll never be the same, Ben...”

Now he grabbed her wrists, held them up over her head, speared deep, pushing with his toes until her pelvis tilted, getting his length as deep inside her as he could. She loved it, loved it but laughed.

“That’s it. That’s it, Ben... Ben Todd doesn’t know how good he can fuck...”

“Shut your mouth...”

“He’s finding out...”

“Shut up, Chelsea...”

“Libby’s finding out, too... Libby’s finding out all about *other* men...  
She likes *other* men...”

HE WITHDREW, gripped her upper arm, rolled her so she was face down and flat on the bed. He got over her back, legs closed between his. The point of his erection pushed into her ass crack; he took a hand to wiggle it around until he found her asshole, then he slipped inside that. Chelsea kicked her legs behind him, laughing and sighing.

“Libby’s finding out *all* about what other men can do...”

“You’re such a bitch,” he said

“That the best you can do?” She laughed, “You need better lines, Ben... you know you have to cozy up to the producer...”

“How are you so awful?”

“You fucking love it, you toad, now fuck my ass...”

He crushed his weight over top of her, wanting to suffocate her in his bed sheets while he pounded her ass with his rock hard cock. He got the headboard banging louder than it ever had before. He gave Chelsea everything. And finally, he was getting the response he wanted. She grew sweaty, her breaths long and airy. She gasped; he pounded his dick as deep into her as he could.

“Yes, yes, yes,” she started to chant, and he slipped his forearm around her neck, closing her head in the V of his arm.

“Fucking choke me, you weakling...”

“Shut up,” he said again but she only laughed.

Now he was swatting her ass, one arm around her neck, the other slapping an ass cheek, his cock driving fully in and out of her rectum.

And he was done. Done with Chelsea. He pulled out, jerked himself furiously onto the small of her back. She giggled menacingly at the wet feel

of it on her skin, cooing and laughing. He squeezed it all out of him, all his badness flowing out of his balls, signing his pearly signature on her lower back.

Now he was panting, suspended above her on one hand, his other gently squeezing and stroking his erection. He was disgusted with her. Disgusted with himself. And an hour and a half north of here, he wondered what Finn was doing to Libby, and wondered if would be anywhere near as bad as the things he'd done and wanted to do to Chelsea.

He collapsed next to her on the bed, staring up at the ceiling, feeling like it was all coming to an end.

Chelsea chuckled, her thin hand coming to draw away the T-shirt from her face. Face sideways on the pillow she smiled at him.

"Not bad, Ben, not bad at all. I had a mini ass-orgasm there."

Now he coughed an actual chuckle, turned his face to hers. He smiled seeing her beauty, but it faded. "He's not going to choke her, is he?"

"He will if she wants it."

He looked up to the ceiling again. "She wouldn't want that."

Chelsea cackled and her knees darted up to thump his thigh. "You thought she wouldn't go for it at *all*, you thought Finn would never get her in bed... One look at that dick..."

He admitted to her his greatest fear: "I think she really likes him."

"He likes her."

"That doesn't worry you?"

"Finn likes all my friends he fucks. He's not running off with your city mouse."

"I hope he's good to her."

"He'll be good, Ben. Serious. He'll make her come a dozen times, do things she didn't know were possible. He'll fucking cuddle with her if she wants it, that madman." She chuckled again. "He'll buy her breakfast in the morning, and your dopey bride *will* probably fall in love with him."

"No, she won't."

"Right, cool guy, makes good money, hot, *hot* body, killer eyes, killer ass, giant dick, she's *already* got a crush on him, he fucks her six ways from Sunday, comes in her little corn hole and she never, ever thought she'd like that, but Sweet Jesus, when he did, it put a little flutter in her tummy... she'll be drumming on her little bean thinking of her night with him, you laying where you are right now, sleeping and oblivious."

He turned his head on the pillow and looked at her evil face. It amused her to torture him like this; she was enjoying it, he could see the sparkle there. "Why are you so bad?"

"Everyone loves a bad girl, Ben," she said and smiled.

They looked at each other for a long while in the quiet room. She said, "You're the one that likes to choke innocent girls."

"I liked choking you. And you're not innocent."

"Want to choke me again?"

They connected eyes, both of them expressionless and blinking. It was a lure. "You're going to pretend you died, aren't you? Freak me out..."

She held the straight face as long as she could, then snorted in her throat and exploded in cachinnation. He admired her row of perfect movie star teeth and chuckled a little too. "You were going to, right?"

She steadied her sexy eyes on him, said, "Choke me and find out."

He looked away; looking in her eyes would have him making mistakes again. He said, "You don't care he's having sex with Libby?"

"I love watching Finn fuck a girl. I love the way the muscles of his back squirm, love his ass, oh, my God, he has the hottest ass. Then it's the girl... what's her reaction to him? I watch her face to see how she responds to his size. They're all different."

"Is his size...? Is it really big?"

"Ten. Thick. Inches."

He groaned, made a disgusted cluck of his tongue.

Chelsea chuckled air through her nostrils. "You're going to have a new woman limp through your front door tomorrow..."

He chewed on the inner lining below his bottom lip, grimacing, wondering what his wife would think of sex with Finn. What would Lib think having sex with a man who could do it better, and had better equipment on a better chassis?

Chelsea read his mind, whispering, "He's fucking her right now..."

"Stop..."

"He is, Ben, he's fucking her hard, making her scream..."

"Lib doesn't scream..."

"Finn'll make her scream, Finn'll *make* her..."

He grunted, rolled his eyes at her, made sure his display of disdain wasn't hidden from her.

She giggled softly, then her hand crept over. "Uh-oh, Ben, what do we have here?"

The feel of her hand on his dick made his stomach bounce.

"Libby's husband's got a boner thinking about his wife getting it better than ever before."

"No, I'm not..."

"Ben, I've been laying here looking at your dick, it went rubber, now it's rock again. No biggie, ninety percent of my friends' boyfriends get off on it in some way when their girl's with Finn. It's usually the sounds they make..."

Now she was pushing her jeans down over her knees and working her boots off with her heels.

"Don't..."

"Don't what, Ben? Fuck you? Let me sit on this..."

He put his hand down and held her wrist. "Stop."

"Right..."

"I'm serious. You need to leave."

"You don't want to fuck all night?"

"No."

She laughed. "Oh, Big Shot."

"Pull your pants up and get out of here."

Her humor dissipated. The smile on her face stayed the same but her eyes chilled to cold stones.

"I thought it would be fun, Finn and Lib come home, maybe join us in bed. You got other plans, good for you." She pulled her jeans up and buttoned them, sat up, turned her shirt right-side out. He watched her sexy bare back, the profile of her teardrop breast pointed still with a hard nipple. She stretched the shirt over her body, pulling and adjusting, saying, "If Lib tells you she has a tummy ache tomorrow, tell her to take one or two aspirin. It can help her stretched-out little kitty cat."

"I'll let her know."

She looked over her shoulder, sexy half a face, caramel locks tumbling over a cheek and shoulder. "Poor girl, downside of the first time you experience the joy of a big dick is the next morning, God, then having to ride home on a motorcycle...?"

"You can go now, Chelsea."

She turned her face up and laughed loud. “You’re a riot, Ben. Listen, it’s been a blast.” She stood up, stomped her heels in her boots so they fit better, not an ounce of fat jiggling, her braless breasts swaying under Mötley Crue.

She snapped up her bikini top, tucked it in a ball and shoved it in her tight back pocket. “Call me tomorrow, okay? You know you’re going to...”

He met her gaze, tried to be strong. “Good night, Chelsea.”

She looked at his erection again, smiled a wide sneer. “Good night, Ben. Sleep tight...”

## PART 5



HOME GIRL

IT WAS UNEXPECTED, but just before lunchtime he masturbated. Apparently he didn't get enough last night.

The morning had been spent scrubbing the bedroom of Chelsea's existence. Bedsheets were changed, the old ones in the laundry gone through a wash cycle and now in the dryer. He even got down on his hands and knees on the bedroom floor looking for a strand of hair. Even if he found one, the argument could be made that it was Libby's. Libby was blonder, silkier, but a single strand of hair...? The detective work kept him busy, kept his mind on a task.

No word at all from Finn, Chelsea, or Libby since last night. But, if Libby and Finn were up until two in the morning, fucking for who knows how long, and after a long day at the concert, too...? They could still be in bed.

And even that image brought as much pain as thinking of Libby with Finn between her legs, his ass going up and down like his cock was drilling for oil in Libby's tight shaft. Just the simple image of sunlight coming in sideways through the hotel window, the bedsheets tossed around, Finn on his back, sleeping, one hand behind his head, the other around Libby's shoulder; Libby snuggled right up to him. Both of them naked, Libby's precious cheek planted on Finn's hard chest. Only, Libby was awake. Listening to her lover's heartbeat but thinking of her husband at home. Thinking of the bad she'd done and wondering how it had come to this. That's what'd got him in the bathroom, frantically pounding his own meat.

It surprised him. Sitting on the toilet stroking a sudden midday erection and he wasn't thinking about how he fucked the hottest girl in his high

school last night. About all the dirty things he did, about how slender her throat felt under his grip as he gently squeezed off her air supply as he plowed into her. He didn't think of Chelsea at all. What got him off sitting on the toilet were images of his wife and Finn together. What was it like for Lib? Did Finn really make her scream? Did she come? How many times did they do it? What was it like taking another man? And was Finn's penis really as big as Chelsea said? You couldn't believe anything Chelsea told you, but he *had* heard it from his own wife's mouth: *that can't be your penis... Why?... It's too big...*

He had two showers today. One when he woke up and before he began his crime scene cleanup. Then again after he'd masturbated. All traces of whiskey and all traces of Chelsea hopefully washed away. And his sin not scrubbed clean but somehow made equal. Something un-washable you could make appear whole again by dirtying it the same amount. That's right, they were both dirty now.

AT LAST, at one-thirty, message finally came.

**Finn:** leaving Barrie now

Ben texted in return, fishing for some info. No reply came. It was a good chance it was Finn who'd sent the message. Probably with his ass already on the bike, Libby clung to his back, her hands at liberty now to stroke all over his body. They *were* lovers. And poor Lib's pussy. Getting hammered all the way home, having to sit squashed up against Chelsea's husband while the buzz of the bike vibrated against her happy but injured sex. *Shit*, here it came again. He was gripping a new erection through his shorts.

The idea had come to him many times to text Chelsea. Call her. Ask her what Finn had said. But it was useless. He'd snubbed her last night and as good as it felt in the moment, he knew he would pay for it somehow. Chelsea held a grudge. Anything he asked her today would bring a dubious answer. She would find joy in telling him all the awful things Finn and Libby had done last night. Elaborate wild schemes involving Libby being suspended by leather straps from the ceiling while Finn and the entire Dorchester band took their turns with her tied open legs. *Oh, and Ben, how Libby loved it!* She might tell him Finn and Lib weren't coming home. They're going to stay another night. They're going to try to fuck their way right through a hotel bed. Have to call down to the lobby and tell them to send up a new bed, they fucked that one to pieces.

Or she could tell him nothing happened. He wouldn't believe that either. That would just be Chelsea's way of making his imagination work overtime. Let him feel pretend-happy for a few hours, marinating in worry, let him rest in the cushion of peace, and when Lib gets home, ka-pow. *What! You fucked Finn!?* Chelsea would rub her hands together and cackle. It was a waste of time to ask her anything. And he wouldn't text Finn now. What was the point? He was on the bike. He hadn't answered the other one, he wouldn't answer now. So he stewed.

Barrie was maybe an hour and a half away. With traffic it might be two hours before his wife got dropped off home. He sat in the front room watching out at the street and waiting. The lack of action got his mind wandering again. Every time he thought of Chelsea he grumbled. Every time he thought of Libby and Finn together he grew aroused. He had to plant a cushion over his lap to keep his mind off touching it. *What was so damn arousing about this?*

Three hours had passed, and he groaned with worry. All the thoughts of Finn and Libby writhing around in ecstasy in a Barrie hotel bed were extinguished. Now he was making fists then forcing his hands to relax, pacing around the first floor of the house thinking of flashing lights, the highway blocked off... Tragic Accident, Tattooed Man Loses Control Of Bike the headlines would read. Police would call him, he'd have to go down to the hospital to ID her...

Then a sorry sight appeared, peering through the sheer curtains in the front room looking out on their street. He'd expected a motorcycle to pull up out front, Libby clutched to Finn's back, gently easing herself off the bike (favoring her sore little pussy), taking the backpack off, hugging Finn but trying not to let her husband in on the big secret. *But he'd been in on the big secret for a long time. In many ways, he was the big secret...*

Then Lib would limp up to the front stoop, smiling and waving at him with manufactured innocence. Behind Libby's back Finn would give Ben a good old thumbs up. *It's done, Ben, make you happy? I don't even know, man, I don't even know...*

But here, strolling down their street, was a tired-looking little figure. His beautiful Libby who he'd known for fifteen years and been in love with for such a long time. She looked worn out; shoulders stooped, gait slow. She wore her short shorts, the black ones she'd left in. She wore a new T-shirt. A black one, and from here he could read *Dorchester* across it. Her

bare little legs worked at walking along the street in the shade of the maple trees. In one hand she held a canvas shopping bag, a green one, Our Compliments on the side. Her dirty laundry, he imagined. *Her cum-stained underwear...*

He was out the door fast, beating down the driveway with bare feet, the scorching asphalt stinging him. He stepped off onto the grass, met her eyes as she was crossing the street. "Libby," he shouted.

Her chin tilted up, and she gave him a squinting smile, her blonde hair hanging limp astride her angel face. He trotted to the curb and held his hand out to her, she stepped up and he pulled. They combined themselves at the edge of their property, his arms around her shoulders, hers around his waist, shopping bag tapping his calves.

He asked, "What are you doing?"

Still held in his embrace, she said, "What do you mean?"

"Finn didn't drop you off?"

She rocked with him, said, "No, I had all those things on my back, I had to get my stuff out of the bag, then he'd have to drive over a street with the extra helmet..."

"Didn't he want to bring you home?"

"I told him not to," she said.

He set her back from him, his hands on her warm shoulders. "I missed you so much," he said.

"I missed you too, Ben, I missed you..." Her voice trailed off to quiet, and her chin dimpled, sadness passed over her eyes and he hated to see her like that. He hugged her again, harder this time.

"God," he sighed, "I didn't know it would be so hard to be without you..."

The point of her chin nodded against his chest. He held her away again to look at her. There was so much going on behind those eyes. There was a tangible wall between them. She'd fucked Finn, and she didn't know how to tell him. She would have to tell him sometime, that was the whole point. They could share, repair. He didn't want her to suffer, he was eager to let her know that it was okay. But he dreaded having to face his own truth. *But it would be Libby first...*

He said, "Come on inside, tell me all about the concert..."

"I think I need a nap," she said as he took her hand and squeezed his fingers between hers. Her little hand was hot and damp and weak. Her

enervation frightened him for a moment. What if was more than her infidelity weakening her? She'd just come from Finn and Chelsea's house. What if Chelsea told her the truth? Chelsea would love that. Absolutely love it. Couldn't wait to cause chaos...

He said, "You just came from Finn's?"

"Yeah," she said, looking the tired version of puzzled.

"Was Chelsea there?"

"Uh-huh."

"What did she say?"

"Nothing. Just asked me how the concert was."

He pondered as they ascended the short drive toward the house. He said, "It's so weird that you had to walk."

"It's one street over, Ben."

"But you're so tired."

"I've been on a bike for like two hours, it's nice to stretch my legs."

"But now you want to nap?"

"I'm so-oo tired."

Door held open for her, he took the bag out of her hand and watched as she waddled into the house. A brief flash of anger swiped across his vision like a passing shadow. It was the sight of the backs of her bare legs, her beautiful perky butt in the shorts she'd bought to wear for another man's eye. It was a vulnerable part of her. A ticklish part, too. And, the backside, where she couldn't see it coming. He could picture Finn looking at that part of her, his poor Libby glancing over her shoulder to see what the man with the big dick would do. Did Finn take her like that? Did they do it like spoons? God, did they do it from behind on their knees like dogs? Libby had never done that with her husband...

He had to keep the rage in check to stop from slamming the door closed behind them. Libby put a foot onto the staircase, and he stopped her. "Wait, don't go upstairs, stay with me."

"I'm so tired."

"I know, don't go up there."

"Let me just get changed," she said.

Brighter, with hope, he said, "Then you'll come down? You can nap on the couch. We can try to watch Game of Thrones. You can tell me about Dorchester and I'll let you fall asleep if you want to. I'll rub your feet..."

Half her mouth turned up in a smile, and it warmed his heart. “Okay,” she said.

“You want some tea?”

“Yeah. Yeah, that’ll be nice.”

She went up another step. He said, “Lib...?”

She stopped and looked down at him.

“Would you like a little aspirin?”

She held his gaze for a second, thinking about it. “Okay. I could do with an aspirin.”

A ball of ice bumped inside his stomach. He actually leaned forward, putting both his hands on the curved edge of the newel post to keep himself from collapsing to his knees. It was done. She had sex with another guy. Another guy with a big dick. He struggled for something cute to say, but all that was happening behind his bewildered eyes was a tangled mesh of wrestling snakes. Lust, anger, jealousy, rage, passion, regret, and somehow some mutated form of joy. It wasn’t just from the relief of the guilt. What was it? *Was it possible he wanted more?*

“I’m going to go,” she said after patiently waiting for him to say something. She still stared at him, waiting, him standing there with that stunned look on his face, his mouth open. “Okay, a pot of tea and an aspirin coming right up...”



WITH LIBBY UPSTAIRS GETTING CHANGED, he took her shopping bag of things into the laundry room. Piece by piece he removed them and examined each one carefully. Each shirt, each bra, her shorts shorter than the ones she wore right now... He checked them all for semen stains but found none. The white shirt he'd seen her wearing last night while she was cozying up to Dorchester had three red plops, faded to pink. Like she'd been drinking some sort of sweet strawberry drink that splashed on her. For some reason that made him smile. He could picture the accident happening, Libby happy, maybe tipsy, some fruity drink sloshing onto her shirt, and that pouty face she would make, an exasperated sound... He wished he'd been there with her.

He'd saved the best for last, however. Two pair of panties. He held them up to the light, checking each one. There were no signs of semen. Maybe in the pair she wore home?...

Now he found a stiff T-shirt rolled in a tube. He unfurled it: a Dorchester concert shirt like the one she wore, this one in large for him. It was a kind Libby thing that warmed his heart. He took off his shirt and donned the one his wife had bought for him.

He bundled all Libby's dirties together, enjoined a wash load with some things from the hamper and got it started. At the bottom of the bag there were some scraps. Things maybe she'd kept for posterity. There was the torn ticket. A cut wristband in bright pink. A backstage pass. Some pieces of gum, some drink tickets. He took those out and put them aside for her so she could file them away if she wanted to remember the night their relationship changed.

*We'll still be together, I promise, Lib. But last night, things changed. It hurts me so bad, but I deserve it. We're going to be better. We're going to be new...*

The shower was running upstairs while he was in the kitchen boiling a kettle. He bet she had one this morning in the hotel, too, before getting on the bike with Finn. If the hotel had one of those shower wands, he was sure she had it spritzed between her legs full blast, ridding any evidence Chelsea's husband might've left there. She'd probably scrubbed herself down just like he had this morning, washing Chelsea off him. They were *both* bad people. But he loved her more than anything, and this would make them whole.

On a whim, he cooked up some popcorn, put lots of butter and her favorite dill pickle seasoning on it. He brought to the family room the teapot, the popcorn and a glass of water with two baby aspirin in the little dish where she could put the used tea bags. He fired up Game Of Thrones, paused it, and waited. *It's okay, Libby, take your time. You can scrub it all off if it makes you feel better. I don't want you to hurt, I just want us to be equal.*

In fifteen minutes she was back downstairs wearing short pajama pants and a big baggy T-shirt. When she saw him sitting there, she smiled. "Like your shirt?"

He plucked at it and looked at the logo upside down. "It is for me, isn't it?"

"Of course," she said, and sat carefully down on the couch next to him.

He said, "Your butt sore?"

She slid her heel under her backside. "A little," she said.

His heart drilled in his chest like a jackhammer. His voice was tight, but he said in an amused sort of tone: "How was the motorcycle?"

"Not a lot of suspension," she said and turned up her nose a little.

That sweet and innocent lie from her had his heart swelling in his chest, and for some reason he took her in his arms again and pulled her into him. "I love you so much," he said, his voice shaky.

"I love you too, Ben," she said and stroked at his sides.

When they pulled apart, he said, "Hey, weren't you going to tell me about the concert?"

Libby poured herself a cup of tea, took some long sips, knocked back both the baby aspirins with the glass of water. She gave him a rough outline

of the events of the two days. How it was thrilling to be on the motorcycle, how, no, Finn didn't go too fast. How they checked in and all the stuff they did on Friday. She said they had breakfast together on Saturday, and she hung around with him. She lurked in the background while people did the sound checks, but Finn didn't have to meddle too much. She got to see some famous people.

"Like who?"

"I met Alice Cooper."

"Did you really?"

She nodded, smiling. "Yeah, and Kid Rock, too."

"Really, what was that like?"

"I didn't really talk to them. Finn was... but when Finn was talking to Alice Cooper, he locked eyes with me over Finn's shoulder. It was pretty cool."

"That *is* cool."

"And he smiled at me, too."

"What else?"

"Then the concert started, so I mostly was out at these awesome seats out front. And I had like an open tab..."

"Did you drink too much?"

She shook her head no. "No, I paced myself. But I could get whatever I wanted. And I had like these awesome VIP seats right up front."

"Finn was there?"

"Not all the time. He was in and out."

*In and out, huh?* "You weren't lonely?"

"A little..."

"I wish I could go."

"You're such a jerk. You should've come straight from Niagara..."

"There wasn't time, Lib."

She pursed her lips and side-eyed him. "I'm a little mad."

"Don't be mad at me."

She went on to tell him more. She told him every song Dorchester did. She built up to the most exciting part: she met Dorchester. But he already knew that, and he reminded her he'd been sent pictures.

"Oh, yeah," she said. "Oh, that's awesome, I have them. I have to put them on Facebook..."

"You looked really good in them."

“Did I?” She practically squealed.

“Did you wash your cheek when you were in the shower?”

“Yeah, why?” She touched her cheek and frowned at him, not getting it.

“You were cheek to cheek with Van Waters, Lib, most girls wouldn’t wash their cheek ever again.”

She giggled, said, “Poop, I already scrubbed my cheek...”

“Ah, well, you’re not fifteen anymore, anyway, you have to be sensible with your skin care. So what were Dorchester like?”

She scrunched her face. “Old.”

“You know they’re the same age as us.”

“We *are* old,” she said and laughed, “When I listened to them I was in high school.”

“Getting old’s weird, huh?”

They both laughed. There were things he noticed. She still kept her rump off the cushion seat with a heel tucked under the back of her thighs. She kept her arms folded a lot and leaned back from him. A body language expert might say she was keeping distance. Putting up a barrier. Words were divulging to him all the events like a normal person would, but there were events that she would keep hidden, he was sure of it. And that’s what this arm-folding thing was about.

When she got to the final parts of the evening, her enthusiasm waned, but she told him about going out to another hotel and attending a party where some of Kid Rock’s crew was, but that she and Finn went back to their hotel not too long after.

“And then what?”

Lib licked her top lip, and Ben’s penis swelled a little, jiving off of her discretion here. *Just tell me...*

“We went back to the hotel, and we went to sleep.”

“You were able to sleep after all that? You weren’t all jazzed up?”

She shrugged. “We were pretty tired. It was a long, long, *long* day...”

“So you went to your separate rooms?”

There was a flicker in her eyes, like her finely tuned sensors were picking up some sort of remote tremors, her isolated research base about to predict a faraway earthquake.

She was slow to say, “We hung out a little bit. I just had a glass of water...”

“Where was that?”

“Finn’s room. And then I went straight to bed,” she said, and the arms folded across her chest tightened. He watched her fingertips crawl and then disappear under her armpits. She was protecting herself. She was only human. Look what *he’d* done to protect himself. Enlisted another man to seduce her...

“I’m just so glad you were able to go, Lib, I swear.”

“It actually was so much fun, Ben,” she said, wide smile returning, “it’s too bad you couldn’t go, but I’m *so* glad I went.”

That sickened him a little. The hidden truth was being revealed. She cheated on him with another man and she wasn’t *unhappy* about it. *Oh, Ben, the pleasure Finn’s huge penis delivered...*

“Good,” he said, his posture stiffening, his voice getting thin again. Then he reached to the table top and fumbled with the remote, hoping she wouldn’t catch how badly his hands were shaking...

THEY WATCHED ALMOST a full episode before Libby drifted off. She picked through the popcorn until she'd almost finished it, and he'd rubbed her feet. Touching the soles of her perfect little feet with his bare thumbs made him aroused. The idea that maybe just eighteen hours ago another man's hands would've been all over his Libby was driving him wild. The fact that she hid it from him, making him wilder. She was just as bad as he was. He wanted all the details.

His mind raced while she napped, coming up with ways to set this up. Ways for her to divulge to him the truth and feel supported at the same time. He wanted to hear it. He wanted to know about it *all*. And it wasn't so much that he was eager for the *absolution* it would provide, he was eager to know if she had a good time with Finn or not. *And not at the concert, my dear Libby, under the bed sheets... Did you like it with another man?...*

So while she slept, and he still rubbed her feet, he kept them removed halfway down his thigh to protect from her from feeling his full and complete arousal. He had a one hundred percent erection *raging* in his pants.

When she was right out, he flipped over to the Avengers movie instead, so she wouldn't miss their binge-watch. When she woke a little later, they went back to Game Of Thrones. She wanted to skip dinner. She wasn't hungry, and she was tired. As the daylight began to wane, he became solemn. He wanted this to be over; he wanted her to reveal to him what had happened. Maybe it was too soon, but it *was* right there on the tips of both their tongues.

*I love you...*

*I love you, too...*

*Even though I did what I did?*

*Yes...*

*Even though I did what I did?*

*Yes, baby, yes...*

At nine o'clock, with ghostly daylight hanging on to the early evening blue, they both went to bed. He settled in behind her and hooked an arm around her waist. But he couldn't let it go...

"So it was no big deal going with Finn?"

"No," she said limply, like she was letting it drop.

He lifted his head from the pillow, could see past her ear that her eyes were open, staring across the room. He cuddled her a little closer. "What were you so worried about?"

"Nothing."

"You guys are just friends."

"Uh-huh."

"Maybe he can take you away to another concert."

Now he watched her lick her own lips, suck her lower one underneath her front teeth and nibble down.

"I'm so glad you went with him, Lib."

"I am, too," she said, her voice dwindling down to a whisper.

He waited for more. Dipped his hips away because boy, oh, boy that erection had come back again. He watched her eyes eventually close. And when she began to snore lightly, he was overwhelmed with disappointment.

## PART 6



# HALF-TRUTHS

MONDAY, JULY 15

AT THREE IN THE MORNING, he was woken by Libby's body gently shaking. She was crying.

He breathed deeply, opened his eyes wide, adrenaline beginning to race his mind awake. He stroked her shoulder, said, "What is it, Lib? What's wrong?..."

"Oh, God," she murmured, like a little girl that had been caught. She sat up right away, and he sat up behind her, put his arms around her so she wouldn't try to get away from him. She had her feet off the bed, hunched over, and he curled himself against her body. "What is it, Lib, what is it?"

The soft crying opened into deepening sobs. She sniffed and snorted, and he consoled her. "I'm so *sorry*, Ben," she mewled.

"So sorry?—for what?" *Here it was coming...*

"Oh, God, I'm so, so sorry..."

"It's okay, Lib, it's okay..."

She tried to draw a breath, but it grew too shaky; she let out a braying cry then clapped both hands over her mouth. In the low light he could see a teardrop twinkle as it fell from her eye and melted into the bedding. He pulled her against him. "Something happened?"

He could feel her nodding in his arms.

"It's okay, Lib, it's really okay..."

"I'm so sorry," she said and put the hand back over her mouth again.

"Something happened with Finn?" She tried to squirm away from him but he gripped her tight. "Hey, hey, you're not going anywhere. I'll support you through anything, Lib, I love you so damn much..."

Her body softened in his arms, all the fight and tension and struggle easing away from her. She sniffed, took a few deep breaths; he loosened his clutch, and she reared back a little so she could look at him. There was hope and surprise in her eyes. His compassion had affected her.

He had her now. He loved her and he wanted her to know everything would be okay.

“Libby, *anything* that happened, we can work it out. I swear...” He took her hand. It was lifeless. He ran his thumb over the backs of her knuckles and squeezed on her wedding ring.

When she didn’t say anything more, her eyes going up and down his face and chest, he prompted her again: “Something happened with Finn?”

She had to breathe through her mouth because crying had swollen her sinuses. She took a breath before saying, “Don’t be mad at him...”

*At him?* “What did he do?” he asked and was surprised by a certain amount of venom there. A natural instinct to protect the girl he loved—even though he’d set the whole thing up.

“It was weird...”

“Lib, you can tell me.”

“God, Ben,” she sighed, ran her hair behind an ear. “Tissue...” She gestured to the bedside table. He plucked one and handed it to her. She blew her nose, balled it up and kept it pressed in her weak fist. “Promise you won’t be mad at him...”

“I swear I won’t, Lib. We can get through anything.”

Again came that look of surprise. There was admiration there, too, some sort of respect that her husband could be so caring.

He fortified her: “I *mean* it.”

She drew a deep breath, said, “I think Finn might... *like* me.”

“Why do you think that?”

Her face was placid, her eyes distant, as she recalled the events of the evening. She was preparing to tell him, but it proved overwhelming for her and she started to cry again.

“What is it, Lib, what is it?” He rubbed her back.

“He... *kissed* me,” she said then let out a long croak. She folded up again, and he rubbed her back and hugged her.

“That’s okay.”

“It’s not okay,” she said.

“What else?”

“That’s it,” she said, and he stiffened.

“What do you mean that’s it?”

“He tried to kiss me.”

“Tried? That’s all that happened?”

She nodded, unraveled her tissue with her fingers and then blew her nose again. He held out his hand, and she put the used tissue in it and he set it on the night table. He plucked her a new one and handed that to her. “He tried to kiss you?”

She nodded again.

*This is all you’re going to say?* She needed more coaxing. “That’s okay, Lib. Where was this? At the show?”

“No. His hotel room.”

And then the real part of his brain took over, and he said, “What were you doing in his hotel room?” That was the real question that should come from a husband who wasn’t a piece of garbage who’d injured his wife unknowingly with his awful terrible unfaithful behavior.

She exhaled. “I just went in for a minute.”

“To have a glass of water?”

“Uh-huh.”

Compassionate devious Ben returned, and he hugged her again. “You didn’t do anything wrong, Lib. You know I love you.”

She said, “I love you, too. I’m sorry it happened...”

He wasn’t ready to drop it. “Are you sure he tried to kiss you?”

“What do you mean?”

“Well, maybe he was reaching for something and you... I don’t know, could you maybe misunderstand?”

She looked sullen, eyes going down to the bedroom floor. She bit her lower lip. “No, we kissed.”

“Your lips touched?” Just that question had his heart racing again and his penis was wide awake.

She nodded. “I’m so sorry,” she said without looking at him.

“And that’s everything?” *Come on, come on, out with it...*

She threw him a sudden curve ball: “Do you think I’m attractive?”

“Do I think you’re attractive? Libby, I married you and I love you and I think about you all day, every day. I love you to bits...”

“Yeah, but do you think I’m... *attractive?*... You know... *sexy?*”

“You are, Libby, you are...”

“As sexy as Chelsea?” She showed him a pained unsure face.

“Absolutely, baby, way sexier. You keep yours close, you know how I’m always begging to see it...”

“She puts it up front?”

“You’re sexy, Lib,” he said, a vice on his heart over his wife’s hurting, “you are just as sexy, I swear...”

“Okay,” she sighed, deliquescing in his arms.

He held her until it seemed she would remain silent. He said, “And that’s everything that happened? Nothing more...?...?”

She sighed again, looked around the room then sniffed. She said, “He didn’t just kiss me.”

Here we go... “What else did he do?”

“Nothing. But I know how he likes me.”

He asked, “What does that mean?”

She hugged herself closer to him. “How can you tell if a boy likes you, Ben?”

“I don’t know. He sends you a Valentine’s card...?”

“No,” she said, irritated—not at him though, at her inability to convey what she meant. It hit him. She couldn’t even say it...

He held her away, asked quietly: “What is it?”

Her brows worked high, then lowered. “If a boy likes you... Like *really* likes you, what can happen with his body...?”

“You mean...”

Her mouth slimmed and her shoulders went up. “Do you get what I’m saying?”

“I think you have to say it.”

She whined: “Why?”

“I think I know, but maybe I’m wrong... please say it, I want to hear it...”

She chewed her lower lip, said, “In his pants...”

“How do you know?”

She made a bashful face.

“How Libby?”

“I could tell.”

“You could tell he had an erection?”

She nodded, looked at her hands, said quieter: “And he *told* me...”

“He *told* you...”

Now her face twisted up, and she began to cry again.

"It's okay, it's okay," he said urgently. A fear had begun to work in him that maybe there was no more. And now the idea that she might be hurting and his trap hadn't even been sprung was overwhelming... "Don't hurt, Libby, don't hurt... Finn got a boner, that's all right, you didn't do anything, right?..."

"I know, I didn't, I didn't try to..."

"You're just too sexy," he said.

She laughed a blurting wet sound through her sad saliva-thick mouth. He loved to hear it. He caressed her arms and her back.

"You just can't help it..."

"You're so stupid," she said and nuzzled against him.

"And that's all that happened?"

She nodded.

"That's totally nothing, Lib, that's totally nothing."

"Don't be mad at Finn, please?"

"I'm not mad at him at all, Lib. He's a guy, guys can't help themselves..."

She gave a light happy chuckle, and he cradled her.

"Libby," he said, and put his hand over hers. She was happy to have it, ran her fingers between his and stroked her thumb against him. Heart beating fast, he made a bold move. He dragged her hand up his thigh, ushered it between his legs, placed the point of his pajama clad erection between both of their palms. He let her hand go. He didn't say anything, just let her make up her own mind about what he'd just shown her.

HE WATCHED her in the low light coming from the bedroom window, her face sculpted in shadows and gray-blue light. Her eyes were lowered, and her hand didn't leave him. He didn't look down, only watched her face. He could feel her fingers manipulating him, her thumb swirling circles on his erection. He leaned back a little, put his hands behind him. Libby still caressed his turgid manhood.

It was surprisingly exciting to think of her now holding her husband's erection while last night she had been with another man—maybe nothing had happened more than what he'd heard but maybe something more did. But even with what he heard, there was a black swirling badness that he only dared to graze his fingertips against: *what she's holding in her hand she's comparing to the one she put her hand on last night*. It was guaranteed. That studious face she had, the furrowed, curious brow. It wasn't just an innocent wife trying to comprehend her sexuality. It was more than that. Libby was unsure of her place in her sexual world, yes, but right now she had something else to compare her *husband's* sexuality against. The thought was so awful, so bewilderingly powerful, his face began to pinch into a grimace. There was pleasure, but he had to focus to find it amidst the apocalyptic barren of all the pain, all the hurt and jealousy.

He said to her very quietly, "We're all the same, Lib. Men..."

It brought the tiniest curl of a smile to one side of her mouth. She said, "You're not mad at me?"

"Never," he said, taking advantage of the moment to sit forward and remove her hand from him. It was a relief. It was so much effort to sift

through all that hurt to find the tiniest diamond of pleasure. He held her wrists. "I'm not mad at all, Libby. You're amazing, you're my everything..."

With her hand off him, her eyes returned to his. And he was feeling powerfully in love with her and bolder than ever. He let her wrists go, his hands moving to her hips and gathering the hem of her T-shirt. As he began to lift it, she scolded him: "Ben..."

He persisted, beginning to casually see-saw the circle of her shirt hem up to the narrow of her waist. She sucked in her stomach, clamped her elbows to her side. He leaned forward and kissed her mouth. "Let me," he whispered.

With his chin in her neck, Libby let him move her shirt higher. Without his eyes watching she was more comfortable. He pulled it up to her armpits, then guided her to bend forward and pulled over the neck hole. Her hair slid through letting off quiet static pops before it hung like silk around her perfect face again. She wouldn't look at him, and sat back, crossing her forearms over her breasts. He tossed her shirt aside, reached and held her wrists. He wasn't even pulling but he could feel her resistance. "Let me," he said again quietly and reassuringly. "I love you..."

He tugged gently, let her resistance guide the speed with which he brought her hands down. She let him do it. And slowly in the moonlight his wife's breasts were bared to him. It wasn't the first time he'd seen her naked like this, it's just that she was a girl who preferred the dark for naked time. And being confronted by him like this was definitely something that inspired great shame in her.

He said, "You have the most beautiful body, Finn didn't stand a chance."

She made a quiet clucking sound with her tongue. Her fingers swallowed up her thumbs like they were sucking on them. She began to chew on her lip; the pink brown buds of her nipples condensed, the areola tightening in physical frisson, nipples lengthening and hardening.

He said, "How could Finn stand a chance being near you?"

"Stop it," she whispered in a tone that made him smile. She liked what she was hearing.

"You're sexy in your own way, Lib. Chelsea's got her thing, she's aggressive and intimidating, she puts fangs in throats, you *lure* men to you, sing sweet songs till they fall at your feet. All your curves, your sweet charm... you're irresistible..."



Now he caressed her face; she leaned her cheek into it and he rubbed the pad of his thumb under her eyelashes. She kissed the inside of his wrist.

He said, “Your body is unbelievable, Libby, and the more you hide it, the more guys like Finn want to see it.”

“Get out of here,” she whispered.

“I saw you in your little shorts.”

“Stop,” she said, but that curl of a smile was still there.

“You bought those shorts to go out with Finn?”

“For the concert,” she said, her tone slightly scolding.

“Finn sent me a video, you weren’t looking, you were dancing, and you had your arms above your head, I couldn’t stop looking at that perfect little butt of yours.”

“Ben,” she said and laughed a little.

“It was Finn that took the video, how could he not want to kiss you?”

Now he leaned forward, not neglecting the fact that he just mentioned Finn and Lib kissing and was now leaning forward to touch his lips to his wife’s. It was like some sort of ritual, a conjuring spell, bringing his wife back to the moment where her lips touched Finn’s last night, put her in touch with that bad side of her...

He stayed close to her, his lips near her ear. He whispered, “I’m not mad at him and I’m not mad at you. I love you so much, Libby. We’ve been together so long, I’ve known you my whole life. Look at me...” He gripped her neck, held her face close, their eyes only inches apart, a Little League coach giving a halftime pep-talk. “You can’t do anything wrong, Lib. We’re in this together. This big game of life, it’s just you and me. If anything happened, I wouldn’t be mad at all...”

“What do you mean?”

“I’m not mad about what happened in Finn’s room.” Just saying that made Lib’s face scrunch up. “Listen,” he said, “seriously, you can’t do *anything* wrong. If something more happened—if the worst thing *ever* happened—I would never leave you...”

“Ben,” she said in an annoyed sort of way, though she leaned forward appreciating what he said. She slumped, and he stroked her jawline.

He asked, “Did anything else happen? You can be honest...”

She shook her head no.

“Just tell me, Lib.”

*I know there was more. I heard there was more, heard it with my own ears...*

He bit his lips as he held her, and his wife let the opportunity to be honest slip away. His words were true, he *was* here for her—sure he'd set her up, but nothing more honest could have been spoken right now than that he could see her through anything. The fact that she would let a chance at honesty slip right by her and not even reach for it for some reason made him even harder.

His hand came up and cupped her bare breast, he squeezed her nipple in the V between his thumb and index finger and took her mouth again. He guided her to her back, the two of them on their sides and kissing on their bed. They wiggled their way up so their feet and legs were resting on the mattress. He stroked her warm side, brushed the backs of his fingers over her soft tummy, drawing circles around her navel.

He said, "How could you do that to poor old Finn?"

Lib smiled, got bashful again, swallowed her lower lip and dipped her chin down. He kissed her forehead.

"Poor guy, having to spend the whole day with you bopping around in those shorts. No wonder he got an erection."

She smiled a little wider. He slipped a hand under the waistband of her sleeping shorts and pushed them down to expose a hip. Libby rolled to her back, let him peel her shorts down and off. She planted the soles of her little feet on the mattress and kept her knees raised and together. He slipped a hand between them, found his wife's furry little patch glistening with the dew of her arousal.

He said, "You're excited..."

"Ben," she said, chastising him, her two hands coming down to cover over his. He still stroked his middle finger over her tight opening. It was slick and hot and eager.

Now his own heart was racing. He whispered, "I bet Finn wishes he was me..."

Libby couldn't answer, but he watched a wink of light reflected off her front teeth as she nibbled on her lower lip. She arched her neck and raised her chin. She liked it.

"What do you think he would give to be in bed with you right now?"

"I don't know," she whispered.

"Boy, if he could see what I was doing right now..."

“Ben,” she chastised him again, but there was a tiniest giggle and lightness to her voice.

“Do you think he likes to do it like spoons?” He said it close to her ear and he could see goosebumps raise up in humps on her bare flesh. Her nipples hardened further right before his eyes.

“I don’t know,” she said, that light giggle there, but there was a deepening to her breath and he could tell she was considering it.

“I bet he does. Bet he wishes he could’ve last night. Bet he wishes he could’ve rolled you over like this,” he said, raising her hip and guiding her to roll on her side with her back to him. He kissed between her shoulder blades, ran a hand down her silky skin, over a round ass cheek and finding that wet hot stripe between her legs. He put his ring finger inside her and watched her lips part...

THE MOONLIGHT TRACED a silver rim over Libby's curves. The swell of her shoulder, the shallow of her waist, the rising crest of her haunch. She'd never been more beautiful. She had hidden things. Hidden sexual value. These last two weeks he'd dusted and rubbed at it, brought out its shine. And this affair with Finn was like a jeweler's precision, cutting facets to make Lib's gem sparkle. Petite, full figured, womanly, and old world classic modesty that had her constraining her wonderful feminine bounty with demure costuming. But on any day of the week, Libby was just as sexy as Chelsea. It was *under* the surface. Chelsea was all choppy waves and stormy skies and driving rain. Everything Libby had was that quiet dark mystery that lay in the depths. But it could be just as dark, just as bewildering, just as powerful.

Just like that, he was switching characters... He whispered to her, "Do I need to put on a condom?" His voice, but done in the laconic ease of that cool and casual bad boy covered in tattoos—the one who may or may not have had sex with Libby last night.

"It's okay, tonight it's okay..."

It chilled him. *Was it okay last night?* If they'd had sex, were they smart enough to use a condom? Or could she not even facilitate any sort of defense once Finn's words got her lubricated? Once action began, was Libby an easy lay? Chelsea said Lib would go to her back. He could picture it. At least the first time. Poor Libby, frightened, but curious and aroused. Helpless in her naïve way. Her knees coming up to her breasts, Finn lowering himself...

"Are you sure?" he said, giving it that easy-going drawl.

“Put it in,” she said.

Utilitarian yet dirty. Libby yet not Libby...

He guided a hand over the back of her topmost thigh to raise her knee and give him better access. He stroked himself against her wet and hungry aperture then sunk slowly inside.

In character, he thought of himself as Finn claiming a woman who'd only been with one man. Giving her something she herself had told him she'd never had. A man with a large penis. He whispered, “Should I go slow?”

And to his horror, Libby played along: “Be careful,” she whispered

His heart snapped off a rimshot and his eyes widened. His neck swelled, his blood pressure kicked into high gear. *Was she getting into this?*

“You let me know if it's uncomfortable,” he said in imitation-Finn's voice.

“Deeper,” she sighed and he just about died. He cupped a hand on her hip, his other one snaking through her silky hair to seize the back of her slender, graceful neck. He slipped himself in and out of her, her tight little insides gripping and milking on him. *Oh, what a treat she would be for Finn...*

With his eyes clenched shut, he imagined himself as the other man last night in a Barrie hotel bed. Hand on her hip, hand on her neck, timid little mousy housewife doing the worst thing she'd ever done in her entire life. The thrill was insane, and the impending orgasm built to gargantuan proportions.

He ventured forward into dirtier territory, feeling bold and well-armored, a warrior galloping into battle in a berserker fury: “What are we going to tell them?”

“I don't know,” she whispered.

“We can do this all night...”

“I want to...”

“We can't tell them, this has to be our secret...”

“I won't,” she squeaked.

Then dirtier: “Am I hurting you?”

She moaned, hissed, and bucked against him. Her body squirmed and went open-faced for a second, and he slapped a hand just below her navel, drove two middle fingers down between her legs and did something he'd never done before: pleased her clitoris while they made love. Too bold for

Libby, but not too bold for this *new* Libby made razor-sharp by her bad boy crush, Finn Slade. She was panting and gasping, and didn't bat away his hand, in fact, Lib let her legs drift a little farther apart.

The sound of his rock hard erection goring in and out of her brought slick suction sounds and he could feel her tightness gripping and milking on him.

"Is it okay?" he urged, and she nodded. "It doesn't hurt?"

"Ah, oh, you're *so* big," she panted. Then she came.

Came in a way he hadn't seen before, too. Lib wasn't easy to orgasm. She liked sex, she wasn't afraid, she just seemed to have a lot of shame wrapped around it like hairy twine. He always was joyous when he'd coaxed it. Today was no exception, but it certainly was far darker than it had ever been before. Like a candy with a coppery bitter aftertaste.

*You're so big...*

Then she came... thinking of her larger, well-hung lover...

The orgasm had her gasping and panting. He watched her chest rise and fall rapidly, her breasts jostling and jiggling. They were pointed with hard arousal, cheery pink nipples on a caramel platter. The most beautiful woman around, and she was here with him all the time. He felt crushed and hurt and wonderful simultaneously. He ejaculated inside her.

He knew not to thrust, because when Lib was in the throes she told him not to do that. So he winced and grimaced and tried to keep his eyes open as his seed spurted inside her. It got him panting, too.

Her heavy breathing was laced with a high whistle; a restriction in her lungs. She coughed a little, getting those breasts shaking again. He caressed her stomach, his brow creasing with worry and his eyes beginning to swell with sadness.

As she came out of it, her eyes fluttered, long lashes quivering. Then her eyes opened wider, dumbstruck, rolling around in their sockets like a frightened horse's. He knew the horror of what they'd said while making love was getting to her. The words he'd provoked from her like some sort of admission. He just administered to her the dirtiest and trickiest inquisition. He got her aroused in order to admit her wrongdoing.

Lib's mouth fell open, and she looked to say something but could only utter a thin croaking sound. She bit her lower lip, rolled over to her side away from him and folded both hands under her cheek. His penis slipped out from inside her.

Off the bed now, he went into the closet to retrieve a clean hand towel. He brought it to her, draped it over her bare rump then massaged her seeping seams. She put her hand between his and the towel and took over. She cleaned herself folding the towel over and over then tossing it toward the hamper but missing. If she wasn't hurting, she would've slunk away and put it properly in with the dirty laundry.

He watched her breathing, could hear a soft whimpering and knew she was crying. She didn't want to admit what had happened, but she was getting there. He ached for her. There was no reason she had to hurt because *he* was the one who should be sorry. Still, seeing her this way was destroying him. *Just tell me the truth, Lib. We have so much to discuss...* And seeing her hurt amplified the effect on him. He was crushed to think of her with Finn. To think of her enjoying a man *physically*.

He sighed, asked her: "Are you coming up to the pillows?"

He could see her small ear move as she nodded slightly. On her knees and elbows, she crawled up to the pillows, keeping her face turned away from him, slinking to the wrong side of the bed and facing away.

All she had to do was tell the truth. Why was she being so evasive?

*It's so big...*

His stomach tightened and just as he was about to slip an arm around her and hold her, he put it under his pillow instead. Then he rolled over.

Both of them lay with their backs to each other now, and it took a long time before he finally fell asleep.

## PART 7



BRAND NEW DAY

IN THE MORNING he woke alone in bed. Plates clanked downstairs and delicious food smells drifted up the stairwell and into the bedroom. Hand sweeping over his side of the bed where Libby slept last night, he found his spot cool. He went downstairs in his pajamas to find Libby in a robe standing at the stove, the sunlight coming in their kitchen window in a warm, happy glow. She looked at him quickly and sheepishly, smiled briefly, bid him a soft Good Morning, and went back to her pan.

“Good morning,” he said, sat down heavily at the kitchen table.

Libby looked over her shoulder at him, gave him another smile that seemed a little more confident but still tentative. She said, “What are you doing today?”

“There’s a half-dozen cars in Scarborough I gotta go take a look at.”

She smiled, played with her hair. “When are you leaving?”

“Soon.”

“You want to drive me to work?” She smiled cute.

The more sweet she tried to be, the more innocent, it seemed to have the *opposite* effect on him. It *irritated* him, *aggravated* him. He wasn’t going to forget what she said last night.

She prompted again: “Can you?”

“Sure,” he said.

“I’m making you eggs,” she told him.

“Thanks,” he said.

The perfunctory responses he’d given made Lib’s shoulders slump. He got up, came near her, poured himself a coffee from the carafe, sat back down and had a sip.

She brought the plates to the table, sat across from him, hunched over and small. She'd made him scrambled eggs, bacon, and toast. The toast had been buttered and then braised with a hot stamp shaped in the Game Of Thrones wolf head.

She saw him studying it, said, "When you get home tonight, do you want to watch the rest of the season?"

Appetite gone, he stared at the food with no interest. He said, "What happened last night, Libby?"

Lib's mouth tightened, and she looked at her plate. "You said you weren't mad."

"I'm not. Why can't you just tell me what happened?"

"I did," she pleaded.

He grumbled, took a bite of the buttery toast. It was like flaky nothing in his mouth. His knee was bouncing, and he finished chewing, took another sip of coffee. "I told you you can tell me. You can tell me anything that happened."

"I know," she said, running hair behind an ear and avoiding his eyes again.

"What about what you said?"

Still not looking at him: "When?"

"Come on, Libby."

"What, Ben?" she said, looking at him now, and he could see her eyes glistening in the morning light with the threat of tears.

His lips twitched, and he forced himself to get it out. "About being *big*."

It looked like Libby's stomach rolled over. She went nauseous right before his eyes. She sniffed, licked her buttery lips, folded her arms around her plate and dipped her head low.

"You said Finn was hard?"

Into her plate: "Ben, come on, it's the morning..."

"Did you see it?"

"See what?"

"See that he was hard...?"

"Kind of..."

He twisted in his seat, irritated that she wasn't forthcoming when he'd made it so easy for her. "Is that why you said that?"

"What do you mean?"

"Was he big?"

Libby winced, an ugliness to the question testing her pluck. "I don't know," she said, eyebrows folding up right in the middle, her brow creasing.

"You said he showed you. You *saw* it..."

"I couldn't tell..."

"Libby, come on," he said, getting irritated.

"What, Ben? Don't make me talk about it..."

"What did you see?"

"It was just, I don't know, Ben, a *bulge*..."

"Just a bulge."

Her head rolled weakly on her neck. "I'm sorry I said anything..."

"Libby, I just want you to tell me the truth."

"Ben, I'm telling you the truth, why won't you just accept what I'm saying?"

"Sorry," he said, "it would've been fine except you said that thing..."

Her lips thinned further and she bit them, sucked them under the bite of her teeth. "Don't be mean to me," she whimpered

"I'm not," he said.

She moaned, "I never should've gone..."

"You should have gone, Lib, I said I mean it."

"I told you what happened," she implored.

"Okay," he said, "okay," showing her his palms. "Sorry, okay."

"This is why I don't like to say things in bed."

He dropped his fork, and it clattered against the plate. "Libby, I want you to say things in bed. It's not that..."

"But then when I do..."

"Fine," he said, showing her his palms again. He collected his fork and put scrambled eggs in his mouth but could barely swallow it...

IN THE DRIVEWAY, sitting in his truck and waiting for Libby who was still in the house, he texted Chelsea against his own better wishes.

**Ben:** what did Finn say?

He set the phone down face-first on his thigh, turned up the air conditioning. After breakfast, he and Libby had gone about getting ready for the day, moving around each other in the bathroom in a not unfriendly way, still very quiet with each other. He was dressed first, and now he was waiting for her, listening to the radio, getting the news. His phone dinged.

**Chelsea:** she icing that kitty cat?

**Ben:** what does that mean?

**Chelsea:** how's she taking it?

**Ben:** taking what?

**Chelsea:** what did she tell you?

**Ben:** She told me nothing happened

**Chelsea:** nothing happened?

**Ben:** not even what you and I heard

**Chelsea:** did you tell her you heard it?

**Ben:** Are you crazy?

**Chelsea:** Finn fucked your wife twice last night

He stared at the words right there on the screen. *Finn fucked her?* His skin took a chill from the cold air against the sudden body heat wetting his skin. He wiped at his upper lip.

**Ben:** What did he tell you?

**Chelsea:** said they fucked twice in his hotel bed. Said she was so tight his dick is hurting today

He groaned, tightened his stomach muscles, could feel his face flushing with heat and rage.

**Ben:** are you serious?

**Chelsea:** He had to drive to Hamilton today I asked him if he wanted a bag of ice for his dick

“Come on,” he said, and punched his arm rest. *Why wouldn't Lib tell him that? Why was she such a little liar?*

He turned the screen of his phone to read it again. *Finn fucked her. Twice. She was so tight...*

Sudden churning tumult rip-roared through his insides. He grabbed at his tie to loosen it, undid the top button of his shirt. Fucking grabbed his steering wheel and shook it back and forth, growling through gritted teeth. They fucked. *They fucked!*

“Fuck you, Libby,” he said. Now he was bewildered, looking at the door, waiting for that pretend-innocent to come skipping out to get a ride into work. Yeah, sure, he was a piece of shit who cheated on her. He was a piece of garbage who set his wife up to get seduced by a guy she had a crush on. But she didn’t have to fall for it. She didn’t have to open her legs to Finn. But most importantly: she could have *told* him. He practically begged her to.

Libby’s blonde hair was swishing now behind the glass inset of the door, and she backed her way out with her little lunch bag and briefcase, wearing her sedate attire of lightweight khaki summer skirt and cotton chambray button-down collar shirt.

“Fuck you, Libby,” he said again, put the truck in reverse and backed out of the driveway.

THE FURTHER HE ripped down their street the worse he felt. He eased off the pedal, the engine's roar making him feel ashamed. The tires had even chirped. The worst was Libby in his rearview, hands held up as if to say Where are you going?

The rage couldn't be helped. Nor the jealousy and the hurt. It wasn't the act of the infidelity. It was her lack of honesty.

At the end of Sarah Ashbridge, he jerked his truck to the right before the stop sign and pulled over, grabbed his phone, shame and guilt washing up his back. He texted Libby now.

**Ben:** sorry gotta go business emergency I'm not going into the city, heading out east so sorry

He growled, tapped his phone against his forehead. He sent another message.

**Ben:** I love you so much Libby. I love you so so much

He waited, eyes frozen glued to his phone. Libby hardly ever texted though her old flip-phone could do it. He waited, thinking she wouldn't hear his apologetic missive. At last she responded.

**Libby:** I'm telling you the truth, Ben



He shook his head, looked up through the truck's sunroof at the hazy blue sky. Growled and punched the velour ceiling.

"You are not," he groaned. "You're just not..."

He stared at her message again.

In the coffin of his cab, he shouted at the top of his lungs: "You are a little liar!"

THREE HOURS LATER, just before lunchtime, he was overwhelmed by embarrassment over his behavior this morning. He was a first-class heel. All that bullshit, telling himself about how he would support Libby through anything, and the first little speed-bump, he's throwing up his hands and acting like he's back in high school again. That was not a classy move.

Just because things didn't go your way didn't mean you kicked over the Monopoly board and went home. Kids that did that weren't asked to come and play again. *What had happened?* He'd been so confident about how things would fall into place. Libby had done the thing that would make them equal. But instead of confessing and nudging their relationship closer to the bull's eye again, she started breaking rank, doing the unexpected, and the next thing you know he's storming off, squealing rubber and acting like an asshole.

The truth was, he wanted this to be done because he wanted Libby to be restored with him. Wanted to hold her in his arms and be renewed. Atone for his badness, if she would accept it, and accommodate hers. Sure, he'd held onto fantasies about maybe getting together with Chelsea and Finn, maybe even bringing Neve into his bedroom with Libby, but it was far-fetched.

It was her lies that had stumbled him. Libby was *not* a liar. But there was no way nothing happened. He'd heard it himself...

*Finn fucked her twice...*

Fifteen minutes before her lunch break, he was in the deli where all the staff from the bookstore liked to get their coffee, ordering four blacks to-go and getting containers of cream and sugar. It would be for her friends,

because he was going to take Libby out for lunch. They would start this over. He wouldn't talk about Finn, not at lunch, that would be dealt with in time. He would make Lib happy again, make her feel safe. Make her feel loved. Because the Ben she saw this morning was not the Ben he wanted to be for her.

Coffee tray in hand, he strolled through the black steel and glass double-doors of the downtown bookstore set in the shopping level of a Bay Street skyscraper. Inside, the store was incongruous; sky-high mahogany bookshelves, towering Ionic columns, glittering chandeliers, gleaming hardwood floors. Outside was hot dog carts and finance hustlers, inside the shop's doors it was a wink to the Bodleian Library.

Between the huge round front tables of newest releases, he worked through a mid-day crowd, waving at Earl who manned the checkout today, then up the open staircase to the half second floor. The special-order and customer service kiosk was there, a clutch of middle-aged women gathered near the balcony edge looking down on the first floor, sitting with coffees and quietly gossiping.

His eyes had been darting around, peeping over aisles and around corners, trying to pick up a pretty blonde head dancing around. If she wasn't on the floor, the kiosk is where she'd be.

Tina was there in her place, sitting behind the desk and filling out some paperwork. She saw him coming and her face brightened. "Hey, Ben, hey, great to see you..."

"What's up, Tina?" He set down the tray of coffees, pulled one from its sleeve and set it in front of her. He motioned toward the cream and sugar. "Where's Lib at?"

"Oh, shoot, she didn't come in today, Ben."

"What do you mean didn't come in?"

Tina stopped her tearing of a sugar packet, detecting his alarm. "She didn't tell you? She called in sick this morning."

He was quick on his feet. "Shoot," he said, "I left before she did. She said she wasn't feeling well, I didn't realize it was that bad, poor kid..."

With a sly wink, Tina said, "Probably partied it up in Barrie on the weekend."

"Yeah, she had a really good time. Lib keeps it sensible though."

"Nice of Finn to take her—and get her backstage...? I wish I had a friend like that." She sifted sugar into the coffee cup.

“I was really bummed I couldn’t go.”

“Lib was pretty mad at you. So—she had a good time?”

“She had the best time,” he said, leaning his elbows on the high kiosk counter, his body weight hanging.

“Yeah, that Finn is a great guy,” Tina said, adding two creams. He watched her hands work, thinking about Finn.

“He is,” he said, head cocking warily. “I like him, he’s a good guy. Have you... *met* him?”

“Finn?—sure. He brings coffee too,” she said brightly.

His eyelashes fluttered, and a sudden swell of blood pounded up his neck. His body sagged further against the front face of the kiosk and he had to flex his arms to stop from sliding to the floor. “Finn comes by here?”

“Uh-huh, every once in a while.”

*Wait, every once in a while?* He leapt for a backhand, his mind racing. He asked competitively: “And he brings you guys coffee?”

“He sure does,” Tina said slyly, sipping her coffee with sleepy eyes.

“Better coffee than me?”

“Mmm, I think he mostly goes to the Starbucks, but sometimes the deli.”

*How many fucking times has he brought coffee?* “What’s better, the Starbucks or the deli?”

“Equal. Both are excellent.”

“This might turn into a competition,” he laughed. Meanwhile his heart was pounding and stars sizzled in his periphery. “How often does he come?”

“Once, twice a week. You guys want to compete who can bring the most coffees, I’m all game for that. You know I like donuts, too, right?”

“Good old Finn,” he said, rapped his knuckles on the counter. “How long’s this been going on?”

“Psh, I don’t know, probably since you moved in.”

“Six weeks?”

“‘Bout that,” she said and shrugged, both hands curved around the coffee like she was cold.

Now he didn’t know what to say, caught in Tina’s gaze, desperate not to give away the racing thoughts of betrayal, but beginning to crumble.

He cleared his throat, made an awkward attempt at small talk that came out like a croaking consonant succotash. He shook his head, smiled. “Shoot,

Tina, I better go home and check on Lib. I was going to take her out for lunch today, I guess I'll bring her home something instead..."

Tina smiled warmly, said, "You're so special, Ben," and he faked a smile as his insides began to squirm. His bowels made a squelching sound.

He loosened his tie as he marched down the stairs and between the book rows again, eyes beaming on the front doors as he tried to parse what he was just told. Six weeks? That was before their block party. Before what was the first time he thought Libby met Finn.

IN THE FRUSTRATING snarl of traffic between downtown and the beaches, he began to see before him the events of the last few weeks as if they were laid out on a campaign map. Little pewter military figures making moves like chess pieces around a Machiavellian scheme. Arrows drawn on the map of his existence, a big dirty circle drawn around his wife. Could it be possible that the things Chelsea had done with him, luring him away from his wife, were being done behind his back between Finn and Libby? Was he just as oblivious of her infidelity as she was of his?

This was the first crack of light coming through a collapsed cave wall. Each strike of his pickax bringing more and more light... If it were true, then what would he find when he arrived home? When he clambered up the steps to their bedroom, would he find Finn and Lib entangled in round two (or is it round three or four or even more by now)? Finn's butt pumping up and down, driving that big thing in and out of Libby as she squawked with bright pleasure...

Stuck in a slow moving worm of cars, he couldn't escape images of deep dark betrayal. Lib in bed with Finn and one of Finn and Chelsea's friends, like Neve's well-hung boyfriend, doing all the dirty things he'd done with those girls. Little Lib getting her tiny pink asshole licked and sucked, Lib on her hands and knees getting spit-roasted, sucking two cocks at once, getting ass fucked and giving a blow job, an around the world tour of depravity, maybe the very same night he was with Chelsea and Neve. Both men ejaculating on her multiple times; inside her, deeper inside her, inside her ass, on her perfect tits, on her back, jerking it onto her ass cheeks, onto her face, into her open mouth...

When he pulled off of Boardwalk and onto Sarah Ashbridge, he stopped short of his home. He watched it with the sun visor pulled down, eyeballing the street, looking for that burly custom motorcycle. But his driveway was empty. Of course, it was just walking distance between the two houses. And what would he do if when he went in the house Libby wasn't even home? He would wonder then where she'd gone. Was she off with Finn? Was she over at Finn and Chelsea's? Was she rolling around like a panting little newborn puppy dog on a bed with Finn and Chelsea and Neve? Was she being as bad as he'd been? He deserved it.

He deserved it because he'd earned it. But if they'd done to her what was done to him, weren't they all just pawns in Chelsea's game?

He got out of his truck, closed the door quietly, walked down two houses, strolling with hands in his pockets underneath a honey locust's shade. Made his way up the driveway, sticking to the side where he might not be seen from the windows, quietly then up the front steps and to the door.

He tested it, found it locked. Smart Libby.

Key silently slipped in, lock turned noiselessly, he was inside the house. It was quiet, just the hum of the refrigerator and the sound of the dryer. He slipped off his shoes, and in his socks, slipped around the hall, ducking his head into the kitchen to see if she was there. She wasn't. The family room was empty as well, no one else on the back deck. That left the upstairs. That left the bedroom.

He made his way quietly up to the second floor, moving along the hallway with cold dread in his stomach. It would be Libby and Finn he would find behind his door and though he'd been prepared for this, tried to make it happen, the stark betrayal by his wife might make this too much for him to bear. His hand rested on the doorknob and he challenged himself whether or not he was ready to enter. He took a deep breath, turned the knob and pushed...

LIBBY WAS ALONE IN BED. She was curled up on her side, and there were balled tissues in an array around the pillows and on the floor. She was watching him over her shoulder, bewildered. She didn't say anything.

The calmness of the scene railed in sharp contrast to his expectation and shook him. His rising panic and anxiety stalled. He said, "Libby, sorry I had to take off this morning."

She nodded.

"Look, I'm really sorry. I'm not handling this very well, am I?"

She shrugged one shoulder.

He clenched and unclenched his sore hands. They'd cramped from the tight grip on his steering wheel. "I went by work to apologize and take you out to lunch and they said you called in sick."

She nodded again.

Her silence had him puzzled. And wondering became worrying...

"Yeah," he said, "hold on..." He undid his tie, went into the walk-in closet, tossed it on the dresser, unbuttoned the collar of his shirt then peeked through his hung-up clothing looking for someone hiding. No one.

He returned to the bed, came around so that he could see her face and sat down. He was distracted, the whole while trying not to convince himself that Finn was hiding under the bed. It was crazy. That wasn't the game. The game was for him to *know*, not for it to be done, but for Ben to *know* it had been done...

"Look, Lib, things kinda got weird..."

"They did," she said, grabbed a tissue, wiped at her nose.



“Have you been crying?” Dumb question, look at all those tissues.  
*Unless, of course, they’re actually mopped up loads of Finn’s semen...*

She looked at him sullenly, her chin dimpled. “I’m sorry, Ben,” she said.

“For what?”

“For everything.”

He nodded, laced his fingers together in his lap, and told her: “I know Finn’s been coming by the store.”

Now the red of her face deepened and her lips wriggled as she began to cry again.

“Don’t cry, Lib, don’t cry... It’s okay.”

“It’s not okay, Ben, I’m so sorry.”

“It’s all right, Lib, I just wish you’d tell me what’s going on.”

“Nothing’s going on,” she said.

“Why are you crying?”

“Because I’m embarrassed.”

“But nothing happened, you said.”

“No...”

“Then why are you embarrassed? If you didn’t do anything wrong, you shouldn’t be upset at all.”

“I didn’t. I tried not to...”

“But something happened?”

She shook her head no, infuriating him.

“*Why* do you keep doing that, Lib?”

“Doing what?”

“Lying to me.”

Her eyes locked on his, weak and submissive and full of shame, her chin dimpled and her lips trembled.

He said, “I know something happened—you said Finn kissed you?”

“Uh-huh...”

“And you didn’t kiss him back?”

She shook her head no.

He grunted with exasperation. “Not even a little?”

A weakness showed in her expression now, a fear in her eyes, the ease with which she’d been lying getting a little shaken. His questioning was becoming too *knowing*...

He said, “Why don’t you tell me the truth?”

“I told you,” she said, her voice shaky and quiet and unsure.

“I know you’re not telling me the truth, Lib.”

Her lower lip sucked slowly in her mouth and her eyes grew wide and wet. “How?”

“You kissed him back.”

“D-did he *tell* you that?”

“No, I haven’t talked to anybody.”

She looked at him dumbly.

“I know you kissed him back, Lib, just tell me you did.”

Finally: “I didn’t want to.” Her tiny voice was a whisper.

“But you kissed him back.”

“What do you want me to say, Ben?”

“I want to know why you’re lying.”

She began to cry again and covered her mouth and nose with the tissue.

“Don’t, Lib, don’t. What I’m trying to tell you is it doesn’t matter what the truth is, I can take it. I just don’t want you to lie to me...”

“Nothing happened.”

“For crying out loud, Lib, it did, I *heard* it.”

Her crying abruptly stalled. She held her breath and watched him.

Now that he had her complete attention, things reluctantly began to roll: “Finn’s... phone was... open, I heard everything.”

It was a long drawn out moment where she just stared at him and he wondered if she maybe didn’t hear him. There was no reaction, just dull eyes looking back his way. Then she hid her face and cried into her hands.

“Stop, stop crying, Lib. I don’t want you to cry, I hate that you’re crying. I’m telling you it’s totally fine.”

“I’m so sorry, Ben,” she cried.

“Just come clean with tell me and tell me what happened.”

“He kissed me,” she blurted wetly. “I kissed him...” She let out a low agonal moan. “I tried to leave, he came after me...”

“He showed you his erection?”

She bawled: “You *heard* that?”

“I heard it all, just tell me, just confess it all, please, get it out...”

“Oh, my God,” she said, fresh sobs coming now.

“I love you, Lib, I love you...”

“He showed it to me, he asked me to touch it...”

“And then?”

“Oh God, Ben, don’t...”

“I don’t want you lying to me.”

“I touched it,” she whimpered.

“Why was that so hard?”

“I’m so ashamed,” she said, reaching now to pull a pillow to her.

He sighed heavily, felt like he weighed a thousand pounds as he backed his butt down to sit next to her on the bed, both of them with their feet hanging off. “It’s okay, Lib, it’s—”

“It’s not okay,” she shouted into the pillow.

“Keep going, Lib,” he prompted, “what happened next?”

She pulled the pillow away. “I touched it, I poked it, and then I wanted to get out of there.”

“You stroked it.”

Her brows wriggled. “Just a little, Ben,” she bawled.

“He took you to the bedroom.”

“I *ran* to my bedroom.”

“You guys went to yours?”

“No, I went to mine.”

“And then what happened?”

She blubbered, “God, *you* heard...”

“Tell me.”

“He said he was sorry.”

“And then...?”

“I just felt so stupid, Ben, you heard me I bawled like a baby...”

“What happened after that?”

She frowned, eyes going up, cheeks red. “He put me into bed...”

His breath quickened, and his hand rubbed on his thighs...

“And then he put a blanket on me and I fell asleep.”

He stared across the room, looking out the window that would open onto the street side. Bright daylight out there, midday, not a place for such an awful bit of theater.

“You slept?... And that’s all that happened?” His voice was automatic and far away.

“Ben, I swear I didn’t want to—I don’t know why I did that...”

“And what about coffee with him?”

“He started bringing coffee by after one time he came in and said his wife knew me. He’s funny, he’s nice...”

“He’s more than that to you and you know it.”

“No,” she whispered, looking at her fingers pluck at a balled tissue.

“It’s not as innocent as you say it is, Lib.”

She whispered to her lap: “I swear nothing happened, baby.”

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

She sobbed until she coughed. “I don’t know,” she whined.

“Because you have a crush on him?”

She shook her head vigorously, her pretty features tightening. “‘Cause I’m afraid of Chelsea...”

WATCHING THE SIMPLE, pure but hurting face of his wife ruined him. Her fear of Chelsea, her crush on Finn, then thinking now her fun visit to the concert with Finn was nothing but a ruse. Mean girl Chelsea and her mean husband tricking dumb high school Libby into thinking Finn could actually like her. Her husband let her down, her husband deceived her...

"Oh, shoot," he sighed, dipping his chin down, feeling a thunderhead of reality coming in fast from the coast. "No," he sighed to himself, knowing what he had to do, wishing he didn't...

"Forgive me, Ben," she said, "I'm so ashamed, I'm not that kind of girl..."

Slowly he sank off the bed, his butt sliding down, his knees folding up underneath him until he sat on the floor next to her feet.

"Ben...?" She touched his shoulder.

He rolled until he was on his knees between her legs looking up at her. She was crying, tears on her cheeks, pain he'd given to her. He'd ruined them. He took her hands.

"Ben, please forgive me."

"Libby," he said, holding both her hands in his. "You know how much I love you."

"I love you, too."

"I told you you couldn't hurt me, I'd see you through anything..."

"You did," she said almost hopefully.

"You're so good," he told her.

"No, I'm not."

“You are, Lib, you are. Finn took you away, he tried to seduce you but you wouldn’t let him...”

“I love *you*, you’re my husband.”

“I know,” he said, giving her warm little hands a shake. “I know... That’s what I mean, you’re so good.”

“I’m not bad,” she said, touching his cheek.

“Libby, Finn tried to seduce you...”

“I don’t know about seduce,” she said, running fingernails through his hair over his ear.

“No, listen...”

She brought her hands down again, he held them. She was listening. He drew in a deep breath. “Finn tried to seduce you and I knew he was going to.”

Her expression didn’t change much, but there was a new focus there, like her pupils dilated, locking in to absorb more detail.

“Libby, I could have gone to Dorchester, but I wanted you to sleep with Finn. I saw you had a crush on him, and I kind of liked it, I told him... I told him he could if *you* wanted to...”

A funny little smile flashed across her face but it was there for only a half second. Then she was unsure, brow lowering, trying to comprehend what such a crazy statement could possibly mean.

“You’re so good, even though he tried, you didn’t go for him.”

“No...”

“But I wanted it to happen. I wanted him to...”

“Wanted him to what?”

“I wanted you to sleep with him.”

She still couldn’t understand what she was hearing, cocking her head, rearing back as if she needed reading glasses like all this information was too close to her. She put some distance between their faces, trying to get perspective. “What are you talking about?”

“I wanted you to so that we would be equal. Because, Libby, I’m not as strong as you are...”

“No,” she said in the softest of whispers. When her hands tried to dart away, he held them pinched with his thumb against his knuckles.

“No,” he said, “listen...”

“Oh, no, Ben...”

“I’m not as strong as you are,” he said, his voice trembling. You’re stronger than me, I couldn’t resist. You’re so strong and I’m so weak...”

“You didn’t...”

Now tears swelled on his lids, filling that cup of space where eyeball meets rim, spilling over and making him blink. But he wouldn’t turn away, he kept his eyes on hers.

“Ben, don’t say it.”

“I have to, Libby.”

“Oh, Ben, no...”

“I cheated on you, Libby...”

“With Chelsea?” Her voice was a tiny squeaky whisper.

“Yes, I did.”

“When I was at the show?”

“A week ago, Lib, listen, just... I can tell you more but...”

Then that bewildered face of hers pinched completely closed. Eyes squeezed shut, her tears started fresh down her cheeks following the old trails. Her face blossomed in new bright red, her lips wriggled like they were rubber bands, and the tiniest soughing cries began to chug from her. Soft little coughs, each one a stiletto blade in his heart.

“Libby, I’m so sorry, Libby, please...”

She tried to pull her hands back, and he pinched them tighter. But she persisted, yanking and yanking until he let them go. She covered her face and exploded sobs into them.

“Libby, I’m so sorry,” he said, squatting now, putting his arms around her. He didn’t see the slap coming. Pow, right across the face. It felt good because he deserved it. But now he was crying.

“You’re so stupid, Ben,” she sobbed. “You’re so stupid, stupid, stupid...” She covered her face again, almost folded in two.

“Baby, I’m sorry, I’m so, so sorry...”

Every time he tried to put his arms around her, she elbowed him away. They played a funny game of comfort versus anger where he would put a hand on her and she would knock it away. She was crying in her hands and he would touch her and she’d have to uncover her face to bat at him.

“So,” she said suddenly, lifting her chin, her pained eyes looking across the room, now the realization hitting her: “Finn didn’t want to go with me...”

“He did, Libby, he wanted to, and I let him, he really wanted to be there...”

“Oh, God,” she cried, a warbling sound that she squeezed off into her hands again. “You heard me and Finn, you and Chelsea listening, here in my house... dumb Libby, laughing...”

This time when he went to comfort her and take her in his arms, she pushed him hard with both hands. She hissed, “Just get out.”

He sat back down on the floor, hunched and weak, but looking up at the most perfect person that he’d had the pleasure to know. And to destroy. “I’m so sorry... I just wanted us to be together”

“That doesn’t even make sense,” she said, hands forming small hard fists with thumbs tucked under her fingers. “Just get out of here,” she said again and closed her eyes and he was relieved that the tears at least had stopped. All that was left was the softest saddest chuffing sound. An innocent girl consumed by hurt.

When he watched too long, she pounded one of those fists on the mattress. “I said get out!”

He slunk away, rose to stand, didn’t know what to say anymore. He lingered, trying to formulate that perfect phrase, that *You had me at hello*, something that would save the day. But there was nothing. This poor sobbing figure was all his responsibility. He’d done this.

He shuffled sideways, turned, went to the bedroom door, paused. Still no phrase that could save them would come. He rested his forehead on the door.

It was awful, but at least it was done. And so much could have been saved if you’d just been honest in the first place. His first betrayal would’ve been easier to take than having it come back at her twofold. He sniffed, opened the door stepped into the hall, quietly closed the door behind him.



## PART 8

# CHAOS

TUESDAY, JULY 16

THE NIGHT WAS TERRIBLE. The most terrible of his entire life. He wouldn't leave the house, he knew that. So he sat in the hall. Off and on he could hear Libby softly crying in the bedroom. One time he asked her if she was all right and she told him to go away.

When it got later, and it was dark, he knocked on the door and asked her if he could get her anything to eat. She didn't answer for a long moment but then he heard her softly say no. He got pillows from the family room, and a blanket, brought them up and tried to sleep in the hall outside the bedroom door.

He couldn't sleep, sat there in the quiet listening to his stomach rumble, and his heart pound. He was hungry, but he had absolutely no appetite. It was somber and solemn, his mind an empty slate. No thoughts of how he got here. He'd gone over it in his head as it was happening a million times, and deep down he always knew it would end up like this. You couldn't run away from the things you'd done.

The greatest gift that night was his wife's silence. Silence meant peace. As he lay there in the dark, sometimes dozing but mostly awake, he heard no more crying, no more sobbing, no more sniffing. For that, he was forever grateful. The sounds of her sorrow had killed him. But he deserved it, and Libby deserved relief. He would profess to her his undying servitude and despite the bad he'd done, he knew somehow that he would be forgiven. It would take a lot of groveling, a lot of supplication, but he was prepared for the job, and eager to do it.

Sometime before dawn, he'd fallen completely asleep, because when he came to, he was groggy and slumber-worn. He rolled around on the floor

trying to remember where he was, feeling the pain brought by sleeping on a thin carpet over hardwood. He kicked off the blanket, lay there staring at the hallway ceiling, his bedroom doorknob looming above his head. He reached up, quietly checked it. It was still locked.

A strange calm fell over him. There was nothing more to hide. Then it rolled over; that idea showing its dark underbelly. Yes, there is. What about Neve? What if Lib wants details?

He shrugged and hummed a sound of regret. He would tell her.

Movement in the bedroom had him bolting up, sitting and tugging at clothes, trying to make himself look presentable. Libby was moving around in there, flicking light switches, going into the closet, going into the bathroom. He listened to the melodious tinkling of her urine in the toilet bowl. Listened to her brush her teeth. When the shower clunked then hissed on, he pulled himself up to stand and staggered into his office, threw himself down in his leather swivel chair. He may have drifted again, because when he came to it was the sound of the blow dryer that had woken him. He rubbed at his eyes, leaned forward and rested his forearms on his knees, thinking how he would supplicate.

*Good morning, Libby, how are you, baby? Can we talk? You can tell me anything, call me anything, you can let it all out... I'm here for you, beat on me if you want, I can take it...*

MORE FLICKING lights and the closet door banging had him rising from his office chair. Libby came out of the bedroom and he met her in their narrow hallway. She was turning around when she saw him and she flinched and jumped.

“Sorry,” he said, and she put both hands up to keep space between them. Face turned away, she tried to get around him and it broke his heart. “Libby, don’t...”

“Don’t stop me, don’t touch me...”

She wasn’t dressed for work, she was in jeans and a sweatshirt, wearing her Reebok granny sneakers that chirped on the hardwood as she stepped off the carpet runner to get close to the wall where he couldn’t put a hand on her.

But he did anyway, moving to pinch his thumb to knuckle over top of her sweatshirt hood trying to get her to come back.

“Don’t,” she hissed, pushing an elbow toward him and walking further down the hall. He let the hood slip from between his fingers and watched her go. When she got to the top of the stairs, he hustled to follow her.

“Where are you going?”

“Leave me alone,” she muttered, her heels squeaking down the stairs.

“Libby, wait...”

He thundered behind her. They made it to the landing at the same time and he gripped her arm lightly. She pulled away but not completely out of his grasp.

“Where are you going to go?”

Her face turned to him but she still couldn't look him in the eye; she was looking at where the feet of the bureau in the hall touched down against the floor. She said, "I'm going to go to my parents."

"Don't, Libby, don't... stay with me..."

"Just let me go, Ben, I'm going to the GO station."

"Don't go, Libby..."

"You can't stop me, Ben, just let me go..."

"Libby, stay and talk to me... I love you so much..."

Lib's lips tightened, but she still would look at them. She said, "I love you, too, Ben, I do."

"You do?"

"You need to let me go to the train station. Just let me go..." Now she wheeled around, marched to the front door.

He followed close behind, said, "Let me get my shoes, I'll drive you..."

"I'm walking, just let me be alone, dammit, Ben."

He paused in the doorway of their home, holding the aluminum door open and watching her hair snap left and right as her sneakers bounded down their two steps and she marched their short driveway and out to Sarah Ashbridge. She turned on her heel and headed toward the end of the street.

"Fuck me," he said. Now her parents were going to know. Now her whole family would know. How did she think they were going to repair the relationship when she brought all these other people in?

*Think of the girls you brought in, buddy.*

He growled, rubbed at his forehead. None of it was worth it. Fucking Chelsea Cunningham was not worth the tiniest iota of his wife's pain. "I'm such an asshole," he said, stumbled to the kitchen, ground fresh coffee and filled water into the percolator. It was boiling as he swiped up his phone and opened it. Dialing, he looked at the time, figured Chelsea would be awake.

On the third ring, she picked up. "What's up, Benji?"

He gritted his teeth. "I told her."

"What did you tell her?"

"I told her everything."

"No way," Chelsea said, and he could hear breathy disbelief in her voice.

"I did. She was lying to me, but I know I'm the bigger liar. I can't be mad at her for doing the same thing I do."

“That’s what got us here,” she said, dishes clinking like she was loading the dishwasher.

“I couldn’t take it anymore. The guilt was crazy.”

“How did she take it?”

“She’s gone. She left me.”

“Aw, shit, Ben. You think she’ll be back?”

“I think so. I just don’t like to think of her hurting.”

“Well, you probably shouldn’t let me suck your dick.”

“Yeah, I shouldn’t have done that. Finn’s been hanging out with her before you and I ever hooked up so you can stop the innocent game. You had a plan.”

“Lib didn’t sleep with Finn, you know that, right?”

“I know it now. I slept in the hallway last night, a lot of things became obvious.”

“Did you believe me?”

“Your timing couldn’t have been better.”

“That makes me so happy, Ben.”

“Consider it a birthday gift,” he said, wondering on his banter with the girl who’d purposely stuck a stick in the spinning spokes of his marriage. Why wouldn’t he explode with rage on her? She was just so fucking beautiful he was still afraid of her.

“Thank you so much, Ben.” Chelsea was moving around the kitchen now, he could hear the fridge door open. She said, “So what happens now?”

“Well, you and I will never talk again. That’s for the best. And, shit, Libby’s going to want to move. So I imagine I see couple’s therapy in my future, a lot of crying, a lot of apologizing—which I’m not ashamed to do—a lot of nurturing and probably some more nights sleeping on the couch, but I know I’ll do whatever it takes...”

“Hold on,” she said.

He could hear Chelsea’s footsteps in the hallway now, knew she had bare feet. He heard her front door open. There were mumbled voices, one of them raised higher, it sounded like a woman. There was a scuffle of some kind, feet banging on the floor, a sneaker’s squeak, a bright and loud smack. It sounded like the phone scattered out of Chelsea’s hand and across the floor. He bolted forward, listening...

Now he could hear two women shrieking and growling, sounds of a struggle. A bright cry of a woman’s pain. More smacking, loud and wet,

fists on face. He heard screeching. *Bitch, Whore, Hate You...* and when it hit him, he couldn't believe it took him so long. It was Libby.

He dropped his phone, ran to the stove, slapped off the burner, ran to the hall, grabbing his keys where they subsequently fell out of his hand and clattered against the door. He lunged forward stooping to pick them up in a hurry, banged his head on the glass, making the doorframe rattle. Jumped up, fell against the door, his mind racing a million miles an hour. He darted back into the kitchen, checked the oven again, making sure the house wasn't going to burn down while he was out saving his wife.

He was in his truck before he knew it, not even closing the house door behind him, screeching backwards out of his driveway then roaring down Sarah Ashbridge, rolling through the stop sign, yanking hard, pulling a hairpin that swung the truck's back end out, the rear wheel drive's screeching behind him and sending up puffs of smoke.

The truck's motor growled as he raced down Chelsea's Street...



## AFTERWORD

Sign up for my newsletter on my website to get the latest info, sneak peeks at upcoming stories, and even a free story or two down the road!

Visit my website!

[ktmorrison.com](http://ktmorrison.com)

[hotwifebooks.com](http://hotwifebooks.com)